U.S. DEPARTMENT OF LABOR

Employment Workshop (DOL EW)

PARTICIPANT GUIDE

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Visit dol.gov/DOLEWmaterials to download the Resource Guide and a digital fillable PDF of this Participant Guide.

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All websites, URLs and screen shots within this guide are active at the date of publication. However, URLs and web content are subject to change without notice, and users of this guide are advised to follow links to confirm information is of the latest version.

Version 6.0

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DEPARTMENT OF LABOR EMPLOYMENT WORKSHOP (DOLEW) MATERIALS

Downloadable resources associated with this workshop include:

1. Employment Workshop (EW) Participant Guide (PG)
2. EW Presentation
3. Veterans' Employment and Training Service (VETS) Resource Guide (VRG)

All EW resources are available in digital format at DOLEWmaterials (dol.gov/DOLEWmaterials).

Throughout this training, you will complete activities in your Participant Guide (PG). Each activity reinforces the information presented and helps you apply what you learn. The PG also includes resources, activities, and links that support your transition to civilian employment.

You are highly encouraged to download your copy of the interactive PDF version of the PG.

- **Save the file first** to enable fillable fields for typing and saving your responses.
- **Keep the PG open** during the workshop to make notes and complete activities.

The interactive PG offers these benefits:

- **Convenience**: Type directly into the guide instead of writing by hand.
- **Organization**: Keep all your notes and activity responses in one digital document.
- **Resources at your fingertips**: Access hyperlinks, activities, and reference materials quickly.

In addition, the electronic **VETS Resource Guide** gathers all resources used in this workshop and all DOL TAP workshops. The VRG contains additional online tools, websites, organizations, and follow-on services useful before, during, and after your transition.

Watch for additional help, fun facts, and resources throughout your Participant Guide.

Quick Tip

Did You Know?

More Information

1 Introduction

SECTION 1: INTRODUCTION

WELCOME

Thank you for your service and congratulations on embarking on the next phase of your career!

Welcome to the Transition Assistance Program (TAP) Department of Labor Employment Workshop (DOLEW). This two-day workshop is provided by the Department of Labor (DOL) for service members and their spouses, and is designed to help you further launch your civilian career.

You have already completed the one-day DOL TAP workshop called Employment Fundamentals of Career Transition (EFCT). In that course, you were presented with dozens of activities a candidate completes in a typical job search. The EFCT workshop also provided three fundamentals that you can use to search and apply for jobs more effectively.

This two-day TAP track, the Employment Workshop, builds on the same job search activities and fundamentals, and presents practical exercises to practice your skills. This course covers emerging best practices in career employment, including in-depth training to build effective resumes, navigate the federal hiring process, network using technology, develop interview skills, and evaluate job offers.

Generally speaking, the EFCT presented what activities comprise a typical job search and why the Three Fundamentals are important. This workshop will show you how to use the tools and techniques in more detail. This is your workshop for employment.

WORKSHOP GOALS

This workshop will continue with topics from previous TAP workshops by focusing on how to:

- write a master or targeted resume.
- use resources to assist you with the federal employment process.
- expand your network, including using social media.
- develop interview strategies and practice answering questions.
- conduct salary negotiations and respond to job offers.

Activities and examples featured throughout this workshop will give you techniques and resources as you continue to implement your plan.

Along the way, we will emphasize some especially helpful Pro Tips. You can think of these like your power tools in your toolbox. They make the task of job searching easier, faster, and more impactful.

FOCUS OF EACH WORKSHOP SECTION

Introduction

- Review of EFCT and the fundamentals of a job search

Resume Writing

- Resume styles review
- Differences in master and targeted resumes
- Drafting your resume
- Writing your cover letter
- Submitting your resume
- Gathering your references

Federal Hiring

- Federal employment system introduction
- Special hiring authorities
- Federal job search
- Federal job announcement
- Federal resumes
- Using USAJOBS to apply for and manage federal job applications

Networking

- Networking and its value in a job search
- Methods to create and expand your network
- Creating a LinkedIn profile
- LinkedIn for networking

Interviewing Skills

- Before the interview
- During the interview
- After the interview
- Answering interview questions

Salary Negotiations

- Salary negotiation preparation
- Salary research
- Negotiating job offers
- Communicating your decision



ACTIVITY 1.1: INTRODUCTIONS

Your facilitator will lead class introductions so you can begin, or continue, adding to your network. What are your expectations for a course titled DOL Employment Workshop?

REVIEW EMPLOYMENT FUNDAMENTALS

Some class participants completed the EFCT workshop yesterday, while others may have completed it several weeks ago. We will review the main themes in the EFCT so that everyone has a similar knowledge base for the DOLEW.

The EFCT course introduced three fundamental concepts that will help you start your job search with confidence and set yourself apart from the competition. Not every job seeker knows or utilizes these fundamentals.

To understand the fundamental concept of developing your brand, you learned to first recognize that the job search is an activity of marketing or sales. You are offering your knowledge, skills, and abilities as an employee to a company or a hiring manager. Therefore, you want to show them what sets you apart from others and how you add value to their organization.

To develop your personal brand, you started with where you currently are and assessed your skills. You also conducted research to determine how your skills fit in the labor market. These actions helped you create your marketing message to make a memorable impression on the employer.

You learned to put yourself in the employer's role as you consider where you will look for an open job, what you will write on your resume, and how you present yourself in an interview. You picked up special Pro Tips while thinking like an employer, such as "Using STAR to Standout," "Connecting with Your Network," and "Analyzing a Job Posting." When you apply this employer-focused mindset to every aspect of your search, you have an edge over your competition.

You have been given access to resources, information, and support that many job seekers do not have access to. This workshop, as well as the EFCT, provides numerous resources throughout, and many more are gathered in the electronic VETS Resource Guide. Resources presented are a mixture of online tools, websites, organizations, and follow-on services. Pay special attention to the Pro Tips, Quick Tips, More Information, and Did You Know icons throughout this guide, which highlight useful information and additional resources.

Following your EFCT course, you gained a good understanding of the job search process. And, more importantly, you learned what tools to use to approach your job search to set yourself apart from your competition for the best fit job. This course, the DOLEW, will provide practical guidance on how to use those tools and how you put the fundamentals in action.

2 Resume Writing

SECTION 2: RESUME WRITING

SECTION OBJECTIVES

- Understand the different types and styles of resumes.
- Explain Applicant Tracking Systems.
- Create or update your resume.
- Understand how to review and submit your resume.
- Complete your application materials with a cover letter and references.

This section is focused on creating your first resume or updating your existing resume for a career change. The topics covered in this section are:



- **Resume Basics** explains what a resume is and how it is used, the difference between a master and a targeted resume, and includes an explanation of three common styles of resume.



- **Preparing to Write** explains Applicant Tracking Systems and why you analyze a job posting to target your resume.



- **Drafting Your Resume** focuses on how to effectively represent your skills and qualifications.



- **Reviewing Your Resume** provides resources and ways to present your best work.



- **Writing Your Cover Letter** focuses on the parts of a cover letter and how to articulate your interest in the job.



- **Submitting Your Resume** covers how to deliver your resume.



- **Gathering Your References** focuses on collecting contact information of supervisors and colleagues who can attest to your skills and qualifications.

RESUME BASICS

Most jobs you apply for require a resume. A resume is a document that quickly shows an employer your relevant skills and experience. It is often the first line of contact that you have with a potential employer. An employer will form their first impression of you based on your resume.

The number one purpose of a resume is to effectively summarize and highlight your qualifications in a way that will make the employer want to contact you for an interview.

Why is writing a resume important if you are filling out applications?

A resume highlights and outlines your work history and allows you to add measurable accomplishments. Having a resume allows you to quickly identify knowledge, skills, and abilities (KSAs) as well as your education. You can often take your most attractive KSAs from your resume and target them in an application.

Before you begin drafting your targeted resume, review the statements in the quiz and decide if they are true or false.

Answers will be discussed in class and are available in Appendix A.

ACTIVITY 2.1: RESUME QUIZ

Read each statement and decide whether it is true or false.

1. The number one rule for writing a good resume is “more is better.”	TRUE	FALSE
2. Regardless of your age, your resume work history should list all jobs going back to high school.	TRUE	FALSE
3. Your targeted resume should not be longer than two pages.	TRUE	FALSE
4. The best resume is flexible enough to cover various job options within your professional field of interest.	TRUE	FALSE
5. A good resume paints a clear picture of you, including your height, weight, race, age, marital status, and number of children.	TRUE	FALSE
6. Employers like to see that you are interested in things other than just your job, so include volunteer work, continued education, and association involvements.	TRUE	FALSE
7. All resumes should contain the complete names, addresses, and telephone numbers of your references.	TRUE	FALSE
8. To help your resume stand out, you should make it as unusual as possible by printing it on brightly colored paper or including a picture of yourself.	TRUE	FALSE
9. A well-written resume is sufficient to get you the job you want.	TRUE	FALSE
10. It is always better to spend money getting a professional resume writing service to write your resume for you as opposed to doing it yourself.	TRUE	FALSE

RESUME TYPES

As discussed in EFCT, there are two types of resumes: Master Resume and Targeted Resume.

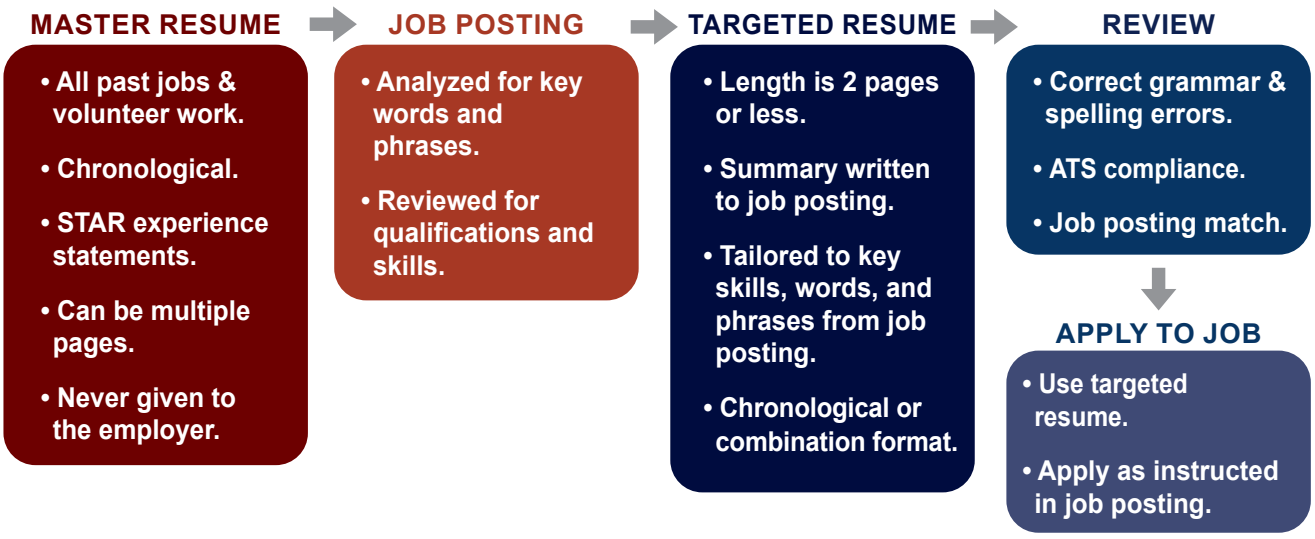
A master resume is a repository of your full employment history and includes what you accomplished in each position. Because this is like a bank containing all your skills and achievements, you do not have limitations on how long or short it needs to be. Your master resume will not be submitted to an employer.

A well-written master resume will:

- make it easier on your memory. It is hard to recreate your work history time and time again. If you have a master resume, you have your chronological work history and skills listed in one place.
- allow you to figure out effective ways to group your experience to best position yourself for a specific employer or opportunity.
- make it easier to create a targeted resume.
- contain all of your historical information, including details you might not need on every targeted resume you send. Keeping this information readily available on a master document saves you time when a specific employer does request it.

Writing a master resume can be time-consuming, but it is worth the effort and time upfront. There is no specific template because not every potential employer will request the same information. You should include the following information on your master resume, plus any relevant information for your career field:

1. Employer's name
2. Employer's city and state
3. Job title
4. The month and year when you started and finished
5. Your duties and responsibilities
6. Your accomplishments - use STAR statements
7. Supervisor's name and contact information
8. Education and certifications, including year obtained



You will not provide your master resume to a potential employer. However, you will use your master resume as a resource to pull content geared and targeted to a particular job opening.

Remember, a master resume is a living document, so you will need to continue to improve and add to it as you gain additional skills.

For a targeted resume, you will take your master resume, remove any information that is not relevant to the job posting, and identify your key skills and accomplishments that match the job announcement. The targeted resume does the work for the employer, making it easy to see how your specific skills and qualifications are a match to the job's requirements.

To write a targeted resume, you must know what position, career field, or company you are targeting, and then spend time analyzing the requirements of the job posting and researching the company. What are the key skills or keywords that this company cares about? The goal of your targeted resume is to show the employer that you match the exact skills and qualifications that they are seeking.



A Targeted Resume

is created from your master resume. Here you will pinpoint the experience and skills that directly match the job you are applying for.

RESUME STYLES

The goal of a targeted resume is to effectively summarize and highlight your qualifications in a way that makes the employer want to reach out and schedule an interview with you.

In this section, you will learn the basic components of a targeted resume and prepare for the resume writing process.

There are three styles you can use to organize the information on your targeted resume: chronological, functional, and combination. In this training, we will focus on the chronological resume style due to its popularity among employers, but you should be familiar with all three styles.

Chronological: Time-based

- This style is most preferred by employers, as it lists the jobs you have held, starting with your most recent position, and then proceeding in reverse chronological order.
- It also describes your experiences and accomplishments in each position.
- This style is compatible with many Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS).

Chronological Resume Example:

ALEX SPENCER
Email | Phone
HEALTHCARE ADMINISTRATION SPECIALIST

U.S. Navy veteran with over 4 years of experience in healthcare business administration. Highly skilled at budgeting, scheduling, and seeking out ways to improve patient care. Experience collecting relevant business intelligence for healthcare and financial services industries and in managing large teams and streamlining workflows. Recipient of multiple awards for outstanding performance, professionalism, and leadership including awards for excellent customer service.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

UNITED STATES NAVY September 20XX – Present

Hospital Corpsman, Norfolk, VA

Command Pay and Personnel Administrator August 20XX – Present

- Assists the manager in providing day-to-day direction for the overall administration, coordination, and evaluation of the organization's human resource function.
- Developed a master tracking database that decreased administrative errors by 10%.
- Conducts periodic pay surveys, schedules and conducts job evaluations, prepares pay budgets, and monitors and schedules individual pay actions.
- Processes routine day-to-day tasks such as preparing personnel status and strength reports, preparing personnel awards, and other administrative support as required.
- Implemented monthly safety training for three administrative departments (32 personnel) to educate and inform the workforce on work safety and accident prevention regulations.
- Ensured 100% training compliance and conducted quarterly safety inspections with a 100% resolution rate.

Customer Relation Representative (CRR) Manager April 20XX - August 20XX

- Supervised 298 Customer Relationship Representatives (CRRs) for the command and divisional clinics, resulting in an increase of patient satisfaction by 3% in one fiscal quarter.
- Coordinated communication between patients, family members, and medical staff to facilitate optimal quality healthcare, obtaining a 100% resolution rate.
- Educated medical staff and patients by developing informational materials.
- Helped improve institutional policies based on collected, analyzed, and reported encounter data.
- Reduced risk and legal liabilities, consistently researching options, and implementing recommendations.

Dermatology Team Leader September 20XX - March 20XX

- Supervised 13 technicians in providing quality care for 11,341 beneficiaries annually.
- Managed and inventoried surgical instruments and supplies valued at $58,000.
- Developed an administrative board that increased members' mission readiness and competition status within the clinic and command.
- Assisted in department-wide training compliance updates resulting in no discrepancies during QC inspections.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Business Administration (BBA) in Economics and Finance
Florida Institute of Technology, Melbourne, Florida

Functional: Skill-based

- Some employers do not prefer this style because it lacks specific employment history and dates.
- Showcases skills. Typically used by job seekers who are changing careers, as it allows them to focus more on transferable skills rather than company names and job titles.
- Allows you to group your skills and accomplishments into one or more categories.

Functional Resume Example:

ALEX SPENCER

Email | Phone

HEALTHCARE ADMINISTRATION SPECIALIST

U.S. Navy veteran with over 4 years of experience in healthcare business administration. Highly skilled at budgeting, scheduling, and seeking out ways to improve patient care. Experience collecting relevant business intelligence for healthcare and financial services industries and in managing large teams and streamlining workflows. Recipient of multiple awards for outstanding performance, professionalism, and leadership including awards for excellent customer service.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- Patient Care Optimization, Healthcare Business Administration
- Team Leadership & Training, Risk & Compliance Management
- Process Improvement, Budgeting & Scheduling
- Customer Relations Management, Personnel & Pay Administration

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE & ACHIEVEMENTS

Human Resources & Personnel Administration

- Assisted leadership in providing day-to-day direction for the overall administration, coordination, and evaluation of human resource functions.
- Developed a master tracking database that decreased administrative errors by 10%.
- Conducted pay surveys, job evaluations, prepared budgets, and monitored pay actions.
- Implemented monthly safety training for three administrative departments (32 personnel), ensuring 100% training compliance.
- Conducted quarterly safety inspections with a 100% resolution rate.

Customer Service & Patient Relations

- Supervised 298 Customer Relationship Representatives (CRRs) across multiple clinics, resulting in a 3% increase in patient satisfaction in one fiscal quarter.
- Coordinated communication between patients, families, and medical staff to facilitate optimal quality healthcare with a 100% resolution rate.
- Educated staff and patients by developing informational materials.
- Improved institutional policies through data collection, analysis, and reporting.
- Reduced risk and legal liabilities by researching and implementing best practices.

Healthcare Team Leadership

- Supervised 13 technicians providing care for 11,341 beneficiaries annually.
- Established work schedules and assigned responsibilities to meet coverage demands.
- Managed and inventoried surgical instruments and supplies valued at $58,000.
- Developed an administrative board that increased members' mission readiness and competition status.
- Assisted with training compliance updates, ensuring no discrepancies during inspections.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Business Administration (BBA) in Economics and Finance
Florida Institute of Technology, Melbourne, Florida

Combination: Elements of both time and skill

- Good compromise between chronological and functional formats.
- Job seekers can show skills, non-work-related experiences and work history.

Combination Resume Example:

ALEX SPENCER

Email | Phone

HEALTHCARE ADMINISTRATION SPECIALIST

U.S. Navy veteran with over 4 years of experience in healthcare business administration. Highly skilled at budgeting, scheduling, and seeking out ways to improve patient care. Experience collecting relevant business intelligence for healthcare and financial services industries and in managing large teams and streamlining workflows. Recipient of multiple awards for outstanding performance, professionalism, and leadership including awards for excellent customer service.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Leadership & Team Management

- Supervised 298 Customer Relationship Representatives (CRRs) for the command and divisional clinics, resulting in an increase in patient satisfaction by 3% in one fiscal quarter.
- Supervised 13 technicians in providing quality care for 11,341 beneficiaries annually.
- Met coverage demands by establishing work schedules and assigning specific jobs.
- Developed an administrative board which increased members' mission readiness and competition status within the clinic and command.

Process Improvement & Administration

- Assists the manager in providing day-to-day directions for the overall administration, coordination, and evaluation of the organization's human resource function.
- Developed a master tracking database that decreased administrative errors by 10%.
- Conducts periodic pay surveys, schedules and conducts job evaluations, prepares pay budgets, and monitors and schedules individual pay actions.
- Processes routine day-to-day tasks such as preparing personnel status and strength reports, preparing personnel awards, and other administrative support as required.
- Helped improve institutional policies based on collected, analyzed, and reported encounter data.
- Reduced risk and legal liabilities, consistently researching options, and implementing recommendations.

Training, Compliance & Safety

- Implemented monthly safety training for three administrative departments (32 personnel) to educate and inform the workforce on work safety and accident prevention regulations.
- Ensured 100% training compliance and conducted quarterly safety inspections with a 100% resolution rate.

- Coordinated communication between patients, family members, and medical staff to facilitate optimal quality healthcare, obtaining a 100% resolution rate.
- Educated medical staff and patients by developing informational materials.
- Managed and inventoried surgical instruments and supplies valued at $58,000.
- Assisted in department-wide training compliance updates resulting in no discrepancies during QC inspections.

WORK HISTORY

UNITED STATES NAVY- Hospital Corpsman, Norfolk, VA **September 20XX – Present**

- Command Pay and Personnel Administrator August 20XX – Present
- Customer Relation Representative (CRR) Manager April 20XX - August 20XX
- Dermatology Team Leader September 20XX - March 20XX

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Business Administration (BBA) in Economics and Finance
Florida Institute of Technology, Melbourne, Florida

Now that we've covered the different styles of resumes, let's focus on how to get them seen by employers. We'll start by discussing the Applicant Tracking System (ATS) and then learn how to analyze a job posting to find the keywords that will help your resume increase its chances of being selected.

PREPARING TO WRITE YOUR RESUME

UNDERSTANDING THE APPLICANT TRACKING SYSTEM (ATS)

Many employers use a streamlined hiring software called the ATS. A key feature of this software automatically tracks, collects, sorts, and identifies resumes that meet the required qualifications. An ATS can use different algorithms and even varying degrees of artificial intelligence (AI) to sort large numbers of applications and speed-up the hiring process. It is a searchable system for the hiring organization. An ATS not only identifies qualified candidates, but it is also used for posting job listings to multiple job boards, determining where applicants located the job listing, and marketing. Other features include scheduling interviews, sending emails to candidates, and alerting company employees such as the hiring manager and recruiter.



Quick Tip

Be aware that some ATS can now identify AI generated resumes. Always be sure to make it your own.

An ATS compiles resumes submitted by applicants. The employer provides the job requirements and keywords to be used for accurately identifying the most qualified candidates. When the system analyzes a resume and establishes that it meets the predetermined requirements, the system allows the candidate to progress forward in the hiring process. If an application contains minimal keywords, it may not be selected to move on to the hiring authorities. Rather than sifting through hundreds of resumes, the system allows recruiters more time to evaluate the best applicants.

Unfortunately, as useful as the system can be to employers, there are potential pitfalls in the process. ATS scans may eliminate people who are qualified but who have not included the keywords on their resume that an ATS has been programmed to identify. The system could also inadvertently disregard a qualified candidate due to differences in accepted formatting. The applicant may never be selected and have no awareness that the formatting was the deciding factor in not getting through the system. There may also be a difference in the words used on an application that may be similar, but not the same, as the keywords on the job posting.

Use these tips to improve your resume's chances with an ATS scan:

1. Add keywords and phrases that appear in the job description or job announcement in your achievement statements. For example, if the job requires someone with experience in HTML and CSS, then you will need to create an achievement statement specifically stating your use of HTML and CSS.
2. Use an acceptable file format. When attaching or uploading documents, use the format requested in the application (e.g., PDF or MS Word).
3. Avoid uploading charts or images unless otherwise instructed. Most automated screen technologies cannot index non-text files.
4. Use both the long-form and acronym versions of keywords (e.g., "Master of Business Administration (MBA)" or "Search Engine Optimization (SEO)" for maximum searchability.
5. Use a chronological or combination resume format. Avoid the functional resume format because it doesn't have dates and can confuse the ATS.
6. Avoid tables and columns throughout your resume. Never break your whole resume into columns or tables, as they often cause errors.
7. Align the keywords in your skills section with the language used in your achievement statements. Some ATS do not pick up the skills section.

8 Do not use the headers or footers function for important information as it may not get picked up by the ATS or may cause errors. You can use the header for noting the second page of your resume.

ANALYZING A JOB POSTING

Analyzing the job posting is a critical step in your job search. Recall that job postings provide insights into the skills, experience, and other selection criteria that an employer considers most important for a specific job vacancy. Here are some tips for maximizing the information you can gain from job postings:

- Read the entire job posting. Skimming the posting may cause you to miss pertinent information, such as type of position (full-time or part-time), location, or travel expectations.
- Print out the job posting and highlight keywords in the qualifications, skills, and experience sections.
- Verify you meet the minimum requirements when sending a resume in response to a job posting. If the job posting says certification, license, degree, experience, etc. required, you might be wasting your time if you do not have those qualifications.

Recall from EFCT:

- The inclusion of the word “preferred” (such as “degree preferred” or “two years of experience preferred”) means you can and should still apply even without that specific qualification, provided you meet the other mandatory requirements.
- Apply directly through the company website rather than through the job board if you locate a job posting on a job board that interests you. Many company websites will have you create an account, allowing you to track your application progress.
- Be wary of job postings that ask you to pay for training or purchase kits or training materials as a condition of employment.

Quick Tip

The best way to increase your chances of being selected to move forward in the hiring process is to ensure you are analyzing and using the job posting to target your resume.

PRO TIP:

ANALYZE JOB POSTINGS

Looking closely at a job posting will help you think like an employer and create an effective targeted resume.

SAMPLE JOB DESCRIPTION

Review the *Director, Human Resources & Administrative Services* job description below and observe what keywords might be included as achievement statements in a resume. Selecting keywords can be subjective. However, the goal is to select words that you believe stand out and can be connected to your own achievements.

Redstone Association seeks a dynamic and selfless leader to direct the overall planning, coordination, and direction of the Association's Human Resources program, policies and practices including administrative support operations for an employment population of 150 year-round employees and 250 seasonal employees. Work is performed under the general direction of the Chief Executive Officer.

Scope of Work:

Directly supervises 10 employees. Responsibilities include interviewing, participating in the hiring process, and training employees; planning, assigning, and directing work; appraising performance; rewarding and disciplining employees; addressing complaints and resolving problems.

Essential Duties and Responsibilities:

- Administers and supervises the activities of the department, including benefit and compensation program administration, talent acquisition for seasonal staff and full-time year-round openings, employee relations, performance management and employee/organizational development and training.
- Monitors current regulatory environment and best practices to ensure compliance with state and federal laws.
- Prepares reports and analyzes statistical information related to turnover, recruitment costs, and benefit plan participation; assists with special assignments as requested, including developing and implementing programs and presenting technical data to the Board of Directors and members of senior staff.

Minimum Qualifications

- Bachelor's degree in human resources management, business management or related field (Preferred)
- Microsoft Office: 5 years (Preferred)
- Progressive HR: 8 years (Required)
- Supervisory: 2 years (Required)
- Professional in Human Resources or other HR certification (Preferred)

Keywords identified with highlights are also listed on the next page.

As you consider the job requirements and compare them to your qualifications, you will need to list the keywords and phrases identified, as done in the example below.

JOB POSTING ANALYSIS: KEYWORDS & DETAILS EXAMPLE

Keywords & Phrases

- Supervise and resolve problems
- Talent acquisition
- Performance management
- Employee/organizational development and training
- Prepares reports and analyzes statistical information

Job Requirements

- Supervisory Experience: 2 years (required)
- Progressive HR Duties: 8 years (required)
- Education: Bachelor's degree in HR management, business management or related field (preferred)
- Microsoft Office: 5 years (preferred)
- Certification: PHR or other HR certification (preferred)

My Qualifications

- Supervise, Resolve problems, Performance management
- 5 years Supervisory experience
- 7 years Microsoft Office experience

THE JOB POSTING

As you learned in the EFCT workshop, you will create a targeted resume for every new job posting you choose to apply to.

ACTIVITY 2.2: LOCATE A JOB POSTING

You can span your search across several job boards simultaneously to aggregate additional postings, including the National Labor Exchange, using CareerOneStop. (https://www.careeronestop.org/JobSearch/job-search.aspx)

You will need to access the details from the job posting to complete the next exercise. It would be best to copy/paste it into a document you can easily reference later.

ACTIVITY 2.3: IDENTIFY KEY WORDS IN YOUR JOB POSTING

Complete this process on your own with your job posting.

STEP 1: Thoroughly read your job posting, paying close attention to the position requirements, qualifications, and responsibilities.

STEP 2: Review your job posting for keywords and phrases that provide insight into the company's mission, values, and organizational culture.

STEP 3: Use the space below to document the keywords and job requirements from the job posting, as well as your qualifications. Check to see how you meet and exceed the job requirements to target your skills to match the keywords you identified.

After identifying the keywords, phrases, and job requirements in your job posting, you will use this information to target your achievement statements later in this course.

JOB POSTING ANALYSIS: KEYWORDS AND DETAILS

Keywords & Phrases:

Job Requirements:

My Qualifications:



PRO TIP:

KNOW YOUR MARKETABLE SKILLS

Knowing what job skills you have, and which of those skills employers are looking for, greatly enhances what you offer as a job applicant.

SCANNING A RESUME

Employers often spend fewer than 30 seconds looking at your resume on the first review. To pass the initial screening, you should ensure that your resume format is visually appealing and easy for an employer to quickly scan.

In this activity, you will play the role of the hiring manager who is looking for an Emergency Medical Technician. As the hiring manager, you received two resumes for the position. Think about the important components of the job description and what you will look for in a candidate.

Follow your facilitator's direction as you read the following sample job description and review the job requirements.



ACTIVITY 2.4: RESUME QUICK SCAN

SAMPLE JOB DESCRIPTION

About Us

Great Lakes West Hospital is seeking an Emergency Medical Technician (EMT). All of our units are MICU-ready, equipped with state-of-the-art diagnostic tools and highly trained medics. Hiring process includes but is not limited to drug screenings, background checks, continuing education courses, and more.

Things You Will Do

- Rescue and extricate victims of accidents, sudden illness or entrapment using proper rescue and medical techniques including the administration of medications or treatments.
- Responsible for the care, transport, and treatment of ill/injured patients in both emergency and non-emergency situations.
- Responsible for relaying and receiving information regarding the patient and patient condition.
- Ability to properly care for and maintain the vehicle including, but not limited to stocking the vehicle per hospital standards.
- May be required to drive ambulance to and from referral hospital.
- May be required to obtain consents and authorizations from patients or legal guardians.
- Must have excellent documentation skills for Ambulance Run Reports.

Things You Will Need

- Associate Degree in Emergency Medical Studies. (Preferred)
- Minimum of 1 year ALS Paramedic experience. (Preferred)
- Must have valid Driver's License with no more than 2 moving violations in the last 2 years.
- ACLS; BLS; NREMT certification. (Required)
- Pediatric Advanced Life Support (PALS) or its equivalency(s) to be obtained within initial probationary period.
- Emergency Vehicle Operator Course (EVOC) or its equivalency must be obtained within initial probationary period.

This Is Who You Are:

- A responsive medical professional who is interested in 911 work while demonstrating best practices.
- A person committed to safety and excellent customer service all day, every day.

SHAWN BUTLER

Fort Drum, NY • (555) 789-6543 • Shawn.Butler@somedomain.com • LinkedIn URL

EMERGENCY MEDICAL TECHNICIAN | EMT-P PARAMEDIC

- Seven years of emergency medical technician/paramedic duties working at home station and field
- Two years' experience as Lead Technician supervising a six-person medical team
- Proficiency in Microsoft Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Access, and Outlook)
- Maintained National EMT-P, BLS, ACLS, and PALS
- Fluent in English and German

WORK EXPERIENCE

Emergency Medical Technician-Paramedic **June 2023 - Present**

Medical Center, Fort Drum, NY

- Administer basic and advanced life support to patients on scene, en route to hospital and in-hospital setting in accordance with federal, state, and local laws and standards.
- Taught Emergency Medical Technician refresher courses to over 200 EMTs.
- Assist physicians in the Emergency Department with trauma patients.
- Mentor EMT students with clinical and classwork.
- Manage $85K medical supply account with 100% accountability.
- Assess the nature and extent of injury or illness to establish and prioritize medical procedures.
- Rescue and extricate victims of accidents, sudden illness or entrapment using proper rescue and medical techniques.
- Perform procedures such as injections, immunizations, infection management and EKGs.
- Perform phlebotomy on all age groups from newborn to geriatric.
- Participate in hospital performance improvement activities; improved safety and patient outcomes by 20%.

Emergency Medical Technician **July 2020 - June 2023**

Deployment Site, Undisclosed

- Led 3-member response team, 4.8k clinical visits, 12 Aerovac missions, and over 350 ER runs responding to all dispatches safely, ensuring life-saving techniques were executed.
- Performed lab tests and communicated results with 100% accuracy.
- Operated and maintained care of emergency vehicles to include supply maintenance and infection control.
- Thoroughly documented assessments, physical findings and treatment rendered in pre-hospital setting on patient care report within 24 hours of dispatch.

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

- Bachelor of Science in Emergency Medical Studies, GPA 3.75, University of Missouri, Columbia, MO
- Emergency Medical Technician- Paramedic License EMT-P, 2021
- ACLS and PALS certification, 2021
- Emergency Vehicles Operations Course (EVOC)

SAMPLE JOB DESCRIPTION

About Us

Great Lakes West Hospital is seeking an Emergency Medical Technician (EMT). Each of our units are MICU-ready, equipped with state-of-the-art diagnostic tools and highly trained medics. Hiring process includes but is not limited to drug screenings, background checks, continuing education courses, and more.

Things You Will Do

- Rescue and extricate victims of accidents, sudden illness or entrapment using proper rescue and medical techniques including the administration of medications or treatments.
- Responsible for the care, transport, and treatment of ill/injured patients in both emergency and non-emergency situations.
- Responsible for relaying and receiving information regarding the patient and patient condition.
- Ability to properly care for and maintain the vehicle including, but not limited to stocking the vehicle per hospital standards.
- May be required to drive ambulance to and from referral hospital.
- May be required to obtain consents and authorizations form patient or legal guardians.
- Must have excellent documentation skills for Ambulance Run Reports.

Things You Will Need

- Associates Degree in Emergency Medical Studies (Preferred)
- Minimum of 1 year ALS Paramedic experience (Preferred)
- Must have valid Driver's License with no more than 2 moving violations in the last 2 years
- ACLS; BLS; NREMT certification (Required)
- Pediatric Advanced Life Support (PALS) or its equivalency(s) to be obtained within initial probationary period
- Emergency Vehicle Operator Course (EVOC) or its equivalency must be obtained within initial probationary period

This Is Who You Are:

- A responsive medical professional who is interested in 911 work while demonstrating best practices.
- A person committed to safety and excellent customer service all day, every day.

TAYLOR BURNS

(714) 555-5555 | Taylor.Burns@somedomain.com | LinkedIn URL

Emergency Medical Technician

- Certified EMT and dedicated member of emergency response teams delivering fast, quality care during medical emergencies, accidents, fires, natural disasters, and other crisis scenarios.
- Passionate medical services provider able to remain calm under pressure and react swiftly in urgent and life-threatening situations.
- Demonstrated success with extensive knowledge of medical technology. Highly experienced with most aspects of medical equipment and quick to learn.

SKILLS

ACLS certified
Cool and collected under pressure
EKG expertise
Training New EMTs
Adept at multiple revival techniques
Wound care expert
Experienced in multiple splinting techniques
Extensive human anatomy knowledge
Intubations and infusions
Ambulatory transport
Rescue and medical equipment
Patient documentation

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

ABC Ambulance Company — Sacramento, CA
Emergency Medical Technician, 2019 to Present

Recruited and hired as full-time EMT for ambulance company. Work collaboratively with the emergency services personnel in responding to 911 dispatched calls to provide pre-hospital urgent care, life support, and patient transport.

- Leverage comprehensive knowledge of emergency medicine to assess, treat, stabilize, and transport seriously ill or injured patients to area hospitals and trauma centers.
- Provide skillful medical care to revive and stabilize patients suffering from traumatic injuries, cardiac arrest, strokes, seizures, drug overdose, hypothermia, and other serious conditions.
- Foster a teamwork environment conducive to positive communication with all team members. Lead a 3-man team ensuring cohesiveness and collaborative patient care.
- Served on taskforce that researched, selected, and installed GPS navigation system providing ambulance drivers with real-time traffic and road conditions. New technology accelerated emergency response time by 25% during rush hours.
- Maintain thorough familiarity with treatment protocols, response requirements, and quality assurance procedures in a system in which assigned.

- Comply with all state and company regulations for operation of ambulance in accordance with policy and safe practice.
- Document patient information obtained from interviews – demonstrate high standards of performance, including teamwork, communication, and compassion.
- Ensure that ambulance remains in a state of readiness, in terms of mechanical reliability, medical supply and equipment, cleanliness, and appearance standards.
- Document all aspects of patient treatment and conditions on run reports.
- Calm and reassure patients and family members, enabling accurate gathering of crucial information (i.e., allergies, medications, pain level) to aid in treatment.
- Manage care in-field and in-transit, including performing standard testing and administering necessary medication within scope of practice.

Finley Health — Richmond, VA
Emergency Medical Technician, 2016 to 2019

Emergency Medical Technician- selected to work as EMT in the field and in the Emergency Room. Provided timely and accurate care and interventions to patients varying from noncritical to critical status while remaining calm and often in charge of other first responders and medical technicians.

- Promoted team effort when working with dispatch center, external public safety agencies, and health care providers.
- Provided direct patient care, including stabilizing patients and determining course of action based on triage.
- Successfully executed the extrication of injured motor vehicle accident patient. Stabilized patient with C-spine and safely released patient from vehicle using the Jaws of Life.
- Provided advanced airway interventions ranging from endotracheal intubation to supraglottic airway placement.
- Assumed responsibility for safe patient transport from point of pick up to delivery of patient to the receiving department or discharge.
- Observed and reported pertinent patient and family information to clinical site personnel to promote patient safety.
- Transferred patients to and from cart/bed/wheelchair using correct and safe equipment and techniques.

EDUCATION AND CERTIFICATIONS

- Bachelor of Science in Emergency Medicine (with Honors)
  University of California, Davis — Davis, CA

MEDICAL CERTIFICATIONS

- Advanced Life Support (ALS)
- Nationally Registered EMT
- Advanced Cardiac Life Support (ACLS)
- Emergency Vehicle Driver's License

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Professional Development:

- Complete ongoing training in the areas of airway management and cardiac life support.

Affiliations:

- Nationally Registered Medics of Southern CA

Computer Skills:

- AHLTA Medical Management
- MS Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Access, Outlook)

In this exercise, you may have noticed how difficult it can be to properly scan an entire resume in a short, limited time. Although Taylor Burns' resume had more information, it was too long to get through in a quick scan. Additionally, you may have noticed that Shawn Butler's resume was more targeted and met more of the requests noted in the job description. Keep these thoughts in mind when creating your targeted resume.

DRAFTING YOUR RESUME

There are many resume formats and templates, so find one that works best for you.

The commonly included sections of a targeted resume are:

- Contact Information
- Headline or Title (Optional)
- Summary of Qualifications
- Work Experience/Accomplishments
- Education/Training

RESUME FORMAT

Keep your targeted resume formatting professional and simple using the following guidelines:

- Length: One to two pages (if two pages, add your name to the second page)
- Alignment: Left-aligned
- White space: Clear margin, one inch all around is recommended
- Styles: Use bold, italics, and underlines sparingly
- Font: Arial, Calibri, Cambria, Franklin Gothic, Garamond, Helvetica, Times New Roman, or Verdana
- Font size: Optimal size is 10 to 12-point font. Section titles and headers can be 14 to 16-point.
- Review: Proofread and spell check
- You will notice that some resume samples have bullet statements with the second and subsequent lines are flush with the first letter of the first line, and some have the second and subsequent lines slightly indented to the right. It is a personal choice on which format you prefer to use.

WHAT STYLE OF RESUME SHOULD YOU USE?

A chronological resume format suits people who have an extensive work history that is in the same line of work as the job for which they are applying. However, it does not work well for career changers or people who have been out of the workforce for some time. If you have a lot of work experience in different industries or significant gaps in employment, you should opt for a functional or combination resume.

A functional resume is a good option if you have little relevant work experience, gaps in your employment history, or are looking for a job in a creative industry where your portfolio matters more than your resume.

Combination resumes were designed for job seekers who already have relevant work experience or are looking to jump into a new industry. If you're applying for a position that requires a lot of technical skills and expertise, using a combination format is the best way to showcase these abilities to the hiring manager. If you had an impressive set of accomplishments and job duties in previous positions and want to highlight the skills you've developed over the years this style is perfect to help you succeed in a career path.

Before you begin writing, decide whether you will be working on your master resume or your targeted resume.

If you are working on your master resume, it is best to use the chronological style as it is straight-forward and can easily be converted to another style. You will also need to gather your source documents to assist you, such as any prior job and military evaluations, military records, Verification of Military Experience and Training (VMET), Joint Service Transcript (JST), personal awards, NCOERs, FITREPs, and school transcripts.

If you are ready to work on your targeted resume, first decide what style you wish to use: chronological, functional, or combination. Then you will need a job posting to target your resume. If you do not have a job posting, you can use the job announcement you located earlier.

Remember, your targeted resume will introduce you to a potential employer. Be sure that your brand is presented well in your resume and that it makes an excellent first impression. Misspellings, inconsistent use of font and type size, and misaligned margins can all indicate a lack of attention to detail. In the eyes of the employer, a sloppy resume equates to sloppy work performance.

Before we get started, take a look at the following resume templates you could consider using.

RESUME TEMPLATES

1-PAGE CHRONOLOGICAL RESUME TEMPLATE EXAMPLE

FIRST NAME LAST NAME

Email | Phone | LinkedIn URL | Location (Optional)

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY or HEADLINE/TITLE

Introduction sentence. Include length of employment with what organization doing what. Next, mention your hard skills. Convey your proficiency, experience, and knowledge for each skill. Add two to three soft skills that would fit well. End with other information relevant to the position, such as clearances, foreign languages, travel availability, etc.

SKILLS

- **Skill category**: Skill 1, Skill 2, Skill 3
- **Skill category**: Skill 1, Skill 2, Skill 3
- **Skill category**: Skill 1, Skill 2, Skill 3

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Position Title 1 **Position Start Date – End Date**

Company A's Name, City, State

Job description

Key achievement 1. Use STAR statement.

Key achievement 2. Use STAR statement.

Key achievement 3. Use STAR statement.

Position Title 2 **Position Start Date – End Date**

Company B's Name, City, State

Job description

Key achievement 1. Use STAR statement.

Key achievement 2. Use STAR statement.

Key achievement 3. Use STAR statement.

EDUCATION

College or University, Location

Highest Level Degree

Major(s), Minor(s), GPA (Only include GPA if above 3.5)

2-PAGE COMBINATION RESUME TEMPLATE EXAMPLE

FIRST NAME LAST NAME

Email | Phone | LinkedIn URL | Location (Optional)

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY or HEADLINE/TITLE

Introduction sentence. Include length of employment with what organization doing what. Next, mention your hard skills. Convey your proficiency, experience, and knowledge for each skill. Add two to three soft skills that would fit well. End with other information relevant to the position, such as clearances, foreign languages, travel availability, etc.

SKILLS

- **Skill category**: Skill 1, Skill 2, Skill 3
- **Skill category**: Skill 1, Skill 2, Skill 3
- **Skill category**: Skill 1, Skill 2, Skill 3

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE:

Function 1 (such as Leadership and Supervision)

- Key achievement 1. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 2. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 3. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 4. Use STAR statement.

Function 2 (such as Logistics and Distribution)

- Key achievement 1. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 2. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 3. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 4. Use STAR statement.

Function 3 (such as Communication)

- Key achievement 1. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 2. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 3. Use STAR statement.
- Key achievement 4. Use STAR statement.

EMPLOYMENT HISTORY

Company A's Name, City, State **Position Start Date – End Date**

Position Title

Company B's Name, City, State **Position Start Date – End Date**

Position Title

Company C's Name, City, State **Position Start Date – End Date**

Position Title

EDUCATION

College or University, Location

Highest Level Degree

Major(s), Minor(s), GPA (Only include GPA if above 3.5)

College or University, Location: State

Next Level Degree

Major(s), Minor(s), GPA (Only include GPA if above 3.5)

TRAINING

First Certificate Name (Date obtained) **Month Year**

Second Certificate Name (Date obtained) **Month Year**

CONTACT INFORMATION

Your contact information goes at the very top center of your resume and should be up to date.

Including your city and state in your contact information is a personal choice. However, this is no longer required by most employers. If the employer is interested, they will contact the applicant who can explain their location.

There are some things to consider when trying to decide whether to include your location. An advantage of including your location is it could increase your chances of getting an interview because you show that you live a reasonable distance from the company. If a job posting specifies a location as a requirement, you are making it easy for a recruiter to identify your location. If you are relocating, you can put "Relocating to Newport News, VA." A possible disadvantage of including your city and state is it could lead to discrimination and privacy concerns. You can approach this decision on a case-by-case basis.

More Information

Make sure you have a professional email address, and if it is new, you must check it daily or have emails forwarded where you will receive them.

Ensure the email address you list is professional. Also, include the web address for your LinkedIn profile or any relevant professional websites (if applicable). Take time to record an appropriate and professional voicemail message on your listed point of contact phone. It may be cute to have one of your kids record your greeting, but you should refrain from doing so while job hunting.

The following three examples show how contact information can differ.

Contact Information Example 1 in Calibri 12-point font with location:

Taylor Lee Coral Springs, FL - (302) 555-1111 - Taylor.Lee@email.com

Contact Information Example 2 in Franklin Gothic Book 12-point font, without location information:

Taylor Lee (302) 555-1111 - Taylor.Lee@email.com

Contact Information Example 3 in Times New Roman 12-point font, with LinkedIn URL information:

Taylor Lee (302) 555-1111 – Taylor.Lee@email.com – www.linkedin.com/in/taylor-lee

ACTIVITY 2.5: CREATE YOUR CONTACT INFORMATION

Use the space to create the contact information section of your targeted resume.

HEADLINE OR TITLE (OPTIONAL)

Use a headline or title at the start of your resume to target your application and immediately capture the recruiter's attention. A headline creates your first impression for the reader. It allows you to quickly showcase the value you will deliver to a future employer and entice them to continue to read your resume. On a targeted resume, it is the job title of the job you are applying for. This is also an opportunity to "communicate your brand" as discussed in EFCT. You can create your headline by locating keywords from the job posting or simply use the exact job title from the job posting.

Place your headline or title directly above the summary of qualifications, which we will discuss next. A best practice would be to center it on your document under your contact information. You can use symbols such as a vertical bar/pipe, a dash, or a centered bullet to separate words. Here are some examples:

EDUCATOR | TRAINING MANAGER

SECURITY ANALYST – CYBER SECURITY – SOFTWARE DEVELOPMENT

BUDGET ANALYST ● PROJECT MANAGEMENT ● WORKFLOW OPTIMIZATION



More Information

When creating your headline, you can locate the bar/pipe symbol above the ***Enter key*** *on your keyboard. To use the centered bullet, click the Insert tab on your top ribbon, go to the end of the ribbon and click the Symbols button, select More Symbols, change the subset dropdown to Geometric Shapes for a large bullet or General Punctuation for a small bullet. Click on the bullet symbol and select insert. You can just copy and paste in subsequent uses.*

SUMMARY OF QUALIFICATIONS

The best way to catch a reader's attention in the first few seconds of reviewing your resume is to provide a summary of skills and experience that match the qualifications and skills needed for the position.

As presented in the MOC Crosswalk workshop, skills are classified as either hard or soft. Hard skills are technical knowledge or training that you have gained through any life experience, including your career or education. Soft skills are personal habits and traits that shape how you work on your own and with others. As discussed in EFCT, you want to focus on those transferable skills for your targeted resume. Recall that your transferable skills are those skills you have that the employer is looking for based on the job posting.



Did You Know?

The goal of the summary of qualifications is to summarize your skill set and let the reader know you are qualified for the position by highlighting relevant experience, key skills, and accomplishments. This is also a good place to identify your security clearance.

Remember, this section must be targeted to include information relevant to the job posting and the future employer (rather than just a summary of your best skills). Use your company research and job posting to help you identify the preferred and required qualifications so you can create a targeted resume for the position. Use the exact terms in your targeted resume that are listed in the job posting.

Your summary can be a short introductory paragraph, a brief list of skills to showcase your talent, or you can combine the two. The following examples demonstrate three different ways you can write your summary of qualifications.

EXAMPLE 1: BULLETED LIST

Summary of Qualifications for a Project Manager role:

- Project Manager with 10+ years of proven experience overseeing application development, vendor management, and implementation strategies
- Respected leader with excellent communication skills and experience building highly motivated teams focused on achieving project goals
- Diligent Project Manager with a proven record of success working with Microsoft Project Server
- Proficient in Microsoft Office Suite (Excel, Word, PowerPoint) as well as MS Project and Visio.
- Earned Bachelor of Science degree in Project Management

EXAMPLE 2: PARAGRAPH

Summary of Qualifications for a Human Resource role:

Certified Human Resource Manager with over 15 years of proven experience planning, executing, and evaluating complex programs and projects. Accomplished measurable results and improved performance while leading cross-functional teams of 200+ in dynamic, fast-paced environments. A skilled and flexible results-driven leader known for providing top notch support to managers and stakeholders. Possess a comprehensive background in human resource development, onboarding, and manpower management.

EXAMPLE 3: COMBINATION OF PARAGRAPH WITH BULLETED LIST

Statement of Qualifications for a Law Enforcement Professional role:

Law Enforcement Professional with over 15 years of experience providing protective services for over $10 million in assets during state, federal, and global security operations.

Key skills:

- Crisis Management: Emergency Response, Search and Rescue, Post Incident Analysis
- Investigations: Interrogation, Surveillance, Reporting



ACTIVITY 2.6: CREATE YOUR SUMMARY OF QUALIFICATIONS

Use the space below to create the summary of qualifications section of your targeted resume.

EXPERIENCE AND ACHIEVEMENTS

The work experience section provides the details of your professional experience. This is where you need to use company information and keywords that relate directly to the position and/or company.

In this section of your resume:

- List your employment history (employer/organization names, job titles, and start and end dates of the positions). Use the word “Present” or “Current” as the end date if you are still working in that position.



Quick Tip

The employment history dates in a resume can include the month and year, or only the year. But dates should clearly show the required length of experience needed for the position.

- List your achievements and/or results from each job you have held that relate to the position or occupation you are targeting. A common practice is to only go as far back as 10 years.
- Include time, numbers, financial savings, percentages, statistics, and examples to illustrate your achievements with the STAR method.
- Show progress in your current employment history; do this by making your promotions stand out.

WORK HISTORY FORMAT

The experience section provides the hiring manager with a list of the companies you have worked for, dates of employment, and the position titles you held.

FORMAT FOR LISTING YOUR WORK HISTORY

Job Title — Month/Year Start Date – Month/Year End Date

Company, City, State

- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.
- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.
- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.

EXAMPLE:

System Administrator — January 2020 – Present

USAA, Dallas, TX

- Resolve Service Desk tickets for more than 3,000 users across 21 states and abroad, maintaining a 24-hour resolution time.
- Maintain three domains to include updating, troubleshooting, and repair of network connectivity to achieve goal of 95% continuous connectivity.
- Serve as Information Assurance (IA) Manager; annually train over 150 staff on IA protocols to ensure standards are maintained.

HOW TO FORMAT A RESUME FOR MULTIPLE JOBS AT ONE ORGANIZATION

Participants with multiple jobs at one installation (like many service members) may use one of the following formats:

OPTION 1: STACKING

This method is used to draw attention to progressive responsibilities, accomplishments, and dedication to the company. There are a few simple rules to this resume format:

- Include the overall date range at the top.
- List dates for each position next to the title.
- Place job descriptions and bulleted key accomplishments directly below each position.

EXAMPLE STACKING FORMAT

Company Name, City, State — Start Date – End Date

Position 1 — Start Date – End Date

- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.
- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.

Position 2 — Start Date – End Date

- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.
- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.

EXAMPLE

USAA, Dallas, TX — June 2015 – Present

System Administrator — May 2019 – Present

- Resolve Service Desk tickets for more than 3,000 users across 21 states and abroad, maintaining a 24-hour resolution time.
- Maintain three domains to include updating, troubleshooting, and repair of network connectivity to achieve goal of 95% continuous connectivity.

Service Desk Supervisor — June 2015 – May 2019

- Maintained and provided troubleshooting for desktops, laptops, and tablets with Windows 7 and 10 to prevent breaks in service or work productivity.
- Managed life cycle replacement, backup, and disaster recovery for computers, iPads, iPhones, and other portable devices within the organization to ensure no loss of connectivity.
- Proficient in all Microsoft Office products including Office 365, TEAMS, OneDrive, and SharePoint.

OPTION 2: SEPARATE LISTINGS

You can list each position separately on your resume as you would if they were positions at different companies. This approach draws attention to your accomplishment history according to both the position and time frame.

EXAMPLE SEPARATE LISTINGS FORMAT

Company A's Name, City, State — Start Date – End Date

Position Title 1

- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.
- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.

Company A's Name, City, State — Start Date – End Date

Position Title 2

- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.
- List your job skills and achievements for this position. Use STAR statements.

EXAMPLE

USAA, Dallas, TX — May 2023 – Present

System Administrator

- Resolve service desk tickets for more than 3,000 users across 21 states and abroad.
- Maintain three domains to include updating, troubleshooting, and repairing of network connectivity to achieve goal of 95% continuous connectivity.
- Serve as Information Assurance (IA) Manager; annually train over 150 staff on IA protocols to ensure standards are maintained.

USAA, Dallas, TX — June 2019 – May 2023

Service Desk Supervisor

- Maintained and provided troubleshooting for desktops, laptops, and tablets with Windows 7 and 10 to prevent breaks in service or work productivity.
- Managed life cycle replacement, backup, and disaster recovery for computers, iPads, iPhones, and other portable devices within the organization to ensure no loss of connectivity.
- Proficient in all Microsoft Office products including Office 365, MS Teams, OneDrive, and SharePoint.

ACHIEVEMENT STATEMENTS

One of the critical aspects in the resume writing process is integrating results, along with keywords into your achievement statements. The goal is to demonstrate to a potential employer how well you performed the skill, not to simply state what skills you have or were responsible for performing.

You can use your performance reviews, collateral duties, internships, awards, volunteer activities, and training records to identify and explain where and when you executed each skill and how it will contribute to the success of the organization.

As you describe your experience and achievements:

1. Select the skills related to the job you are targeting and highlight your major accomplishments that relate to the job.
2. Use the STAR method as discussed in EFCT.
3. Use civilian terms and avoid acronyms.
4. Begin with an action verb or dynamic adjective. Using action verbs will demonstrate to an employer that you acted and produced results.
5. Avoid using the phrases “skills included” and “responsible for.”
6. Use present tense for current job. STAR statements will be in past tense if including a result of past action.
7. Avoid the use of personal pronouns (I, me, she, he, etc.)

Review the sample achievement statements. The most effective statements are those that are both targeted and results-oriented. Not every statement needs to be a STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result) statement, but the majority should follow the STAR method.

EXAMPLES OF ACHIEVEMENT STATEMENTS

PERSONNEL/HUMAN RESOURCES

- Directly supervised the activities and performance of 17 equipment technicians and 4 equipment managers in 3 separate maintenance facilities; ensured 100% execution of maintenance applications, training missions, and quality control.
- Managed 30 staff sales and recruiting representatives, 26 government sedans, and 120 computer networks, with a regional responsibility of 500 square miles.
- Created “hip-pocket” informal training classes for numerous topics including weapon systems and maintenance, vehicle systems and maintenance, and position improvement; provided instruction to groups ranging from 5–40 participants using manuals and hands-on applications.
- Coordinated and organized over 14 instructional programs with various organizations resulting in being recognized by senior management for obtaining a 100% training proficiency rating in all evaluated areas.

ENGINEER

- Conducted job analysis and provided suggestions for improvement, saving the company five labor-hours each week and $300,000 over a two-year period.
- Directed daily operations for engineering department, including supervision of four administrative personnel; received department award for excellent internal customer service.
- Directed design, installation, and testing of custom software equipment, ensuring exceptional completion of tasks on time and on budget.

MAINTENANCE

- Supervised and trained a team of 35 mechanics in the safe operation of an engine, drive-train, and fuel/electric rebuild shop.
- Conducted maintenance inspections for two Army Attack Helicopter units, overseeing the readiness of 14 Apache helicopters, 35+ wheeled vehicles, and 117 personnel. Implemented process improvements increasing maintenance efficiency by 20% and enhanced unit readiness, contributing to a 95% mission success rate.
- Maneuvered trucks weighing over 70,000 pounds into loading and unloading positions; ensured and solidified proper placement and securement of load.

MEDICAL

- Administered over 1000 inoculations for protection against diseases to include: Covid-19, Anthrax, Polio, and Yellow Fever.
- Supervised and assisted medical missions supporting 10,000+ personnel annually, reducing emergency response times by 30% and ensuring 100% medical coverage during field training exercises and weapon range operations.
- Managed Competency-Based Orientation Folders for JCAHO evaluations, ensuring compliance with accreditation standards. Efforts resulted in 100% inspection rating, demonstrating excellence regulatory adherence.
- Received recognition for converting a cargo vehicle into a field ambulance capable of safely carrying 2-liters, saving the government more than $60,000.

MANAGEMENT

- Carried out repairs and warranty work for 5 housing complexes totaling over 50,000 sq. ft. of living space, ensuring quick and timely correction of over 35 major deficiencies within warranty period, saving more than $70,000.
- Supervised the activities and performance of a 72-person workforce, directly managing 3 senior instructors and 18 equipment managers.
- Supervised and trained 15 technicians and operators to act as one entity positioning equipment to maximize efficiency while minimizing any possibility of harm.
- Assigned work to 4 senior personnel based on priorities, difficulty, requirements of assignments and the capabilities of the employees, set and adjusted short-term goals, prepared schedules for completion of work and evaluated work performance.

ACTION VERBS FOR ACHIEVEMENT STATEMENTS

A

Accelerate
Accomplish
Achieve
Acquire
Adapt
Address
Advance
Advise
Advocate
Analyze
Apply
Appoint
Arbitrate
Architect
Arrange
Ascertain
Assemble
Assess
Assist
Author
Authorize

B

Brief
Budget
Build

C

Calculate
Capture
Catalog
Champion
Chart
Clarify
Classify
Close
Coach
Collaborate
Collect
Command
Communicate
Compare
Compel
Compile
Complete
Compute
Conceive
Conclude
Conduct
Conserve
Consolidate
Construct
Consult
Continue
Contract
Convert
Coordinate
Correct
Counsel
Craft
Create
Critique

D

Decrease
Define
Delegate
Deliver
Demonstrate
Deploy
Design
Detail
Detect
Determine
Develop
Devise
Direct
Discover
Dispense
Display
Distribute
Diversify
Divert
Document
Double
Draft
Drive

E

Earn
Edit
Educate
Effect
Elect
Eliminate
Emphasize
Enact
Encourage
Endure
Energize
Enforce
Engineer
Enhance
Enlist
Ensure
Establish
Estimate
Evaluate
Examine
Exceed
Execute
Exhibit
Expand
Expedite
Experiment
Export

F

Facilitate
Finalize
Finance
Forge
Form
Formalize
Formulate
Found

G

Generate
Govern
Graduate
Guide

H

Halt
Head
Hire
Honor
Hypothesize

I

Identify
Illustrate
Imagine
Implement
Import
Improve
Improvise
Increase
Influence
Inform
Initiate
Innovate
Inspect
Inspire
Install
Institute
Instruct
Integrate
Intensify
Interpret
Interview
Introduce

Invent
Inventory
Investigate

J

Judge
Justify

L

Launch
Lead
Lecture
License
Listen
Locate

M

Maintain
Manage
Manipulate
Manufacture
Map
Market
Mastermind
Measure
Mediate
Mentor
Model
Modify
Monitor
Motivate

N

Navigate
Negotiate
Nominate
Normalize

O

Observe
Obtain
Offer
Officiate
Operate
Orchestrate
Organize
Orient
Originate
Outsource
Overcome
Oversee

P

Participate
Perceive
Perfect
Perform
Persuade
Pilot
Pinpoint
Pioneer
Plan
Position
Predict
Prepare
Prescribe
Present
Preside
Process
Procure
Program
Progress
Project
Promote
Propose
Prospect
Provide
Publicize
Purchase

Q

Qualify
Question

R

Rate
Realign
Rebuild
Recapture
Receive
Recognize
Recommend
Reconcile
Record
Recruit
Redesign
Reduce
Reengineer
Regain
Regulate
Rehabilitate
Reinforce
Rejuvenate
Render
Renegotiate
Reorganize
Report
Reposition
Represent
Research
Resolve
Respond
Restore
Restructure
Retrieve
Review
Revise
Revitalize

S

Satisfy
Schedule
Secure
Select
Separate
Serve
Simplify
Sold
Solidify
Solve
Speak
Specify
Standardize
Stimulate
Streamline
Structure
Succeed
Suggest
Summarize
Supervise
Supply
Support
Surpass
Synthesize
Systematize

T

Tabulate
Target
Teach
Terminate
Test
Thwart
Train
Transcribe
Transfer
Transform
Transition
Translate
Troubleshoot

U

Unify
Unite
Update
Upgrade
Use
Utilize

V

Verbalize
Verify

W

Win
Write

ACTIVITY 2.7: CREATE YOUR ACHIEVEMENT STATEMENTS

Use this time to create some achievement statements for your resume. If you are writing a targeted resume, refer to your job posting to choose keywords. Begin each statement with an **action verb**. Use the action verbs list on the previous pages as assistance. Create your achievement statements in the space below.

TARGETING ACHIEVEMENT STATEMENTS

Now that you have created some achievement statements, recall the keyword example on pages 27 and 28. Use that concept to identify keywords in your personal job posting and transform your achievement statements to be targeted using those keywords. **You will need to follow this process for every job you apply for to ensure you target your resume to the job.**

The examples below were created from the job posting and keywords found on page 27.

EXAMPLE 1: CREATING TARGETED ACHIEVEMENT STATEMENTS

BEFORE including keywords:

- Provided executive-level leadership by integrating innovative practices, policies, and programs while collaborating with executive teams in department growth.

Keywords identified in the job posting:

- HR practices (inserted after “innovative”)
- Performance management (inserted after “HR practices”)
- Senior staff (replaced “executive teams”)
- Resolving problems (replaced “department growth”)

AFTER including keywords from job posting:

- Provided executive-level leadership by integrating innovative HR practices, performance management, policies, and programs while collaborating with senior staff in resolving problems.

EXAMPLE 2: CREATING TARGETED ACHIEVEMENT STATEMENTS

BEFORE including keywords:

- Directed various HR functions for 30K military and civilian personnel including recruitment, retention, strategic planning, data analysis, and organizational effectiveness. Implemented new policies to streamline HR operations and optimize organizational processes.

Keywords identified in the job posting:

- Talent acquisition (replaced the word “recruitment”)
- Preparing reports and statistical information (replaced “data analysis”)
- Developed and implemented programs (replaced the words “Implemented new policies”)

AFTER including keywords from job posting:

- Directed various functions for 30K military and civilian personnel including talent acquisition, retention, strategic planning, preparing reports and statistical information, and organizational effectiveness. Developed and implemented programs to streamline HR operations and optimize organizational processes.



PRO TIP:

ANALYZE JOB POSTINGS

Looking closely at a job posting will help you think like an employer and create an effective targeted resume.

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

Formal education and specialized training belong on your resume. The key is to determine what is most relevant to the future employer and what will best position you as the ideal candidate for the job. Use the following guidelines to list your education and training history:

1. List your most recent education and training first.
2. Include relevant degrees achieved beyond high school, highest to lowest.
3. List the locations of colleges and universities, but it is not necessary to include dates attended. Some research states that you may encounter ageism if the date you earned your degree is too recent or too far back.
4. List special honors you achieved, such as graduating Cum Laude, with honors, or having a grade point average (GPA) at or above a 3.5.
5. Indicate the number of credit hours completed or provide an expected graduation date if you have not yet graduated.
6. Provide certification or renewal year for any certifications you have. Discard irrelevant certifications (e.g., Do not list CPR unless it is used in the job.)
7. Include licenses, coursework, and schools relevant to the job.

Use the following examples to list your education.

If you have completed your degree:

- Type of degree, major, university name, city, state, honors or GPA (optional)
- Master of Arts in Educational Leadership, University of Arizona, Tucson, AZ, Summa Cum Laude
- Bachelor of Arts, Political Science, Emory University, Atlanta, GA
- Associate of Science in Human Resources Management, Georgia State University, Atlanta, GA

If you are still working on your degree:

There are different ways to list degrees in progress.

- Master of Arts in Educational Leadership, University of Arizona, Tucson, AZ, 25/30 semester hours completed
- Associate of Science in Human Resources Management, Georgia State University, Atlanta, GA, in progress—16 credit hours completed

If you are including a certification or license:

Type of certification, certifying organization, date completed/expires.

- Senior Professional of Human Resources (SPHR), HR Certification Institute, December 20XX/Expires December 20XX

ACTIVITY 2.8: CREATE YOUR EDUCATION AND TRAINING

Use the space below to create the education and training section of your resume:

OTHER ADDITIONS

VOLUNTEER SERVICE

Volunteer experience is valuable because it illustrates important skills you possess and shows that you are involved in your community.

If you have relevant volunteer experience, list it in your experience section as if it is a paid position. Use the STAR method to create your achievement statements.

EXAMPLE:

Website Designer – volunteer June 20XX-present

Lifehealth Foundation, Fayetteville, NC

- Designed website for the Lifehealth Foundation, increasing traffic to website by 25%.
- Developed a front-end WordPress site and blog with 341+ pages.
- Customized a web app to schedule donations pickup to facilitate on-site processes.
- Created an online presence on social media sites such as Facebook, LinkedIn, and X, and increased market awareness by 65%.

AWARDS

Awards are valuable because they indicate you performed well in a specific position and that your efforts were recognized. Use the following guidelines to list your awards:

- Provide the name of the award and a brief statement explaining why you received the award.
- It is best to include the award as a bullet point in the experience section under the position you earned it. It is no longer customary to have an awards section at the end of your resume. Including the award under a specific job position is better.



Quick Tip

Be selective in including your awards. Add only those that speak directly to your accomplishments (not unit or group awards, unless YOU led the group).

EXAMPLE:

Website Designer – volunteer June 20XX-present

Lifehealth Foundation, Fayetteville, NC

- Designed website for the Lifehealth Foundation, increasing traffic to website by 25%.
- Recognized by CSS Design Awards (CSSDA) in 20XX for outstanding work in developing website.

REVIEWING YOUR RESUME

CHECK FOR ERRORS

You will be better able to identify errors or other issues if you view it from a fresh perspective. Use the editor tool in your word processing software to identify spelling and grammar problems. Also, consider downloading a free version of Grammarly to help you identify errors in your document.

As useful as these tools are, they will not pick up every error. Do not rely on them to identify all issues in your resume. Do your own careful review. When you are ready to review, keep in mind that you are not simply looking for spelling errors. Think like an employer as you read your resume. Ensure all information flows logically and presents your skills and qualifications clearly.



Quick Tip

When you finish writing your resume, put it aside for a day before you start making revisions.



More Information

Use your free resources at the Transition Center, family center, American Job Center (AJC), or a non-profit to provide more in-depth review and assistance.

Follow these tips to create a polished final version of your resume.

1. Take time to review your draft carefully and give your resume your full concentration.
2. Verify all dates, names, and phone numbers are accurate.
3. Look for typographical errors and transposed numbers.
4. Check for consistent verb tenses and parallel structure in bulleted lists.
5. Review several times, each time looking for a type of error. For example, read one time for organization of content, another time for formatting, and another time for spelling and accuracy.
6. Read it backwards starting at the bottom. This tip forces you to slow down and look at each word.
7. Do not trust spell check to catch your errors; many words can be spelled correctly but are the incorrect word choice in the context. For example: their, they're, there.
8. Check that all terms and acronyms are spelled out where needed.
9. Confirm your name is on every page. This is important in case pages get separated.
10. Ask a trusted friend or colleague to read your resume after you have reviewed and revised it. Explain to them that you are looking for feedback and accept their input graciously.

SCAN RESUME FOR KEYWORDS

Targeted resumes address the specific needs of the employer and demonstrate how you can and will meet the goals of the role. In addition, ensure it contains important keywords from the job description. Once your targeted resume is ready and you are prepared to submit for a job application, find out how well your resume might do in an ATS scan.



Video

See an example of a resume scan. (https://www.dvidshub.net/video/embed/987056)

There are several AI and online tools available that can scan your resume against a job posting and analyze your use of matching keywords. Once on the site, you can either paste in the text of your resume or upload a Word or PDF file, then paste the text of the job posting you're interested in. The application reviews your resume against the job posting similarly to an ATS scan.

Use the results of the AI scan analysis to revise your resume so that it is optimized for your selected job description. Repeat these scans for each job application.

WRITING YOUR COVER LETTER

PURPOSE OF THE COVER LETTER

A cover letter may be submitted with your resume. Once again, ensure you follow the instructions in the job application. The cover letter helps you introduce yourself in a memorable, personal way and expands on information in your resume. In 2024, according to LinkedIn, 83% of hiring managers read cover letters and take them into consideration when making hiring decisions.

Your cover letter offers an opportunity to represent your skills and achievements in a narrative format. Select a story from your career that gives the reader a clear idea of who you are and how you can add value to their company. Don't try to fit your whole career and life into the space of a cover letter; focus on key aspects. Your cover letter should not duplicate or restate your resume.

Your cover letter should show:

- How your work experience meets job requirements.
- How your skills meet job requirements.
- Why you want to work at the organization.

PARTS OF A COVER LETTER

Like a targeted resume, a cover letter should be based on the requirements of the job you're applying for. A typical cover letter is 250 to 400 words long and uses the format below.

1. Header with contact information.
2. Salutation (or greeting) to the hiring manager.
3. Paragraph stating the position you are applying for and how you heard about the job.
4. Paragraph communicating your qualifications for the job.
5. Paragraphs describing a key achievement to show why you're the right person for the job.
6. Closing paragraph with a call to action.
7. Complimentary close and signature.

DRAFTING YOUR COVER LETTER

Before you draft your cover letter, research the company to get a sense of the company's culture and compare your skills with the requirements for the position. Make a list of competencies you want to highlight and the specific experiences you want to share.

Telling stories from your career is a great way to demonstrate your skills and give hiring managers some insight into your personality and work style. Let's say you're applying for a project manager position. From the job description you see the job requires several years' experience managing multiple projects and strong collaboration skills to partner effectively across various levels of the organization.

Describe how, in your previous role as a project manager, you successfully managed a project (with specific numbers if possible), communicating and collaborating with many different coworkers. Your anecdote can accomplish a lot at once—it can show your knowledge of project management methods, your ability to lead teams to successful outcomes, and your ability to troubleshoot problems so they are quickly resolved.

End your letter with a reason for them to contact you. Your call to action should be polite and open-ended, suggesting that you are excited to offer more information and that you are looking forward to talking with them. Do not be too forward, though. Remarks such as, "I'll call to schedule an interview," are too aggressive coming from a job applicant.

WRITING TIPS

- **Be Specific.** Saying you have amazing problem-solving skills is too vague. Explain the details of a problem you solved and explain how you used your skills to solve it.
- **Write in an Appropriate Voice and Tone**. Your writing conveys your personal voice, while also using an appropriate voice and tone for the target company. Researching the company will help dictate the tone you want to use, which may differ greatly, depending on where you apply. For example, the tone of your letter for a legal consulting firm will be more conservative. A tech startup may appreciate a creative tone or your letter might contain more technical savvy terms.
- **Be Honest**. You should never be dishonest in a job search. Implying or stating that you have a skill that you don't have will come back to haunt you upon being asked to use that skill in the interview or on the job.
- **Avoid Overused Words and Phrases**. Hiring managers will read the same basic cover letter repeatedly, and you don't want to be the last template cover letter the hiring manager discounts before lunch. Adding a little word variation helps you stand out against other applicants. Instead of describing yourself as creative, try imaginative. You're inventive, not innovative. You're not determined, you're tenacious. These word variations at least show that you can think beyond what the average applicant is willing to do.

COVER LETTER TEMPLATE

Your Name

Your website or LinkedIn URL

Email

Phone

Date of Letter

Hiring Manager's Name (if known)

Hiring Manager's Title, Company Name

Street Address

City, State, Zip Code

Dear Hiring Manager: If possible, find out the hiring manager's name and use that. Do not address "To whom it may concern." You can use "Hiring Committee" if it is not one person or you have no name. Do not address to Mrs. or Miss, use Ms.

INTRODUCTORY PARAGRAPH: You want to tell the reader why you are writing as well as list the name of the position or department for which you are applying. Mention how you heard about the organization or the job opening.

BODY: Build a connection between your background and the company's needs. Name someone you know in the company (if they have agreed to be a reference for you). Show that you have done some research on the company by talking about new projects the company has taken on, mentioning the management philosophy they use, or citing something you have read about them. If you have any directly related experience or education, summarize it here so the reader can look for it in your resume. If you have relevant skills or accomplishments related to the job, mention them here.

CONCLUSION: Indicate your interest in the job. State that you look forward to being able to discuss your background in an interview. Thank the reader for his/her time and consideration.

Sincerely, (or Best Regards. Do not use V/R.)

Your name or signature

EXAMPLE COVER LETTER

James Donaldson
Linkedin.com/in.james-donaldson/
James@email.com
555-123-4567

July 10, 202X

Ms. Margaret Cook
Personnel Director, Accounting Software International
5678 East Doral Street, Suite #1200
Lockridge, Tennessee 77777

Dear Ms. Cook,

As a highly skilled Business Consultant, I read your posting for a new Business Consultant position at Accounting Software International with interest. My experience aligns well with the qualifications you are seeking. I am drawn to Accounting Software International because of my interest in accounting software and the opportunity to use my skill sets in a more specialized career.

ASI's commitment to its customers and culture of excellence aligns perfectly with my own convictions. I have spent the past five years working with clients around the globe, helping them to improve operations and maximize profits by utilizing all the features of their existing software programs. I can quickly and accurately understand organizational needs, and I have a proven track record of meeting those needs.

Last year, I led an initiative to implement a new process for identifying compliance issues and improving accuracy in reporting. As a result, productivity increased 12% overall and client satisfaction significantly improved. I am confident that I will be a valuable addition to your team.

I look forward to the possibility of discussing this opportunity with you. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Best Regards,

James Donaldson

SUBMITTING YOUR RESUME

Once your targeted resume is finalized, you will be ready to upload it to a job application site or ATS or to send it as an email attachment. Most resumes are delivered in digital form.

Digital resumes can be sent as either a Word document (.docx or .doc) or as a PDF (based on instructions provided). Recruiters and hiring managers do not agree which format is best.

Always go with the format the employer requests. If job application instructions specifically say, “Please submit your resume in PDF format,” then do that. And the same goes for a Word document. If a choice isn’t given, consider the pros and cons of each file format:



Quick Tip

Employers and recruiters do notice if you cannot follow directions, and they generally favor employees who are savvy with technology, so be sure to take the time to provide what is requested.

- A PDF cannot be altered, whereas a Word document can be edited (either accidentally or intentionally) by the recruiter or company you submit it to.
- While PDF is now widely accepted and preserves formatting best, a plain Word (.docx) document remains the safest and most traditional format to ensure maximum compatibility across all generations of ATS software.
- Submitting as a .docx/.doc does not preserve your formatting unless the person opening has the same word processor. For example, a person may have a Mac and not use Microsoft Word. PDFs will preserve file formatting in any viewer.

Give your documents a logical file name. Employers often download resumes and cover letters to a common folder so your filename should help them identify your document later. Make sure your filenames do not have any spaces in them. If you want to include a space in the name, use an underscore.

- AliciaThomas_resume
- AliciaThomas_coverletter

HOW TO UPLOAD A RESUME ONLINE

You may need to upload a targeted resume and cover letter to a job search engine or a specific company’s job site page. Here are some general tips to follow:

- Look for a text box. Some sites will let you copy/paste the text of your resume into a box on their job application form. If you choose to do this, make sure the formatting looks professional and correct within the text box. Many ATSs require the applicant to use their system’s resume format, similar to a resume wizard. They will have you copy and paste your resume section by section into their form or questionnaire.
- Search for a button that says “Upload” or “Upload a resume.” When you click this button, you can then find the file on your computer to add it as an attachment to your job application.
- Pay special attention to any instructions about uploading. Look for any notes specifying a preferred format.

HOW TO SEND A RESUME IN AN EMAIL

Sometimes employers will ask that you submit your resume, cover letter, and other required credentials via email to the hiring manager or other human resources professional. Follow specific directions provided in the job posting regarding attaching or pasting the content of your resume in the body of the email. Do not do both unless specifically requested. If no specific request is given, attach your resume to the email.

If the employer requests the resume in the body of the email, ensure that your formatting is correct. Sometimes formatting changes when copying and pasting, especially fonts, spacing, and paragraph alignment.

Put your name, the name of the position, and job reference number for which you are applying in the subject line. Include a message in the body of the email with a brief explanation of why you are writing and submitting your resume. Think of it as a mini cover letter. You may want to attach your prepared cover letter separately if the application instructions ask for it. Make the cover letter and resume separate attachments to reduce confusion.

When you take the time to upload a targeted resume that is professional and easy to read, it can help you stand out from the competition.



Quick Tip

Creating a full application package (resume, cover letter, reference, etc.) shows your personal brand of being competent, thorough, detailed, and able to follow instructions.

GATHERING YOUR REFERENCES

It is often a good sign if you are asked for a list of your references after you interview. This is a cue that you are being seriously considered for the position. In some instances, your references are requested at the same time as your application. In either circumstance, you want to have your references prepared and ready to go. When including your references, do not make them a part of your resume. Instead, list a minimum of three on a separate document.

What are references? References are those supervisors or colleagues who can provide feedback about your work experience, abilities, education, skills, and personality. You can create a list that includes former employers, direct or indirect supervisors, colleagues, personal and professional connections, teachers, and others who can endorse your ability to do a job. Better yet, if you know anyone in the company you are applying to, ask for an internal reference. Many companies offer employee bonuses for internal references and that person may be eager to participate in the referral program.

Consider the following best practices:

Ask permission. It is customary to ask for permission to use someone as a reference. Discuss this with the person beforehand to ensure they are willing to participate. This also provides you with the opportunity to review some of your skills and accomplishments with them to jog their memory before they are called.

Some common questions you can discuss with your potential reference ahead of time are:

1. What was the nature and length of your relationship with the candidate?
2. In what capacity did you work with the candidate (peer, colleague, supervisor)?
3. Could you give me a brief description of the duties the candidate performed?
4. What were the candidate's strengths?
5. Would you recommend the candidate for this position? Why or why not?

Be selective. If you have any doubt that the person may not be a good source to present you in the highest regard, it is best not to use them. Also, ensure you aren't overusing one reference. This can cause reference fatigue and may discourage the person from supporting you in the future.

Prepare the reference. Provide them a recent resume and a copy of the job announcement. This will allow them to speak intelligently about which of your skills are a best fit for the potential employer.

Verify information. Once you have identified a list of people to use, verify and confirm that you have the correct contact information. They may prefer to be called on their work number versus their cell phone. You also want to make sure you collect an email address from them that they will check. Employers have been known to send questionnaires to references to gather information.

Say thank you! In every aspect of your job search journey, there will be people in your network that will contribute to your success. It is important to send a thank-you email after they've agreed to be your reference. It would also be a great gesture to let them know if you got the job and show them that their support contributed to your accomplishment. In any regard, keep them posted on the status of your job search so they will be prepared if they receive another phone call.

REFERENCE EXAMPLE

Name
Job Title, Company
Phone number
Email

Amy Weston
Chief of Operations, ACME Inc.
(123) 555-1212
Amy.Weston@email.com

Quick Tip

Your references are excellent resources for your job search. They may review your resume or help you network.

ACTIVITY 2.9: BRAINSTORM YOUR REFERENCES

Use the space below to brainstorm the names of three or more people you want to add to your reference list.

LETTERS OF RECOMMENDATION

The references you selected are also great sources for a letter of recommendation. A letter of recommendation is a letter from a trusted contact in your network that can speak to your skills, achievements, and character. It is not required, but some job seekers like to collect letters of recommendation in case that specific reference is not available to an employer. This contact is endorsing why you are a great candidate for the position you are seeking. Traditionally, an employer will call your references to collect information they may be seeking beyond your resume. However, certain settings such as academic or professional designation jobs like medical and legal normally request a letter of recommendation.

RESUME SECTION REVIEW

We have covered a lot of resume information in this section. Let's do a quick review.

You learned how to:

- understand the different types and styles of resumes.
- explain Applicant Tracking Systems.
- create or update your resume.
- understand how to review and submit your resume.
- complete your application materials with a cover letter and references.

3 Federal Hiring

SECTION 3: FEDERAL HIRING

SECTION OBJECTIVES

- Gain a better understanding of the federal hiring process.
- Identify preferences and executive orders for veterans.
- Recognize differences between federal resumes and standard business resumes.
- Know where to obtain additional information on federal hiring.

FEDERAL EMPLOYMENT SYSTEM

The federal employment system is made up of multiple agencies with a total civilian (nonuniformed) workforce of just over 3 million. According to the Office of Personnel Management (OPM), veterans historically comprise 30% of the federal workforce.

Federal agencies continue to value veteran candidates as their skills are highly transferable to the work of those agencies. In 2025, the OPM Talent Team released a government-wide program to boost veteran hiring by working with agency leaders to define target occupations that closely align with the skills of transitioning service members. OPM partnered with veterans' program leaders to recruit qualified veterans to fill critical agency needs.

There are many laws, executive orders, and regulations that govern federal employment, making it more complicated to apply for federal employment than private companies. This section will provide a broad overview of federal employment.



Did You Know?

There are thousands of available positions across multiple agencies beyond the Department of War and the military services' federal components.

WHY CHOOSE FEDERAL EMPLOYMENT?

Pursuing federal employment is a natural transition for many veterans. It is an opportunity to continue public service supporting the mission of the U.S. Government. Also, the systematic processes and functions can feel familiar to veterans, offering a similar structure and culture to that of the military.

Federal benefits packages, including leave and healthcare, can be generous when compared to many private-sector employment benefit packages.

Did you know that veteran federal employees may be able to apply some of their time in military service towards their paid annual leave accrual? The accrual calculation is different for retired and non-retired prior service members. Check with OPM for more information on creditable service.

Did you also know that veterans can get credit for military service? As a general rule, military service in the Armed Forces of the United States is creditable for retirement purposes if you left active service under honorable conditions and the service is performed prior to your separation from civilian service for retirement. Find out more on OPM's FedsHireVets website under Federal Retirement.

We'll discuss more about federal employment opportunities, how to apply for positions, and where to find additional resources to assist you.

More Information

You can learn about Creditable Service for Leave Accrual on the OPM website. (https://www.opm.gov/policy-data-oversight/pay-leave/leave-administration/fact-sheets/lump-sum-payments-for-annual-leave/)

Visit OPM's FedsHireVets website for more information on Creditable Military Service Buy-Back. (https://www.opm.gov/fedshirevets/current-veteran-employees/federal-retirement)

There are four websites to become familiar with as you begin the path toward federal civil service.

OPM.gov

Official site of Office of Personnel Management

Provides information on: Job Classifications & Occupational Series, Pay & Leave, Benefits, Performance Management, and the latest published memos, including the Merit Hiring Plan. (https://www.opm.gov/chcoc/latest-memos/merit-hiring-plan.pdf)

www.opm.gov

USAJOBS.gov

The Federal Government's Official Employment Site

As a part of OPM, USAJOBS helps recruit and retain a world-class government workforce for the American people. Potential employees use this site to find federal jobs that match their skills, education, and experience. Federal hiring managers use the USAJOBS Resume Mining feature to identify and connect available veteran applicants with roles for which they may be qualified.

Various events posted on the USAJOBS site provide more information about learning opportunities and specific positions. This includes general information webinars hosted by OPM to help you prepare for your job search.

Provides information on:
Open Jobs, How to Apply, Hiring Paths, and Tutorials & Training.

usajobs.gov

Quick Tip

When applying for a job, check USAJOBS events page to see if there are any events near you. (https://www.usajobs.gov/event/)

OPM.gov/FedsHireVets

Office of Personnel Management's Government-wide Veterans Employment Website

FedsHireVets is a one-stop resource for federal employment information for veterans, spouses of active-duty military members, and family members of veterans. Created by OPM, this site will be your most valuable resource for learning about special hiring authorities and overall federal employment for veterans. This website is a critical component of the federal government's strategy for the recruitment and employment of veterans.

There is an online training module in the FedsHireVets virtual classroom designed primarily for veterans, but it also offers useful information for military spouses.

There is also an agency directory with a list of Veteran Employment Program Offices responsible for promoting veteran recruitment, employment, training and development, and retention. You can contact the liaisons directly for each agency.

Provides information on:
Veteran Job Seekers, Veteran Federal Employees, Veterans Preference, Training on Federal Employment, and Agency Directory for Recruiting Veterans.

OPM.gov/FedsHireVets

Quick Tip

Locate training at the Virtual Classroom Training for Transitioning to Federal Employment. (https://www.opm.gov/fedshirevets/veteran-job-seekers/virtual-classroom/)

Use the Veteran's Employment Program Offices Directory to locate liaisons for each hiring agency. (https://www.opm.gov/fedshirevets/veteran-job-seekers/vets-agency-directory/)

USA.gov

Official Guide to Government Information and Services

USA.gov is the U.S. Government's official web portal to all federal, state, and local government web resources and services. An A-Z list of all government departments and agencies is found on this site with contact information included.

Provides information on:
Finding a Federal Job, Excepted Service (Agency Listing), Veterans' Preference, and Federal Jobs for People with Disabilities.

https://www.usa.gov/

EXPLORING FEDERAL HIRING

The federal civil service is comprised of three distinct services: Competitive Service, Excepted Service, and Senior Executive Service.

Competitive Service

Competitive service positions represent the majority of federal civil service jobs and are governed by Congressional civil service laws that mandate fair and equal treatment in hiring.

Individuals who meet the minimum qualifications must go through a competitive hiring process. This process may consist of a written test, an evaluation of the individual's education and experience, and/or an evaluation of other attributes necessary for successful performance in the position to be filled.

Excepted Service

Excepted service positions are federal roles outside of the competitive service and the Senior Executive Service. These agencies establish their own qualification requirements and are not bound by most Title 5 rules governing appointment, pay, and classification. There are federal agencies in which every position is considered an excepted service position, and other agencies in which only some positions are excepted service positions. For example, positions at the U.S. Postal Service and Central Intelligence Agency are excepted by law.

Senior Executive Service

The Senior Executive Service (SES) is the corps of executives selected for their leadership qualifications and charged with leading the continuing transformation of government. These leaders possess well-honed executive skills and share a broad perspective of government and a public service commitment which is grounded in the Constitution. The SES positions encompass duties identified as executive or managerial.

KEY TERMS AND HIRING PATHS

Merit Hiring Plan

The Merit Hiring Plan Memo was issued by OPM in May 2025 and builds on the Chance to Compete Act of 2024 to reform federal hiring. Focused on candidate evaluations through skills and competency-based assessments, the Merit Hiring Plan aims to strengthen the federal workforce with highly capable, mission-driven employees.

Four Key Elements:

1. Restructuring the federal recruitment process to ensure the most talented, capable, and patriotic Americans are hired into federal service.
2. Applying skills-based hiring, removing unnecessary degree requirements, and requiring the use of rigorous, job-related assessments to select candidates based on merit and competence.
3. Streamlining the job application process.
4. Reducing time-to-hire to under 80 days.

Series

The federal government uses a numbered system for grouping similar occupations. The occupational groups or job families correlate jobs into numbered series. For example, a nurse is part of the 0610 series as a subset of the 0600 family for Medical and Healthcare Group.

Knowing the numerical series of the job family you wish to pursue can be helpful when searching for open positions. You can find a list of job series definitions on USAJOBS.gov by searching "Series" in the Help Center or on OPM.gov under Classification & Qualifications. (https://help.usajobs.gov/how-to/search/filters/series)

You can determine your Military Occupation Specialty (MOS) to Federal Job Crosswalk correlation using this link at Mil2FedJobs. (https://www.dllr.state.md.us/mil2fedjobs)

Pay Scale and Grade

The General Schedule (GS) classification and pay system covers the majority of civilian white-collar federal employees. You may notice several abbreviations of different pay scales and wage types such as Wage Grade (WG) or Law Enforcement Officer (LEO). A pay grade is a rate of basic pay based on the specific level of work or range of difficulty, responsibility, and qualifications.

The GS pay schedule has 15 pay grades and 10 steps in each grade, with GS-1 being the lowest and GS-15 being the highest. The steps within each grade can be related to a federal employee's tenure. Step increases are raises in salary and occur over time similar to longevity increases. In some circumstances, starting pay and steps can be negotiated based on your experience and/or education.

Hiring Paths

The federal government offers unique hiring paths to help hire individuals who represent a diverse society. Review the hiring paths to determine your eligibility. You may be eligible under one or more groups. Examples of the hiring paths include:

- Veterans
- Military spouses
- Students and recent graduates
- Individuals with disabilities
- Family of overseas employees

More Information

Locate Veterans' Hiring Paths on USAJOBS under Hiring Paths and Veterans. (https://help.usajobs.gov/working-in-government/unique-hiring-paths/veterans)

There may be other hiring paths available to your situation. When applying for positions, choose all that apply.

VETERAN HIRING FLEXIBILITIES

Veterans' Preference

Veterans' Preference recognizes the sacrifices veterans made by serving our country. It assists with a favorable competitive position for federal employment and recognizes the debt owed to disabled veterans. Veterans' Preference does not guarantee "a job for a veteran."

Not all veterans are considered veterans for the purpose of federal civilian employment, and not all active-duty service qualifies for Veterans' Preference.

Only veterans discharged or released from active duty in the armed forces under honorable conditions are eligible for Veterans' Preference.

With Veterans' Preference, you may receive preference over non-veteran applicants in the hiring process. Veterans' Preference can be used when applying to permanent and temporary positions in both the competitive and excepted service (of the executive branch). Preference does not apply to positions in the Senior Executive Service or to executive branch positions for which Senate confirmation is required.



Video

Watch the following Veterans' Preference Video for more information on what it is and how it is applied in the federal hiring process. (https://www.dvidshub.net/video/embed/987054)

Rating and Ranking Applicants in the Competitive Service

Preference-eligible veterans are divided into five basic groups as follows:

- CPS – Disability rating of 30% or more (10 points)
- CP – Disability rating of at least 10% but less than 30% (10 points)
- XP – Disability rating less than 10% (10 points)
- TP – Preference eligible with no disability rating (5 points)
- SSP – Sole Survivorship Preference (0 points)



Quick Tip

Veterans' Preference can be confusing. You can check your eligibility using the Department of Labor's Veterans' Preference Advisor. (https://webapps.dol.gov/elaws/vets/vetpref/mservice.htm)

Candidate Ranking and Selection Process

Agencies evaluate candidates based on their relative ability, skills, and knowledge using either a category or a numerical ranking system. Certifying a predetermined number of candidates in score order ensures that the most highly qualified candidates are considered by hiring managers, while upholding Veterans' Preference.

When using the category ranking system, qualified applicants are grouped into categories based on their qualifications; Highly Qualified, Well Qualified, and Qualified. Veterans' Preference is then applied within categories by placing veterans ahead of non-veterans within the same category. Applying Veterans' Preference across categories means that a veteran with 10 points, as shown above in the CPS, CP, or XP categories, is moved to the top of the highest category.

When an agency uses a numerical ranking system, Veterans' Preference is applied by adding extra points to the evaluation or assessment scores.

Hiring officials consider all eligible candidates and select from the top-ranked candidates. In both systems, Veterans' Preference ensures veterans are given priority consideration during the selection process.

DOCUMENTATION

You must provide acceptable documentation of your preference or appointment eligibility. Acceptable documentation may include:

- The Member 4 Copy of your DD214, "Certificate of Release or Discharge from Active Duty," is preferable.
- The SF-15, "Application for 10-Point Veteran Preference", is used by federal agencies and OPM examining offices to determine claims for Veterans' Preference.
- A "certification" is a written document from the armed forces that certifies the service member is expected to be discharged or released from active-duty service in the armed forces under honorable conditions not later than 120 days after the date the certification is signed.

SPECIAL HIRING FLEXIBILITIES

Special non-competitive hiring flexibilities are established by law or executive order. Agencies may, but are not required to, use a variety of appointing authorities to hire job applicants.

Veterans, individuals with disabilities, many current and former federal employees, and returning Peace Corps volunteers are all examples of individuals eligible for non-competitive appointment.

Special Hiring Authorities for Veterans are designed to assist veterans in their job search. These special authorities represent a few of many appointing authorities that agencies can use entirely at their discretion.

Veterans' Recruitment Appointment (VRA) is an excepted authority that allows agencies to appoint eligible veterans without competition. If you:

- served during a war or are in receipt of a campaign badge for service in a campaign or expedition;

OR

- are a disabled veteran;

OR

- are in receipt of an Armed Forces Service Medal (includes the Global War on Terrorism Service Medal) for participation in a military operation;

OR

- are a recently separated veteran (within 3 years of discharge);

AND

- separated under honorable conditions (this means an honorable or general discharge).

You can be appointed under this authority at any grade level up to and including a GS-11 or equivalent. This is an excepted service appointment.



Quick Tip

Check your eligibility for any of the Special Hiring Authorities for Veterans on the OPM veteran's website. (https://www.opm.gov/fedshirevets/hiring-officials/strategic-recruitment-and-hiring/veterans/)

30% or More Disabled Veteran Appointment

This allows any veteran with a 30% or more service-connected disability to be non-competitively appointed. You are eligible if you:

- retired from active military service with a service-connected disability rating of 30% or more;

OR

- have a rating by the Department of Veterans Affairs showing a compensable service-connected disability of 30% or more.

This authority can be used to make temporary (at least 60 days but not to exceed 1 year) or term (more than 1 year, but not more than 4) appointments in the competitive service. There is no grade level restriction. There is no requirement that the temporary appointment be converted to a permanent position.

Veterans Employment Opportunity Act (VEOA)

This competitive service appointing authority can only be used when filling permanent, competitive service positions after the agency has decided to solicit candidates from outside its own workforce. It cannot be used to fill excepted service positions. VEOA allows veterans to apply to announcements that are only open to so-called “status” candidates, which means “current competitive service employees and certain prior employees who have earned competitive status.”

To be eligible for consideration under VEOA appointment, your latest discharge must be issued under honorable conditions (this means an honorable or general discharge), AND you must be either:

- a preference eligible (defined in title 5 U.S.C. 2108(3));

OR

- a veteran who substantially completed 3 or more years of active service under honorable conditions.

Disabled Veterans Enrolled in a Veterans’ Affairs (VA) Training Program

Veterans enrolled in this program may enroll for training or work experience at an agency under the terms of an agreement between the agency and the VA. While enrolled in the VA program, the veteran is not a federal employee for most purposes but is a beneficiary of the VA.

Training is tailored to the individual’s needs and goals, so there is no set length. If the training is intended to prepare the individual for eventual appointment in the agency, the agency must ensure that the training will enable the veteran to meet the qualification requirements for the position.

Upon successful completion, the host agency and VA give the veteran a Certificate of Training showing the occupational series and grade level of the position for which they trained. The Certificate of Training allows any agency to appoint the veteran noncompetitively under a status quo appointment, which may be converted to career or career-conditional at any time. For more information, contact the Department of Veterans Affairs, VA Regional Office - VR&E Division.

Other Special Hiring Authorities

Though not specifically for veterans, and not entirely inclusive, the following is a sample of some of the more frequently used special hiring authorities that veterans should be aware of and apply under as appropriate.

Schedule A Hiring Authority for Persons with Disabilities

Not specifically for veterans, the Schedule A authority for people with disabilities is an excepted authority that agencies can use to appoint eligible persons, to include veterans, who have a severe physical, psychological, or intellectual disability. To prove your eligibility to be appointed to a federal job under Schedule A, you must:

- be qualified for the job for which you are applying (i.e., have the necessary competencies and relevant experience to perform the job);

AND

- provide "proof of disability" documentation.

Sample Schedule A letters can be found on OPM's website. (https://www.opm.gov/policy-data-oversight/disability-employment/getting-a-job/sampleschedaletters.pdf)



Did You Know?

SEAD 7 on reciprocity mandates that all executive branch agencies accept existing national security clearances and background investigations previously adjudicated by authorized entities to ensure efficient personnel transfer and eliminate redundant vetting. (https://www.dni.gov/files/NCSC/documents/Regulations/SEAD-7_BI_ReciprocityU.pdf)

Pathways Program

If you are a student or recent graduate, you may wish to consider beginning your career in the federal government by applying for a vacancy under whichever of the authorities described below that may apply to you.

- Internship Program is for current students enrolled in a wide variety of educational institutions from high school to graduate level, with paid opportunities to work in agencies and explore federal careers while still in school. Visit USAJOBS Students to learn more about internships and locate opportunities. (https://help.usajobs.gov/working-in-government/unique-hiring-paths/students)
- Recent Graduates Program is for individuals who have recently graduated from qualifying educational institutions or programs and seek a dynamic, career development program with training and mentorship. To be eligible, applicants must apply within two years of degree or certificate completion (except for veterans precluded from doing so due to their military service obligation, who will have up to six years to apply). For program information, visit USAJOBS Recent Graduates website. (https://help.usajobs.gov/working-in-government/unique-hiring-paths/recent-graduates)

Veterans are encouraged to seek consideration under all the hiring authorities for which they are eligible, in addition to claiming their preference under the competitive examining process (if applicable).

FINDING FEDERAL JOBS

USAJOBS is the federal government's official source for federal job listings.

Job Titles and Job Announcement Content

Job titles in your federal job search should be similar to those you have seen in your civilian job search. They should resonate with you, as the job seeker, and be career focused. For example, IT Project Manager is more descriptive than a general title such as Management and Program Analyst.

Federal job announcements use plain language that accurately summarizes the position and skills sought by the hiring manager. Job terms should make sense to the public and be free of acronyms and federal jargon. Position descriptions are standardized for the most common 135 job series in the federal system, which has streamlined the application process.

Quick Tip

Though most federal agencies post their jobs on USAJOBS, some post jobs on their agency website. If you want to work for a specific agency, find its website through the USA.gov A-Z Index of Government Agencies. (https://www.usa.gov/agency-index)

Follow these guidelines when deciding which jobs to pursue:

- You must meet all established federal and DOW qualifications and requirements.
- You may apply for permanent as well as temporary and term positions (i.e., intermittent, seasonal, or "flexible" schedules). There is no limit to the number of times you can exercise your Veterans' Preference or status.

To find open job announcements on USAJOBS, search using keywords or location. Because there are thousands of postings, you will need to filter your search to yield a manageable list of jobs to review. You can filter results by hiring paths, job series, agencies, pay grade, or clearance.

When you apply for federal positions, you must follow all instructions as required by the job announcement. This process is necessary for the Human Resources Office (HRO) to determine if you rank among the best-qualified candidates for the position. The evaluation factors used to rank you are the same factors that apply to all competitive candidates.

ACTIVITY 3.1: FIND A JOB THROUGH USAJOBS

1. Go to the USAJOBS.gov website.
2. To search for job postings, enter a job title or keywords, enter your location, and select **Search**. You can save your search parameters and get email notifications when new jobs meeting your criteria become available if you set up an account.
3. Fill out the Hiring Path Filter by marking all options that apply to you.

FEDERAL JOB ANNOUNCEMENTS

UNDERSTANDING THE JOB ANNOUNCEMENT

The most important component of a successful federal job search is to have a clear understanding of the requirements outlined in the job announcement. While these can be lengthy, they provide valuable information about the job, and it's important that you read each section before applying. (There is an example on pages 85-87.)

Select the job title to view the full announcement. Sections include:

Overview: Tells you how much time you have to apply, the salary, the work schedule, and the type of appointment and service. Additionally, when looking at the promotion potential, understand it indicates the maximum grade you can achieve in the position, like a career ladder. Pay close attention to these details which may determine whether you want to apply for the position.

Did You Know?

Details on the following Salaries and Wages can be found on OPM's Salaries and Wages website as well as other agency specific websites:
GS - General Schedule, WG - Wage Grade, NF - Nonappropriated Funds, LEO - Law Enforcement Officer, and NH (agency specific pay-bands).

Pay Scale: Identifies the pay scale and grade. You may notice several abbreviations of different wage types, such as WG, NF, LEO, or NH, according to the hiring agency. One of the most common is GS.

Location: Lists the work location(s). Many jobs have multiple locations, so it's important that you verify the location is somewhere you want to work.

Duties: Describes the job's daily activities and responsibilities.

Qualifications: Describes the type of experience you need, certain conditions you need to agree to for the job, and how the hiring agency will evaluate your application.

Required Documents: Lists all the documents you may need to include with your application to confirm you're eligible and qualified for the job. It's very important that you submit the right documentation. If you are missing information or documentation, your application may be viewed as incomplete and not considered for the position. Some examples of required documents include:

- Cover letter
- Transcripts, licenses, or certifications
- SF-15 (if appropriate) – application for 10-Point Veterans' Preference
- DD-214 (if appropriate) – a service member's proof of military service. This Certificate of Release or Discharge form is issued through the Department of War and typically issued at the final out-processing appointment prior to retirement or separation. If applying prior to receiving your DD-214, contact the job posting point of contact to determine alternate acceptable documents such as a Statement of Service, to verify military service.

How to Apply: This section explains:

- Directions for completing the application.
- Agency contact information.
- Next steps, including information on how your application will be evaluated.

USAJOBS QUESTIONNAIRE

Occupational questionnaire self-assessments can only be used for determining minimum qualification and eligibility, such as Veterans' Preference. In addition, the use of self-assessments for rating or ranking candidates in connection with any job vacancy, other than seasonal work or positions, is limited to GS 01-04 level positions.

USAJOBS Technical and Alternative Assessments

Hiring managers use technical and alternate assessments to facilitate screening of candidates. Because a job might attract hundreds of applicants, these assessments identify qualified candidates from the pool of candidates.

There is a broad range of assessments available, including:

1. centralized assessments that apply to multiple federal agencies and/or jobs.
2. targeted assessments designed specifically for an agency or a particular job.
3. flexible online, proctored, or unproctored assessments.
4. supervisor and nonsupervisory assessments.

USA Hire Standard Assessments cover 135 job series and include general competencies that are specific to job series and grades. All USA Hire Standard Assessments, and the Federal Supervisor Assessment (FSA) are mobile enabled. Applicants may use a wide variety of devices (smart phone, tablet, laptop, or desktop computer) to complete these assessments. These skills-based assessments are in continuous development and can decrease the hiring process time.

The Chance to Compete Act of 2024 defines a "technical assessment" as a position-specific tool that allows for the demonstration of job-related skills, abilities, knowledge, and competencies; is based upon a job analysis; and does not solely include or principally rely upon a self-assessment for an automated examination.

There may be minimum passing scores (cut-off scores) established based on the assessment used, business necessity, or the percentage of applicants. The flexibility of the cut-off scores allows for the rigorous, merit-based pre-certificate ranking of candidates.

Examples of technical and alternative assessments that agencies may use include, but are not limited to, the following:

1. Situational Judgment Test (SJT): Presents work-related scenarios and asks applicants to evaluate various courses of action.
2. Reasoning Assessment: Requires candidates to solve problems or determine correct conclusions from given information.
3. Job Knowledge Test: Requires applicants to apply specific technical facts, rules, or knowledge to the questions or scenarios presented.
4. Work Sample/Simulation: Requires candidates to demonstrate their proficiency in performing a sample of job requirements, and may include:
   - Structured Interview: May include asking applicants to showcase technical ability through a Case Study Presentation, where a prompt and instructions are provided to the candidate via email some number of days before the interview.
   - Live Exercise: Requires candidates to complete a live challenge during the interview.
5. Accomplishment Record: Requires candidates to provide written descriptions of their prior achievements or work activities.

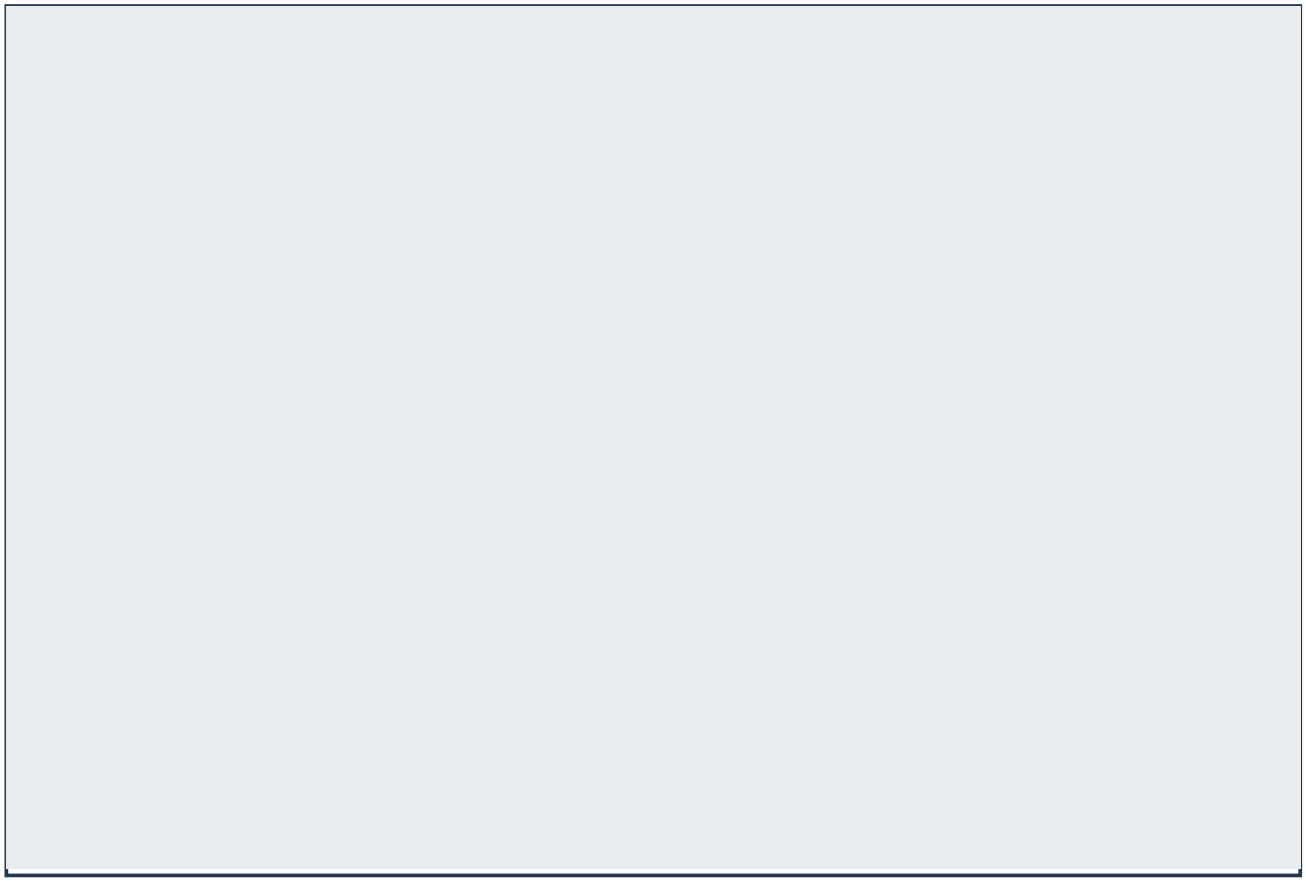
6. Structured Resume Review: Facilitates Subject Matter Expert (SME) review of resumes to determine those meeting the minimum requirements for a position.
7. Structured Writing Sample: Requires certification that the candidate is using their own words (not a consultant or AI) and that the sample has not been edited or drafted by someone else.

Agencies are strongly encouraged to use two or more assessments before providing certification of eligibility, which adds your name to a list of candidates who passed qualification and rating requirements for applicable positions. Further details can be found in the Merit Hiring Memorandum. (https://www.opm.gov/chcoc/transmittals/2025/Merit%20Hiring%20Plan%205-29-2025%20FINAL.pdf)

Talent Pools

A talent pool is a collection of qualified applicants who have completed assessments for a specific job role. OPM manages talent pools for common job series across the government, such as HR Specialists. Hiring managers can view candidates who are qualified, on an active certificate (list of candidates for consideration), and available for immediate employment. Hiring for multiple positions off the same list of candidates reduces hiring time because there is no need to recruit, post jobs, nor examine applicants for each open position.

Applicants need to allow their resume to be searchable on USAJOBS to take full advantage of talent pools.



BASIC FEDERAL RESUMES

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN FEDERAL AND STANDARD RESUMES

A federal resume details the specialized skills and qualifications for a targeted federal job. Federal applications require a concise, skills-based resume which serves as the formal application. Subject Matter Experts (SMEs), rather than HR staff alone, assess and rate your resume to determine your specific level of qualification for the position.

Consider these guidelines when creating your federal resume:

Format:

- File type: Recommend saving and uploading as PDF. Size limited to 5MB or less.
- Length: Your resume must be limited to two pages. If you submit more than two pages, you will be disqualified.
- Font: Recommend using Calibri, Helvetica, Arial, Verdana, Open San Source Sans Pro, Roboto, Noro Sans, or a sans-serif font size like Lato, if available. Recommend 14-point size for titles and and 10-point size for main text.
- Margins: 0.5 inches.

Clarity: Use chronological order with concise, clear, and results-focused language. Avoid using acronyms and terms that are not easily understood. The hiring agency will not make assumptions about what's in your resume.

Relevance: Prioritize your most relevant and recent work experience. Remove any outdated or unrelated experience. Focus on demonstrating skills and competencies.

Customization: Tailor your resume for each application. Your experience descriptions should directly align with all the requirements and qualifications found in the job announcement.

Required Information: Federal resumes must include:

- Relevant work experience, including:
  - Employer name
  - Job title
  - Job start and end dates (month and year)
  - Average number of hours worked each week (part- or full-time employment)
  - Salary information (only if specifically requested in the job announcement)
- Education, certifications, and licensure
  - If this information is required by the job announcement and not included, your application will be considered incomplete, and you may be disqualified.

Free Response Essay Questions:

Applicants will be asked to respond to four general essay questions and required to certify that they are using their own words and did not use a consultant or AI, such as a large language model. To reduce the burden on candidates, the responses cannot exceed 200 words per question.

Additional Documentation:

Federal resume applications will often ask applicants to provide additional information, including transcripts, evaluations, and military service forms. If you fail to provide these documents, you will be marked as having an incomplete application package, and you will not be considered any further. Check out USAJOBS Help Center on Updating Your Resume for more in-depth information. (https://help.usajobs.gov/faq/application/documents/resume/page-limit)

RESUME BUILDER

Once you create a personal account, USAJOBS offers a resume builder tool to ensure candidates complete basic application information required by federal agencies. The resume builder enables you to create a document in a standard federal resume format. USAJOBS also gives you the option to upload your own document. If you choose to do so, submit your resume document as a PDF.

Using the resume builder, however, will make searching and evaluating your resume easier for federal human resources specialists. The resume builder tool mitigates the risk of the application being rejected due to formatting issues or missing information. The tool also increases the likelihood of your resume being scanned and viewed. It helps you ensure your resume is communicating and matching your competencies, knowledge, skills, abilities, experience, and education to the requirements for each job.



More Information

You can learn more about resumes and building a resume in USAJOBS through their Help Center. (https://help.usajobs.gov/how-to/account/documents/resume)

As you work in the resume builder, save your work periodically. For security reasons, your session will time out after a period of inactivity. Save regularly so that you do not lose any work. You can make only one resume searchable at a time.

FORMATTING RESUMES

When you copy and paste text from Word documents into the USAJOBS resume builder, some formatting may be lost. To fix formatting errors inside your resume, you must first save the original file in a .txt format.

DOCUMENTS MANAGEMENT

Your USAJOBS account allows you to upload a number of documents, so they are ready for selection when you apply for a federal job. Under the documents tab, you can upload and maintain five resumes and 10 other documents. Essential documents you can upload include transcripts, DD-214, and other documents that may be required to verify your eligibility for a special hiring authority. You can also make one resume searchable by recruiters who are looking for your skill set.

SUBMITTING RESUMES WITH APPLICATIONS

Some agencies accept uploaded resumes and those created using the USAJOBS resume builder, while some may only accept one or the other. Even though you may have both types of resumes in the **Document** section of your profile, the agency determines which ones to accept when you are applying online. The **Apply** button displayed on the job announcement page activates the process for a job seeker to complete an application.

USAJOBS automatically provides a list of available resumes and other documents to attach to your application and will only display resumes and documents the hiring agency is willing to accept. For example, if the hiring agency only accepts resumes created using the USAJOBS resume builder, your uploaded resumes will not be available to add to your application. Pay special attention to the **How to Apply** section of the job announcement to find out which resume format and documents are accepted and how to submit them to the hiring agency.

APPLICATION MANAGEMENT

USAJOBS illustrates the process for positions posted to ensure all applicants receive fair and equal opportunity. The **Home** tab contains an **Application Manager**, which helps to organize your applications as well as saved jobs, and saved job searches. It will provide a status on your dashboard. This gives you the most accurate information about your job applications.

JOB STATUS

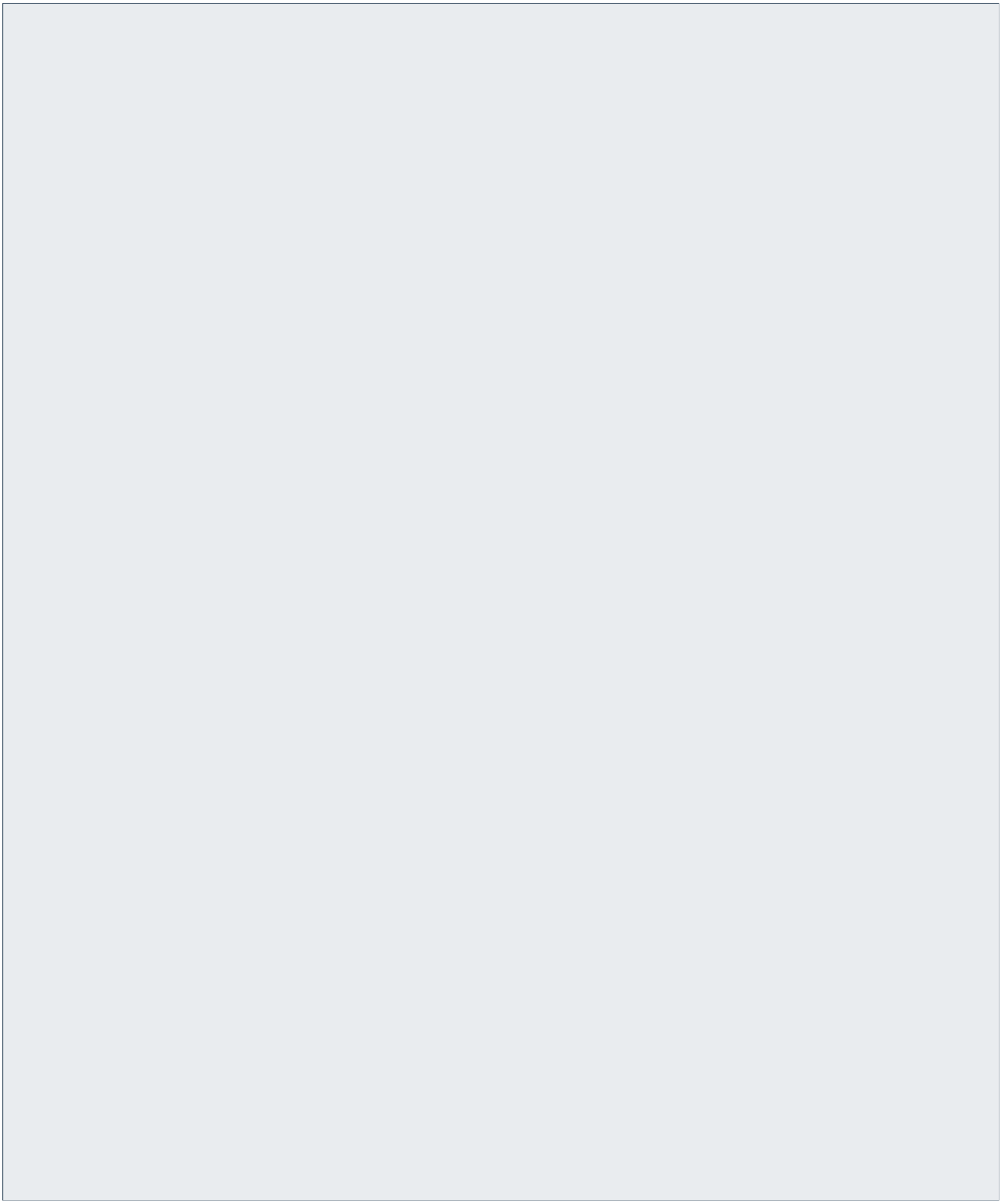
A job status tells you where the job is in the hiring process—whether a hiring agency is accepting applications, reviewing applications, has completed the hiring process, or has canceled the job.

- **Accepting applications**: This job announcement is open and accepting applications. You can apply now.
- **Reviewing applications**: The job announcement is closed, and the hiring agency is reviewing applications. This status will display until the hiring process is complete.
- **Hiring complete**: Hiring is completed, and the position is filled.
- **Job canceled**: The agency withdrew the job announcement and did not hire anyone. An agency can cancel a job announcement any time after they post a job.
- **Job closed:** The job's closing date passed, and the hiring agency did not receive any applications through their online application process. This status will also appear for jobs that do not accept online applications, and the closing date has passed.

OPM offers training to assist you with understanding the federal hiring process on their Virtual Classroom. (https://www.opm.gov/fedshirevets/veteran-job-seekers/virtual-classroom/#)

USAJOBS POSITION ANNOUNCEMENT EXAMPLE

NOTE: Hyperlinks and radio buttons are inactive in the following Position Announcement.



PORTIONS OF USAJOBS POSITION ANNOUNCEMENT

FEDERAL HIRING SECTION REVIEW

Let’s do a quick review of the focus of this section. You have:

- reviewed the federal hiring process.
- learned about preferences and special hiring flexibilities for veterans and others.
- recognized differences in federal resumes and standard corporate resumes.
- obtained resources for additional information on federal hiring.

4 Networking

SECTION 4: NETWORKING

Networking is just as important to your job search as a resume. Networking is your opportunity to provide your resume and introduce yourself to interested and connected contacts. In the EFCT course, you learned that networking is the leading way people get jobs.

When you consider that the entire process of finding a job is an exercise in selling your skills, abilities, experience, and education to an employer, it reframes the traditional concept of a job search.

In this section, we will introduce an updated approach to networking to help find the right job for you. You have already begun to develop a picture of what your current network looks like. We will continue the discussion about various types of networking methods you can use in a job search and offer specific steps you can take to make your personal job search less stressful and more productive.

SECTION OBJECTIVES

- Understand networking and its value in a job search.
- Identify multiple methods to create and expand your network.
- Determine ways to effectively engage your network contacts.
- Learn how to use online social networking in your job search.
- Create or enhance your LinkedIn profile.



PRO TIP:

CONNECT WITH YOUR NETWORK

Since most positions are filled through personal and professional connections, networking is fundamental in getting the job you want.

WHAT IS NETWORKING?

You have likely heard the expression, “it’s not what you know, it’s who you know,” and the sentiment still rings true in today’s job market. To date, networking remains the number one job-search method. Knowing the right people can increase your chances of getting hired.

Networking is the process of interacting with others to exchange information and develop relationships. Members of the military are often very familiar with the tactics of networking.

At times, locating your next assignment or transferring to a new unit, depends on the individual service member. You have had to negotiate moving to unknown areas, locating personal services, transportation, and more. Depending on where you are, finding resources can be simple or challenging.



Did You Know?

According to HubSpot, a top resource for business and career insights, 85% of jobs are found through networking. (https://www.apollotechnical.com/networking-statistics/)

When searching for a job, the people in your network can help you find opportunities and conduct research. That knowledge will enable you to target your resume, online applications, and answers to interview questions to match an employer’s needs and priorities.

Networking is not the same as asking for a job. It is important to remember that networking is a mutually beneficial process. You never know when your skills and resources can prove to be beneficial to others in your network.

Every single person that you know, meet, and interact with is a possible member of your network. People will play varying roles in your network by providing access to different information, resources, or connection opportunities.

The good news is that you already have a network of people in your contacts that can help you with your employment process.

Many networking experts will also tell you to be a good networking contact by providing helpful resources and sharing information with your network on a continual basis. You do not want to be seen as the person who only gets in contact when you are in a job search. You may be surprised how much you regularly gain from your network.



ACTIVITY 4.1: EXPAND YOUR NETWORK

In the EFCT course, you identified the people currently in your network. Now, let’s focus on growth. Brainstorm ways you can intentionally expand your professional network and turn those ideas into steps.

In the space below, list at least three new networking opportunities you will pursue, and the specific actions you need to take to establish those new connections.

WAYS TO EXPAND NETWORK		ACTIONS TO TAKE
EX. Follow ABC Company on LinkedIn	:	Create LinkedIn Account
1. _____	:	_____
2. _____	:	_____
3. _____	:	_____

REACHING YOUR NETWORK

You are armed with a list of people to contact; now what? How will you contact them and what will you say?

You can build a more effective network by connecting with people in three ways:

1. **Informal networking**: Connecting with people that you already know, such as your former colleagues, high school and college friends, former supervisors, in-laws, etc.
2. **Formal networking**: Connecting with people that you do not know at structured events such as a networking event, professional association, or career fair.
3. **Online networking**: Connecting with people through a variety of online social media platforms.



Quick Tip

At the end of this guide, there are a variety of examples of networking emails used to connect with colleagues in different situations.

We will explore how you can connect with the right people by using the power of networking through formal, informal, and online settings.

INFORMAL NETWORKING

You learned in your EFCT course that knowing the right people can help you reach your career goals faster. We also identified a few types of networking you can use in your job search.

Now, we are going to cover some of the actions you should take to maintain and expand your employment network. Use the following tips to reach out to people and let them know you would like them to be a part of your network.

Ask for Referrals from Your Current Network

The easiest way to expand your network is to ask your current friends, family, and associates to introduce you to people they know who could be beneficial for you to connect with. The “friend-of-a-friend” connection is a great way to start introducing yourself to others. You can use email, phone, or a conversation to connect with people you already know.

Example Conversation Starter -

“I am starting a job search and want to explore opportunities in logistics. If you have any suggestions on a good person to speak with in the field or a place to explore more, I would appreciate the advice.”

Contact Former Coworkers, Supervisors, and Businesses

Don't forget to reconnect with former colleagues, supervisors, and businesses you worked with in the past. These people all had a relationship with you before and could again—you simply need to reconnect with them.

Example Conversation Starter -

"How are things with you? I am entering the job market and would appreciate any direction or referrals you might wish to share. I'd like to continue working in the X-ray technician field. It is great to stay in contact with you."

Contact Your Local American Job Center

Your local American Job Center (AJC) already has a network of people that can assist you in your transition. You can leverage the services and personnel available at the AJC to expand your network quickly. Use CareerOneStop to locate your local AJC. (https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/AmericanJobCenters/find-american-job-centers.aspx)

Contact Your Schools

Your former professors and colleagues have an extensive network within the college, community, and thousands of alumni. They want you to be successful because you are a product of their institutions, so they can be a great resource for you.

Example Conversation Starter - At an alumni event.

"The majority of my work experience is in intelligence. I have just started looking for job opportunities in this area. Would you happen to have any connections or leads in the intelligence field?"

Volunteer

Many service members and spouses volunteer countless hours with military, educational, nonprofit, and charitable organizations. Volunteering provides valuable experience, helps develop new skills, and can lead to career opportunities. It also fills employment gaps in your resume and shows productive use of your time. Volunteering is an opportunity to help others and meet new people who share your same passion. Since you volunteered with them, it is an easy way to connect with them and tap into their networks.

Example Conversation Starter -

"I have really enjoyed volunteering here and I have learned a lot. I was wondering if there may be any positions opening up in this area that I could apply for?"

While you are volunteering, be aware that other volunteers have jobs elsewhere. You may know your network contact from a mutual volunteer atmosphere, but they could be working in a field you are interested in. Have conversations with your fellow volunteers.

Example Conversation Starter -

"What do you do when not volunteering here? I am leaving active-duty service soon and am exploring different career fields to see where my skills might be a good fit."

CONDUCT INFORMATIONAL INTERVIEWS

Another great strategy for connecting with people is to conduct informational interviews. The EFCT workshop introduced informational interviews as a way to research companies and career fields. You can also use them to learn about a specific job opening or make contacts at a particular company.

To set up an informational interview, you must first find contacts who are willing to discuss their occupations and career paths with you. You should start by asking people in your network for contacts in a field, company, or job that interests you. Your local AJC will have local business contacts, or you could join a professional organization in your field to build your contacts. Many nonprofit groups and support organizations offer mentoring and informational interviewing opportunities that help veterans, transitioning service members, and military spouses.

When you contact someone, be polite, concise, and clear about your request. You are asking for information from them and you want them to know you will be respectful of their time.

When you send an email to ask someone to make an introduction to their contacts, make sure you include a short description about yourself for the context of the introduction and why you want to be introduced to make it easy for your contact to pass along your information. You can find email examples in Appendix B.

More Information

Check out the following article from Berkeley.edu on, "The Value of Informational Interviewing." (https://voices.berkeley.edu/why-informational-interviews-are-crucial-your-network)

Example Conversation Starter -

"I understand we both share a background in the military. I am beginning my transition off of active duty next month. I am intrigued by the work that you do. Would you be willing to speak with me for 15 or 20 minutes to share more information about your field of work and any advice you might have for me?"

TIPS FOR SETTING UP INFORMATIONAL INTERVIEWS

Be prepared. Have a professional introduction ready. It's important to have a short, concise introduction describing yourself and what you are trying to do. (You developed your professional introduction in your EFCT course. Now it is time to put it to work.)

Be professional. Treat your contact with respect and be professional. On the day of the meeting, this includes being on time and respecting the time allotted. Don't ask about openings. Keep in mind that you are there to learn more about the industry you're interested in and ask for potential steps you can take for your next career move.

Ask questions. It is best to ask open-ended or follow-up questions during the interview. Examples: What general skills are required for this line of work? What do you like most about your work? What kind of advice would you give me regarding a career in this field?

Ask for advice. Ask for guidance on the next steps to take after the interview. You could ask what skill set is the most valuable in the field and if there is anything you can do or resources you can read in the meantime to make yourself a marketable candidate. Your contact may also know more people who can help you gain more knowledge about the field you are interested in. Finally, ask if you can follow up with future questions should you need their help.

Express your gratitude. After the interview, don't forget to send a thank-you email or letter, ideally within 24 hours. Don't forget to follow up in a few weeks or so with updates regarding your job search and other details your contact might be interested in knowing. This will help you nurture the relationship with this person. Once you land a job, reach out to everyone who has helped you along the way, thank them, and ask how you can help them in return.

ACTIVITY 4.2: EXPLORE INFORMATIONAL INTERVIEWS

Who might be a good resource for an informational interview? (For example: someone who currently works for X company, someone doing the job currently, or a hiring manager.)

What three or four questions would you plan to ask? You can also leverage AI to help you brainstorm some questions.

FORMAL NETWORKING

Formal networking is a chance to meet people in your planned profession and in your local area. There are many groups that allow you to easily join and meet others. Here are a few examples of groups ready-made for formal networking.

JOIN YOUR PROFESSIONAL OR TRADE ORGANIZATIONS

Joining professional or trade organizations is an excellent way to connect with people who share the same professional interests and goals as you. Once you're a member, you may receive access to the membership list, which can open many new prospective network contacts. Most organizations also run regional or national meetings and conferences. This is another opportunity to grow your network as you learn new industry information or gather continuing education credits, if required. Always make sure to follow up with an email after meeting any new contacts, ideally within 24-48 hours. You can find follow-up example emails in Appendix B.

Be aware that many of these organizations may have membership fees and most require time to attend meetings and become involved. You cannot join them all, nor do you want to. Most organizations allow a few meetings before they request you join. As you attend initial meetings, remember you are assessing the organization to determine if it is a good fit.

Here are a few talking points when at a networking event, "Have you been here before?" is a great question to start a conversation and learn more about the organization, group, or event. If the response is yes, a follow-up question would be, "This is my first meeting. What do you enjoy about this group?"

If the response is no, a follow-up would be to ask, "This is my first meeting also, what do you know about this organization?"

When you need to get out of a conversation, an easy explanation is an honest approach. You can explain, "I know we both are here to meet people and network. I am going to continue to circulate, and I hope to speak with you again before the event is over."

FIND A MENTOR

Often, people confuse mentoring with coaching and counseling. Mentoring is a long-term relationship focused on supporting the growth and development of the mentee. The mentor draws on their knowledge and experience to assist the mentee with achieving their professional goals.

A mentor is someone with experience who can help you with career guidance and connect you with their professional contacts. Their support is invaluable—not just in the employment process, but they can assist you in your professional development as well.

The DOW TAP Managing Your Transition course and the DOL VETS Resource Guide have more information on mentors, including how to find a mentor and characteristics of a good mentor. (https://dol.gov/DOLEWmaterials)

A mentor will dedicate some of their time investing in your success. To be a good mentee, you will need to:

- Be focused and dedicated to your success.
- Be open to feedback from your mentor.
- Be a good listener.
- Have a well-defined career goal.
- Commit to your appointments/meetings with your mentor.
- Be accountable for your actions and inactions.

Example Conversation Starter -

"Thank you for taking the time out to collaborate with me. I am reaching out to you because you are currently working in the field of Cyber Security which I am interested in pursuing. I admire your hard work and dedication towards your career goals. For that reason, I wanted to ask if you would agree to be my mentor in order to get me on the right track?"

ATTENDING NETWORKING EVENTS AND JOB FAIRS

Networking events are a great way to build connections with business leaders. These events are all about networking, so people that attend these events are more than happy to connect with you and others.

Job, career, and resource fairs can be held in person or online. Look for virtual job fairs advertised on social media platforms. There are dozens of events targeted specifically for transitioning service members.

There are several event types to consider. They are presented to the public with different goals and levels of direct impact on a job search.

Job fairs are targeted at finding candidates to fill positions available with the employers attending the event. Job fairs give you an opportunity in a single location to network with multiple employers who are actively hiring. Some events are quite large, with a collection of employers from a variety of industries, while others can be smaller and targeted to a particular industry or profession.

Career fairs typically target a specific profession or industry. Career fairs provide many great opportunities to meet new employers or check out education and training possibilities relevant to the fair's target industry or profession. These events are not exclusively centered on finding a job or filling a particular position. However, this does not change your networking focus. Establishing contacts and gathering information are the goals at these events. You should not go into a career fair with the expectation that you will leave with a job offer. You will most likely be referred to the employer's human resources department or job listing website.

Resource fairs are a convenient way to gather information on what is available in your community on a topic of interest to the public. Resource fairs offer resources, materials, programming, activities, giveaways, video, speakers, and more in one location. Attendees at a resource fair are not typically job-seekers, but you will be able to tap into local organizations that offer help and information related to the theme of the fair. A medic or nurse, for example, might consider attending a health resource fair since they are a good place to begin meeting folks who work in healthcare or other related support industries.

ACTIVITY 4.3: ONLINE SEARCH

A quick online search can reveal many events that may be interesting to you. Search for events targeted toward transitioning service members, veterans, and spouses.

Record your findings of virtual or live job, career, or resource fairs here:

_____

_____

_____

_____

GENERAL TIPS FOR ALL NETWORKING EVENTS

To succeed at any networking events such as job and career fairs, you must prepare in advance by polishing your professional introduction, researching the companies you are interested in, and developing a plan of action. It is not possible to talk to every one of the companies in attendance, so you will have to choose your top five to ten and focus your efforts on meeting and connecting with those company representatives.

BEFORE THE EVENT

1. **Register**. Although it is not always required, having your name on the list of pre-registered attendees shows professional courtesy to both fair organizers and exhibiting employers.
2. **Review the career fair exhibitor/employer list online**. The organizers will advertise which employers are attending the fair. Choose the top organizations you want to connect with.
3. **Set a goal**. Attend the event with the purpose of making the best use of your time. Have a plan for how to interact with other attendees. For example, set a goal to meet new people and exchange names to connect on LinkedIn.
4. **Research**. Study who will be coming to the event. Look at their LinkedIn or other social media profiles and prepare a few questions to ask.
5. **Prepare and practice**. Practice your professional introduction and prepare specific talking points.
6. **Polish your resume.** If you have a specific organization of interest and the organization will be at the event, prepare a targeted resume and have it available. Confirm your resume includes all your contact information, customized LinkedIn URL, and goes back up to 10 years.
7. **Research participating employers.** Find out ahead of time which employers hire people with your skills. Many virtual fairs will send you a list and information on the employers attending. Go to their websites and see what job openings they have posted. Check them out on social media.
8. **Make a list of questions for employers.** Ask about how they recruit and hire people with your skill set. The following are sample questions:
    - What types of strengths and experience do you look for in new hires?
    - Are there any particular positions the company is focused on hiring?
    - How long is the application and interview process? What does it consist of?
    - May I contact you with further questions? Do you have a business card?
    - May I connect with you on LinkedIn?

9. **Questions you should avoid asking:**
    - How much is the pay? (This assumes you have been offered a position.)
    - What does your company do? (This communicates you have not done your research.)
10. **Dress professionally.** Dress in a way that will leave a good impression on the companies and their representatives. Even if participating online, being dressed for work will help you communicate professionally.

DURING THE EVENT

1. **Use a name tag**. When you sign into the event, name tags are usually provided. If you have to write it yourself, make sure it is very legible.
2. **Mingle**. Arrive early to meet other early attendees.
3. **Seek out the event coordinator**. It is a good idea to thank them.
4. **Introduce yourself**. Use a very short, tailored version of your professional introduction when meeting new people.
5. **Network with job seekers**. Talk and connect with other job seekers at the job fair to expand your network.
6. **Provide help to others**. Share a related resource. You will be amazed how helpful that can be.
7. **Get contact information**. Obtain names, personalized LinkedIn URLs, or ask to scan their LinkedIn QR code. You can connect with recruiters and employer representatives during or after the event.
8. **Have supplies**. Keep copies of your resume ready to hand out. You will want easy access to a pen and paper for notes, and a watch to keep track of time. A nice portfolio will be easy to handle, keeps your resumes accessible, provides a convenient pad for writing, and stores papers you collect from other employers. You can write notes about a person or company on the back of their business card to help you remember facts.
9. **Meet and repeat names**. Use a person's name three times in conversation after being introduced to help you remember their name.

AFTER THE EVENT

1. **Follow up**. Send an email or LinkedIn request within 24 hours. If a recruiter requests you to connect with them on LinkedIn or send them an email, do so within 24 hours.
2. **Reach out for future openings.** Many recruiters are associated with large companies and know about nationwide openings.



Quick Tip

Connect with and follow potential employer companies on social media.

TIPS SPECIFIC TO IN-PERSON NETWORKING EVENTS

We have provided you with general tips for all types of networking events. Here are some tips to consider when attending a face-to-face event.

BEFORE THE EVENT

1. **Check the location address.** Once you have registered, you should receive the location. Map it out to ensure you are familiar with the area. If you are able, go check out the location ahead of time. You may find out there are parking restrictions you need to be aware of.
2. **Practice your professional introduction**. The more you practice, the more confident you will feel. And your delivery will be more polished at the job fair.

DURING THE EVENT

1. **Keep a hand free.** If appropriate to shake hands, then you will want to leave your right hand free to do so.
2. **Give a warm greeting.** If appropriate, begin by accepting a handshake, and maintain eye contact. Thank the representatives/recruiters for being at the event.
3. **Get business cards.** Collect business cards so you have the contact information for the recruiters you met at the event. Ask for the names or contact information of the hiring managers. You can write notes on the back of a business card to help you remember information.
4. **Be aware that virtual business cards are also in circulation.** These can be received either by email or by transfer using your smartphone's Bluetooth or Near Field Communication (NFC) capability. Check how to set up your Bluetooth or NFC for transferring data between two devices. You will then be ready to receive and send virtual versions of business cards. You should also create one for yourself. This is typically done using your phone's contact phonebook by adding an entry for yourself into the contact listings. LinkedIn profiles include a scannable QR code to quickly share your profile or request a connection.
5. **Work the room.** Walk around and meet new people —don't settle into your "comfort zone" by spending all your time with people you already know.

TIPS SPECIFIC TO VIRTUAL NETWORKING EVENTS

Many in-person career fairs have been replaced by virtual events. With so many events occurring on virtual platforms, the following additional tips will be useful for those networking environments to maximize the successful outcomes of your virtual career fair experience:

BEFORE THE EVENT

1. **Follow all instructions.** After registering, you will likely receive an email filled with helpful information such as time to log in, requesting a resume by a certain deadline, and creating an account on the job fair app so that you can access all the features. Be sure to read the entire email.
2. **Create your profile.** Many job fairs will encourage you to create a profile to make it easier to share information with potential employers. Complete this step well in advance of the event so you are not rushed.
3. **Adjust your professional introduction.** You may need an abbreviated introduction for the event if you are limited to text and chat. Have your professional introduction ready to copy and place in the chat window.
4. **Check your technology.** Confirm your camera and audio work before the job fair begins. Have a practice call with a colleague and ask what they notice in your camera view.

DURING THE EVENT

1. **Get there early.** Arrive early to sign in, check your connection, and review the platform.
2. **Attend the entire time.** Do not leave your computer unattended during the event. Your inattentiveness sends a poor message. If you are not speaking, remember to mute your microphone.
3. **Be present.** Look at the camera when you speak. You can remind yourself with sticky notes to…Smile. Keep it relevant. Use nods for nonverbal communication. Watch language cues.
4. **Seek out employers.** Make a point to meet any employers you have sent a resume to prior to the event. Confirm they have your contact information by placing it in their chat. Make your meeting memorable.
5. **Provide your contact information.** Have your contact information ready on a Word document so you can easily copy and place it into a chat window.
6. **Use your camera and audio, if possible.** Seeing you brings credibility and builds rapport.
7. **When on camera, keep your background neat.** Be aware of the full view of your background and what employers might be able to see. Look into the camera when you speak to employers. Avoid using green screen virtual backgrounds; some people find these backgrounds distracting.
8. **Use the chat feature.** Connect with other job seekers. They may have valuable information to assist your search. You may need to wait to speak with an employer or recruiter. You can use the chat to leave your contact information.

SOCIAL NETWORKING ONLINE

Social media is a mainstream tool even in business, as it allows employers to recruit and screen potential candidates. You can also take advantage of social media to network with potential employers on their company websites. It is becoming standard for the employers you contact or people you meet at networking events to search for you online. A complete absence of information about you or demonstrations of inappropriate behavior or questionable content (including pictures, stories, or comments) may raise concerns.

ACTIVITY 4.4: ONLINE PRESENCE

Take a few minutes to google yourself and see what pops up. What would a potential employer see if they googled you?

You can strengthen your job search and increase your networking capacity by using the following strategies for leveraging your social media networking capabilities:

1. Create an online profile on your chosen social media website. You can control your privacy settings or may even choose to have separate private and professional accounts.
2. Ensure the information you provide on each site is accurate and up to date.
3. Use your social networks to locate employment opportunities.
4. Take advantage of social media to learn more about the companies you are targeting and to identify the hiring decision makers in those companies. Many companies create posts to announce job openings through their social media sites.
5. Allow social media sites to work for you by setting your job preferences and creating job search alerts to receive a notification when positions that meet your job/work preferences are added to the site.
6. Connect with hiring decision makers, either directly by using the messaging tools within a social media site or by arranging for an introduction through someone in your network. Once you're a member of a social media networking site, you'll immediately be provided with strategies for adding friends and new connections.

Here are some specific tactics for making the most of four widely used social media sites: Facebook, X, Instagram, and LinkedIn.

FACEBOOK (HTTPS://FACEBOOK.COM)

1. If you currently use Facebook primarily for keeping in touch with family and friends, realize that all your contacts and the people they know may have information that could help you identify employment opportunities and learn more about those opportunities.
2. Do not keep your job search a secret. Let everyone with whom you are connected on Facebook know about the type of work you are seeking and the skills and knowledge you can offer an employer.
3. Scrub your Facebook posts and messages to ensure any of your personal posts that may be compromising in one way or another are hidden from public view.
4. Although you may want to restrict access to much of your Facebook profile to friends and family, consider making your employment information and education available to everyone, including employers who may be researching you.
5. Ensure the information in the "About" section of your Facebook page is accurate, up-to-date, and professional.
6. Use Facebook's search feature to determine if a company you are targeting has a Facebook page. If so, "like" the company, explore their content and possible job opportunities.

ACTIVITY 4.5: FACEBOOK GROUPS TO FOLLOW

Name three Facebook groups to follow during your job search.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

X (HTTPS://X.COM)

1. Ensure your X handle (username) is professional.
2. Create a profile that emphasizes your relevant experience.
3. The hashtag symbol is X's way of identifying topics or keywords. Use this feature to search for things of interest, including internships, apprenticeships, job fairs, or jobs (#apprenticeships, #internships, etc.).
4. When you have identified companies or hiring decision makers you would like to know better, check to see if they have an account on X (you may have to ask for their X handle to locate them), and "follow" them.
5. Demonstrate your professional interests and knowledge by periodically reposting relevant articles or content you discover.
6. To strengthen relationships with specific people, reply to their posts, repost their posts, or use the direct message tool to contact them.
7. Participate in chats (online conversations) or online forums related to professional topics that are of interest to you.
8. If you are going to attend a networking or professional development event or job fair and the event publicizes a hashtag, use X to connect with people online that you would like to meet face-to-face at the event.

INSTAGRAM (HTTPS://INSTAGRAM.COM)

1. Create a professional Instagram account.
2. Fill out your profile branding yourself and your talents.
3. Make sure your account is set to public.
4. Use as a visual resume for your skills, experience, and strengths.
5. Use a professional headshot for your bio picture.
6. Search for hashtags like #resumewriting, #nowhiring, #hiring, #jobs, or #jobsearch.
7. Post content related to your field/showcase your work.
8. Use hashtags to bring attention to your posts such as #jobsearch.
9. Create videos to display a project you are working on.
10. Find and follow companies you are interested in.
11. Interact with companies by commenting and tagging their posts.
12. Make sure everything you post is workplace appropriate.
13. Learn about companies you are going to interview with by closely following them on Instagram. During the interview, mention things you saw, such as an event posted.

LINKEDIN (HTTPS://LINKEDIN.COM)

LinkedIn is the world's largest professional online network and is an effective way to reach people inside and outside of your existing networking circles, background, and industry.

To get an idea of how widespread LinkedIn has become, here are some statistics as of 2024: LinkedIn has over 1.15 billion members across more than 200 countries. The platform features 67 million companies, with 70% of recruiters utilizing it for sourcing candidates. Every minute, 7 users get hired via LinkedIn.

Quick Tip

You must create a LinkedIn Basic account before you can upgrade your subscription to the Premium account for free.

- A basic LinkedIn account is free.
- You will need a basic profile before you can upgrade your subscription from a free account to the Premium account. Premium LinkedIn accounts are subscription-based.
  - Active-duty, guard, and reserve receive a one-year complimentary Premium subscription. (Subject to change)
  - Veterans receive a one-year complimentary Premium subscription. (Subject to change)
  - Spouses of service members receive a one-year complimentary Premium subscription and if they have experienced a permanent change of station or separation from the military within the last six months, may also be eligible for an additional free one-year. (Subject to change)
  - Use the following URL for all the complimentary LinkedIn Premium subscription Registration options. (https://socialimpact.linkedin.com/programs/veterans?utm_source=shortlink)
- LinkedIn Premium Career gives you the following additional features:
  - InMail Messaging so you can contact anyone, even if you're not connected.
  - Ability to see everyone who has viewed your profile over the last 90 days.
  - Top Applicant feature to see a list of jobs where you're a great fit.
  - Competitive Insights on people who are applying to the same job as you.
  - LinkedIn Learning, which is an online educational platform that helps you discover and develop business, technology-related, and creative skills through more than 16,000 expert-led courses. You can also choose to add these courses and related skills to your LinkedIn profile once you complete them.

ACTIVITY 4.6: LINKEDIN BASIC ACCOUNT SETUP

For those who have not created a LinkedIn Basic Account, let's take five minutes to create one.

STEP 1: Access the LinkedIn homepage, (https://www.linkedin.com/home). Then select Join now.

STEP 2: Complete the required information and select Agree & Join. Remember to use an email address that you will have access to after you separate from the military.

LINKEDIN PROFILES

Building a strong LinkedIn profile helps expand your network. LinkedIn makes suggestions based on the commonalities between your profile information and other LinkedIn members. For example, if you worked at the same company or attended the same school, LinkedIn suggests that person as a possible connection. So, building a LinkedIn profile helps you connect with people you may not have considered.

A strong LinkedIn profile aids in your job search too. Listing skills and using keywords in your profile allows the LinkedIn Job Alert feature to find you when your details match a job posting. Recruiters use the same tactics on LinkedIn to search for viable candidates for open job positions. Creating a detailed profile brings opportunities to you.

A LinkedIn profile has sections closely related to your resume. Ensure the content you include on your LinkedIn profile aligns with your master resume. Recruiters do not want to be blindsided by a candidate they send to a hiring manager because the experience on the resume does not reflect the same experience in their LinkedIn profile.

LinkedIn profile sections include:

- Profile Intro
- Photo
- Name
- Headline
- Current Position
- Education
- Location
- Industry
- Contact Information
- About (Summary Statement)
- Experience
- Education
- License and Certification
- Skills and Endorsements
- Recommendation

PROFILE INTRO

Your profile intro is a snapshot of who you are. It includes your background image, profile photo, name, headline, current position, education, location, and contact information. Make this snapshot stand out for the right reasons. Ensure your profile intro represents your professional brand.

Background Image

Our brains are hardwired to notice images first, so your background image is your first chance to grab attention. It is an opportunity to project your professional brand and make your profile more visually appealing to recruiters and future employers. Add a background image that reflects your interests, profession, or a milestone in your career.

Follow these tips when creating your background image:

- Follow LinkedIn's suggested file formats and sizes and take advantage of LinkedIn's filters to create a clean, professional image.
- Use an image that stands out and represents your brand. Remember to keep it professional.

Profile Photo

Recruiters spend approximately six seconds looking at your profile intro to determine if you are a candidate they want to read more about. Your photo is the first thing they see. Recruiters look for approachable candidates they feel comfortable sending to hiring managers. This photo is a visual representation of you and your professional brand.

Follow these tips when choosing your profile photo:

- Use a recent photo that looks like you. We all have more flattering photos of ourselves from years past but misrepresenting yourself may make potential employers question your credibility. Make certain your face takes up approximately 50-60% of the frame to ensure you are visible in the frame and not a distant, unrecognizable figure.
- Dress career-appropriate. This may mean business casual for you. Do not overdress or underdress for your career field. If it is not acceptable at work, then it is not acceptable in your profile photo. We suggest you do not wear a military uniform in your photo. Dress for the job that you want.
- Be the star—appear alone. You would not take your child or a pet to an interview, so do not include them in your profile photo unless their presence is applicable to your career, like a pet-grooming service. Remember, this site is dedicated to professional networking. Save the personal photos for other social media sites.
- Take a clean, professional photo. You do not have to pay for a professional photo shoot for a profile photo. Just ensure certain quality markers are met:
  - Good lighting
  - Simple background
  - Clean, crisp images (no distortion or blurry images)

Name

To make it easier for people to find you, use the same name on LinkedIn you use when you introduce yourself. For some, that might be a nickname or shortened version of a proper name. Use the **Former Name** field to add previous names, or nicknames, if you choose to display your full name and nickname together. Only include your name in the **Name** field—do not put contact information (phone numbers, emails, etc.) Use the **Pronunciation** feature if your name is difficult to pronounce or does not read in English like it is spelled.

Headline

The headline not only shows up on your profile, but also in the home feed every time you post or publish content on LinkedIn. You have a limited number of characters in the Headline field to draw potential connections and future employers to your profile content. Ensure it accurately represents your professional brand.

The following four examples are headlines from LinkedIn Profiles:

- Connector | Cross-Functional Team Builder| Coach | Proud Marine Spouse
- Accountant | Data Analytics
- Web Designer | Graphic Design | Photography
- Career Coach | Outplacement | Job Search Specialist | Employer Branding | Human Resources



ACTIVITY 4.7: DRAFT YOUR HEADLINE

Follow these tips for your headline:

- Include your role. This may include your title and/or what you do.
- Recall that you did this similar exercise with your resume headline, however it was more targeted to the job posting.
- Use keywords for your industry. Recruiters use keywords to search for potential candidates on LinkedIn. The system searches based on how many times the keywords appear in a profile and if they appear in the headline. When the keywords are in the headline, you have a better chance of moving up in the search results. Choose your top skills for your career and include them in your headline.
- Use vertical bars (|) to separate titles, phrases, and top skills. Because you are including job titles, keywords, skills, and phrases that might not necessarily link, ensure you separate each with a space, vertical bar, and another space. (Find the vertical bar key under the backspace key on your keyboard.)

If you do not have access to LinkedIn, write your headline in the following space.

_____

_____

_____

Current Position and Education

Current **Position** and **Education** fields in this "edit intro" section will automatically transfer any experience and education you add here to the **Experience** and **Education** sections lower in your profile. Displaying your education is optional. Ensure you choose the correct company and school when completing the **Education** and **Experience** sections.

Recruiters and hiring managers can select the company logo to go directly to your experience at that company and select the company logo again to go to the company's LinkedIn profile.

Location

Members who include their location receive up to 19 times more profile views, and including the city makes it more likely to be found by members in your professional community. This includes connections, recruiters, and potential employers.

Recruiters search for candidates by location, so this strategy is a personal decision you need to make. Keep in mind, when you add job preferences to your profile, you have the option to add multiple locations.

Industry

Although industry does not appear on your profile info, it is working hard on the back end for you. Over 300,000 people search by industry each week.

Complete this field to make it easier for potential employers and other LinkedIn members to find you.

Contact Info

Include websites, email, and other contact information or social media sites you want displayed. Only include professional contact information.

ADDITIONAL LINKEDIN SECTIONS OVERVIEW

Later, when you have additional time, access your LinkedIn account and continue to enter information for the other sections. You can copy and paste information from your resume into the appropriate locations, if applicable.

- **About (Summary Statement)**
  - The summary is the number one profile section recruiters view on LinkedIn. It is the LinkedIn equivalent of your professional introduction or elevator speech; it differs only in length. Where your elevator speech is short enough for a brief elevator ride, your summary statement needs to be longer. In fact, a LinkedIn summary requires a minimum of 40 words for your profile to appear in recruiter searches. It is okay to use personal pronouns here (I, me, my), which can show your personality.
  - Example 1: I love writing code. Ever since writing my first program in Python and manipulating it to produce a desired output, I have been obsessed with the idea of using software to solve practical problems. Software engineering is a never-ending puzzle that…
  - Example 2: I'm a passionate educator and instructional designer, dedicated to improving educational opportunities for everyone and revolutionizing the education system. I believe it's critical to provide real-world, personalized, high-quality educational opportunities for everyone…

- **Experience**
  - Complete all fields so recruiters and potential employers see a full picture of your work experience. Ensure your experience on LinkedIn matches your resume.
  - Recruiters do not want to be surprised by unknowingly sending a candidate with a completely different resume to an interview with a hiring manager.
- **Education**
  - A profile with education listed gets 11 times more profile views. LinkedIn uses your schools to suggest connections and help you grow your network. Including your education also helps recruiters match you to job requirements.
  - Complete all applicable fields, but if you are not comfortable, you do not have to complete the dates on your degrees unless the date is an anticipated graduation date. Unless your degree was earned in the past five years, it is recommended you omit the date.
- **Licenses & Certifications**
  - Like other sections of LinkedIn, including your license and certifications ensures you will show up in more keyword searches and helps recruiters match you to job requirements.
  - Include all current licenses and certifications.
- **Skills**
  - You can list up to 50 skills in your profile. List skills that match the jobs or industry you are seeking and update them regularly.
  - According to LinkedIn, users who list at least five skills are contacted up to 33 times more by recruiters.
  - **Skills Endorsements**
    - When a connection endorses your skills, it promotes the strength of your profile and increases the likelihood that you will be identified for opportunities related to the skills you possess.
    - Your connections can go on your profile and endorse skills you have listed. Endorsing your connections' skills is way to validate the abilities they have identified on their profile.
- **Recommendations**
  - A LinkedIn recommendation is a personalized review or testimonial of someone's character, work, education, or accomplishments. This feature allows your contacts to display meaningful feedback on your profile. Like many other features, words used in your recommendation also help your LinkedIn search ranking.
  - To give a recommendation, go to the person's profile, select "more" next to "message," and select "recommend." You can also select "request recommendation" if you feel that person would be willing and is a good contact to provide a recommendation.



Quick Tip

When adding or editing in the Experience or Education sections, turn off the "Notify network" option at the top of the pop-up window.

When on, LinkedIn sends a notification to your entire network for each job you add to your profile. The feature's purpose is to alert your network when you have a promotion or job change, not to alert them to each step of your profile build.

ACTIVITY 4.8: PERSONALIZED LINKEDIN URL

LinkedIn offers an option to personalize your profile's web address (URL). A customized URL is significantly more professional than the long, autogenerated one. By removing the extra numbers and creating a simple, unique link, you make it easier to read, minimize typing errors, and provide a direct, clean reference for your resume and networking.

Click on the "Me" drop-down in the top bar and select View Profile. There you will see the option to update your Public Profile & URL. Ensure you include your name in the URL and keep it professional. Add your personalized LinkedIn URL to your resume. For example, linkedin.com/in/andrew-thompson2nd.

SET "OPEN TO" FEATURE

Let recruiters and others on LinkedIn know you are open to work with the "Open to" feature. Recruiters use the "Open to new opportunities" spotlight to prioritize candidates who are actively seeking positions. The "Open to" feature allows you to set the parameters with job titles, locations, start dates, and job types (full-time, contract, internship, etc.). Select the "I'm open to remote work" checkbox to show in recruiter searches for remote positions. Recruiters use the "Employment type" filter to find candidates for specific job types, so ensure you select all job types that apply to you. You have the option to make your "Open to Work" status visible to recruiters only or to all LinkedIn members; sharing it with your network maximizes the potential for discovering new opportunities.

LinkedIn offers numerous online tutorials for building your professional identity and creating a strong profile. As you create and develop your own profile, you can find helpful LinkedIn tutorials to assist you on the LinkedIn Help page. (https://www.linkedin.com/help/linkedin?lang=en)

More Information

The Department of Labor also offers two free workshops to help you build and make the most of LinkedIn's available resources. You are invited to take each of the free 2-hour LinkedIn workshops that DOL offers through the TEAMS Workshops: LinkedIn Profiles and LinkedIn Job Searches. (https://www.dol.gov/TEAMSworkshops)

Search LinkedIn Learning for free LinkedIn videos on building and improving your profiles, networking, and maximizing LinkedIn as a professional tool.

LINKEDIN RECRUITER VIEW

Recruiters and hiring managers not only use LinkedIn to research candidates who applied for open positions at their companies, but they also **actively search for viable candidates** on LinkedIn for those open positions.

LinkedIn features more than 20 million active job listings. Understanding how a recruiter searches for candidates and how LinkedIn displays those results helps you create a winning strategy for your job search.

Recruiter View

Much like an Applicant Tracking System (ATS), LinkedIn Recruiter uses search criteria to filter and rank candidates whose profiles best match a job's requirements.

Did You Know?

According to Product London, an online presence expert, nine out of ten employers use LinkedIn during the hiring process and 97% of Fortune 500 companies use LinkedIn for recruiting and sourcing talent. (https://productlondondesign.com/linkedin-statistics/)

Recruiters leverage every section of your profile to set these filters, searching by specifics like job titles, skills, locations, companies, schools, and employment type to quickly find the most relevant candidates.

CUSTOM FILTERS IN RECRUITERS' VIEW

Maximize your exposure to recruiters by following these tips to ensure your profile filters to the top of their search results.

Use keywords more than once throughout your profile. The more a keyword appears in your profile, the higher you are on a recruiter's search for that keyword. So, if someone's profile has Project Manager listed 12 times and yours has that keyword 15 times, you will appear higher in the search results. This applies to industry keywords, job titles, and skills. For example, if Data Analysis is one of your skills, ensure you include the keyword "Data Analysis" throughout your profile, including the **Skills** section, under individual job positions (e.g., in bullet points describing your achievements), and in your **About** section.

Include similar job titles for your previous positions (if applicable). Some job titles are standard throughout an industry and others vary by company. For instance, one company uses the job title Trainer while another uses Training Instructor. Another example is Project Lead, Task Lead, or Project Manager. List other job titles that encompass your role in the industry to appear in more searches. Remember to include relevant job titles in other sections of your profile, like the **About** section.

HOW SEARCH FILTERS WORK IN RECRUITER VIEW

Recruiters use advanced search filters to refine their search results. Recognizing how recruiters filter search results and find candidates like you, allows you to customize your profile for optimum reach.

NETWORKING SECTION REVIEW

In this section of the workshop, you have:

- gained an understanding of networking and its value in a job search.
- identified multiple methods to create and expand your personal network.
- determined ways to engage your network contacts.
- learned how to use online social networking in your job search.
- created or enhanced your LinkedIn profile.

5 Interviewing Skills

SECTION 5: INTERVIEWING SKILLS

SECTION OBJECTIVES

- Distinguish the different types of interviews.
- Recognize key aspects of before, during, and after the interview.
- Identify best practices of in-person and virtual interviews.

You've got an interview request! All the hard work you've put into researching careers, getting credentials, completing your resume, finding job postings, networking, applying online, and following up has paid off with an interview request. Congratulations!

While all the work you've done so far has been on your personal timeline (probably all hours of the day), an interview is an event in time involving others having a set beginning and an end. Because of these constraints, it is now important for you to focus on making that event a success.

This section of your employment workshop will provide information and activities you can use to build your interviewing techniques and confidence.

INTERVIEW TYPES & TIPS

Types of Interviews

A company interviews to find the right person for the job; an individual interviews to find the right company and job fit. As mentioned in the EFCT workshop, employers may conduct interviews in a multi-stage process that occurs in a variety of formats. Companies use the following methods to conduct interviews:

- Phone Interview
- Live Video Interview
- In-Person Interview
- AI Interviews

PHONE INTERVIEW

A phone interview is often the first step in the interview process. Prior to the phone interview, a company or recruiter may call to screen an applicant to verify basic qualifications for the position. A phone interview is typically more in depth than the screening call, asking traditional interview questions.

Phone Screening vs. Phone Interview

A phone screening is quick, can be unscheduled, and as short as 10 minutes. During the call, employers may verify basic qualifications, clarify outstanding application questions, or confirm your continued interest in the position. The goal of this screening call is to create a shortlist of qualified candidates.

Not every employer conducts a phone screening, but if your employer does, this is when it will be determined if you are qualified and whether you will move to the next phase of the hiring process.



Quick Tip

If you are driving and receive the call unexpectedly, pull over and give your full attention to the call. Multi-tasking is not appropriate during a screening call or an interview.

A phone interview may be conducted by a recruiter, the hiring manager, or multiple hiring decision-makers. During a phone interview, more in-depth traditional interview questions are asked and you have more of an opportunity to ask questions. Typically, a phone interview is scheduled in advance, often after the phone screening interview, giving you a chance to prepare. A phone interview can last 30 minutes or longer.

Suggestions to prepare for a successful phone interview:

1. Dress for the interview, as it creates a professional attitude that is not visible but comes through in your manner and voice over the phone.
2. Treat the phone interview as you would an in-person interview.
3. Be in a quiet place where you can concentrate and free from any interruptions.
4. Confirm your phone has good connection and ample charge.
5. Have your company, industry, and job research materials with you. However, be aware that some phones can pick up pages being shuffled in the background, so plan accordingly by laying out your pages so you can easily read them without the need to shuffle through them.
6. Mention your research during the interview to demonstrate your understanding of the business.
7. Smile during the call. Feel free to stand up. Both make a difference in the projection and quality of your voice.
8. While you can use notes during a phone interview, be sure your conversation is natural, not monotone, and you are not reading your notes word-for-word.

9. Have a copy of your resume on hand as the recruiter is going to have a copy and you would like to have the same information they have if they refer to something from your resume.

LIVE VIDEO INTERVIEW

Becoming increasingly popular, live video interviews take place online between the employer and the candidate.

1. Check your tech. Be very familiar with the software settings, webcam, and microphone.
2. Dress appropriately from head to toe.
3. Have a professional and uncluttered background.
4. Have appropriate lighting and do not sit with your back to a window.
5. Position the webcam at eye level so you are looking directly at the camera and can address the interviewer.
6. Do a trial run with a friend to ensure you can log in and your equipment works.
7. When confirming interview details, ensure you have a contact phone number for the company should you encounter trouble with the platform.
8. Be in a quiet room with no distractions, such as cell phones, clock chimes, pets, children, etc. Plan ahead of time if you may need an alternate location like a private room at the library or possibly at your AJC.
9. Have an electronic version of your resume available to share via email, screen share, or chat during the interview.

IN-PERSON INTERVIEWS

An in-person interview usually follows a successful phone interview. You can meet with one or multiple people at a time. Interviewers are typically recruiters or hiring managers. Prepare for a successful in-person interview with these suggestions:

- Scout the interview location the day before.
- Anticipate possible delays in traffic.
- Arrive at least 15 minutes early to your interview.

Whether your interview is in-person or virtual, there are a variety of interview types that you may experience. Next, we will go over the six most common types of interviews, but this list is not exhaustive.

PANEL INTERVIEW

A panel interview involves two or more interviewers sitting on a panel or committee (somewhat like a promotion or award board). Interviewers may include HR representatives, hiring managers, and team leads. The candidate answers questions from one or multiple people on the panel. Follow these guidelines to prepare for a panel or committee interview:

- Monitor your body language and eye contact. Be ready to maintain eye contact with the whole panel, paying slightly more attention to the person who asked the question.
- Bring a copy of your most recent resume for each person on the panel, a notebook, and a pen.
- If applicable, be prepared with professional examples of your work in a presentable folder or portfolio.

MEAL INTERVIEW

Meal interviews are often used for client-facing roles, allowing employers to observe your social skills in a less formal setting. While the atmosphere may feel relaxed, it's crucial to maintain your professionalism, as this remains a key part of the interview process.

Follow these guidelines for all meal interviews:

- Carefully select your meal (it should not be too pricey or too messy).
- Avoid ordering alcohol (even if the interviewer orders a drink first).
- Be polite to everyone you encounter, including all restaurant staff.
- Practice good manners.

GROUP INTERVIEW

A group interview includes multiple candidates. Employers mostly utilize this interview type when staffing numerous job openings at once, like hospitality jobs or seasonal retail jobs.

A group interview may serve as a screening for candidates and can be more like a presentation about the company and the challenges of the job. In this case, employers typically call candidates of interest back for an in-person or panel interview after the group interview. Follow these tips for a group interview:

- Bring copies of your resume, a notebook, and a pen.
- The employer may be evaluating how well you interact with others.
- Treat everyone you encounter with respect.

DEMONSTRATION OR WORKING INTERVIEW

Some interviews could involve you demonstrating a skill or working in a particular software application or even working in the employment environment for a trial run. The company will usually prepare you for the possibility of a demonstration of a skill if you must prepare beforehand, such as writing a sample speech or creating a culinary dish. Demonstrations can be a standard practice in some professions, such as welding. It is best to do your research, ask questions before your interview, and be prepared.

STRESS INTERVIEW

While a job interview is stressful already, some industries purposefully create additional stress to evaluate your response. Employers may want to test how you perform in stressful work environments, such as those that are regularly fast-paced or dangerous. For example, the ability to stay calm and clearly communicate with a caller is an essential element for an emergency dispatcher.

Extensive practice will pay off in these types of interviews. As you understand the reasoning for the stress interview, you can remain calm and show your skills and value to the employer. Stress interviews target roles demanding composure, quick decisions, and resilience under pressure, such as in law enforcement, emergency services, medicine, sales, customer service, management, consulting, and airlines.

You might even encounter some unexpected questions during an interview such as solving a puzzle or answering a challenging riddle. Most interviewers do not expect a candidate to intuitively know why a manhole cover is round; rather, these questions are designed to assess a candidate's thought process and reasoning skills. For reference, the round design primarily prevents the cover from accidentally falling through its own opening. Additionally, a circular cover is more efficient to replace, as it does not require precise alignment with the opening.

ON-THE-SPOT OR CAREER FAIR INTERVIEW

Many career or job fairs provide the opportunity for employers to conduct on-the-spot interviews. They are usually unscheduled and can be with a human resource representative instead of the hiring manager. The company may be screening many people over the course of the event. Always be prepared for a possible on-the-spot interview when attending hiring events.

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE IN INTERVIEWS

You may have attended an interview virtually via Skype, Zoom, or other platforms and talked with the interviewer via video or chat, but have you considered that your next interview might not be with an actual person?

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is an area of computer science that has developed intelligent machines, software, or applications that work and react like humans.

Be aware that some companies may ask you to pre-record your answers to questions through a software application and will use AI as one piece in the screening or evaluation method. Some popular platforms include HireVue, MyInterview, and SparkHire.

These questions are usually timed. For example, you may have roughly three minutes to record your response. If timed responses are a stressor for you, be prepared that an AI interview may have a countdown timer. The AI system dissects your video and judges your performance based on selected criteria set by the company.

Developers claim AI can analyze interview performance by assessing language (keywords, filler words, syntax) and non-verbal cues (face/eye movements, body language, speaking speed, tone, pitch) to infer aspects of mood, attitude, or potential deception. However, the validity and reliability of these assessments, particularly regarding complex human traits like honesty or internal emotions, remain subjects of ongoing research and debate, with some studies demonstrating limitations and potential for bias.

With this in mind, here are some things you should be paying attention to when interviewing with an AI:

1. **Smiling** – Show a pleasant countenance as you answer. It can be easy to forget to smile when you are focusing so hard on the questions but try to remember to relax a bit during the process and let some of your natural personality out.
2. **Eye contact** – Avoid appearing shifty by looking away quickly or outright not looking at the camera. Staring at a tiny lens can feel strange, but the more you practice the less it will bother you.
3. **Tone** – Articulate your words clearly with a neutral or bright tone.
4. **Talking Speed** – Prior to the actual interview, record yourself answering questions and review the video to help you evaluate if you are speaking too quickly, too slowly, or not articulating well.
5. **Body Posture** – Sit with an open posture. Appear relaxed, natural, and ready to handle any question.
6. **Keywords** – Using keywords is an essential part of any job application process, and AI algorithms are specifically designed to screen out any candidate that does not seem to be using them in their responses. However, be careful to not overdo or force their use.
    - Be sure to use their keywords specifically. For instance, if they mention experience with Facebook ads, mention Facebook ads in particular and not just social media management in general.
    - Do not try to out-smart the AI by rattling off a string of keywords without cohesion. Remember, you are likely to be evaluated by a live person eventually and getting past the AI in this way, ultimately, will not serve you well.
    - Include keywords in your STAR responses when you prepare them. Doing this will give you tight, solid answers with sufficient keywords without being incoherent.

Regardless of whether you are interviewed by a person or an AI, do your research and ensure you practice, practice, practice.

BEFORE THE INTERVIEW

Your resume gets you into the interview. A successful interview can get you the job. In this section, you will learn how research prepares you for a successful interview.

Throughout this and other workshops, we have explored the job search principle to *Think Like an Employer*. That principle is helpful to keep in mind as you progress through a job interview. For example: What skills or experience would an employer expect a well-matched candidate to explain during the interview when asked, “Why should I hire you?”

Preparing for interview success involves two categories of action: Research and Rehearse.



Quick Tip

You do not get a second chance to make a great first impression, so prepare well for your interview to increase your chances of landing your dream job.

RESEARCH

Before your interview, make sure you’re adequately prepared by researching the company. Though you researched the company before you applied, take the time to refresh your memory and do additional research.

Spend time on the company’s website and follow the company on LinkedIn, X, and Facebook.

Learn the history of the company by reviewing information on its website, usually found in a section labeled “About.” Search for recent articles about the company and find out about its core missions and values. The more you know, the more comfortable you will be in the interview.

You will use your newfound knowledge to better respond to specific questions that relate to the position. The research will also help guide you to create thoughtful and informative questions to ask during your interview. The best candidate questions come from your research.

Check their official website first, then move on to other sources. If there are any client, customer, or employee reviews, study them and identify any recurring themes that might alter your decision to work with them

Your goal when you do this research is to gain a knowledge of the following 10 areas:

1. **Highly valued experience and skills** - It is useful to gain some insight into the things the company looks for in ideal candidates. With this information, you can better highlight the qualities that make you the best candidate for the role. The experience and skills that the company values most can be found by carefully reading the job description and exploring the career page on the company’s site. You can often learn a lot by asking current employees about the employer as well.
2 **Customers, services, and products** - Learn the details of the company’s business. This will allow you to answer questions more effectively as well as ask thoughtful questions of your own. Candidates who are knowledgeable about what a company does and its target audience demonstrate that they are ambitious, organized, and truly interested in the position. You can learn about the company’s offerings and customer base by visiting their website, exploring their blogs, and studying the white papers, case studies, and marketing materials.

3. **Your interviewer** - If you know who will be interviewing you, learn a bit about them so that you can have a meaningful conversation and make a memorable connection.

   In many cases, the name of your interviewer is included in the email coordinating and supplying the details of your interview. If that information wasn't provided, you can always send a follow-up message asking for your interviewer's name.

   After you receive the name of the person who will be interviewing you, learn more about their role at the company, background, and even their interests by exploring the team page on the company's website and/or their professional profile on social media.

4. **Mission Statement** - An organization's mission statement describes its motivations for being in business and the values that give it purpose. You usually find this information on the company's website or in marketing materials. If you're having trouble finding a definitive statement, you could use the values they mention or how they portray themselves to determine the organization's primary motivations.

5. **History** - The company's current standing is important but having a basic knowledge of its past can help you gain a better understanding of its accomplishments, growth, and challenges. You discover important information regarding past business partners, acquisitions, changes in growth, modifications to policies, or processes due to new management. Use the information you gather to showcase your genuine interest throughout the interview.

6. **Competition** - Aside from knowing about the company you're interviewing with, you should also be aware of who their top competitors are. Interviewers will sometimes ask questions related to the company's competition to gauge your awareness of the industry, preparedness for the interview, and general expertise.

7. **Unique selling proposition** - In addition to researching the company's top competitors, spend some time determining its unique selling proposition. This is what makes their brand unique and helps them compete in the market. By showcasing your understanding of the company's market positioning, you highlight your expertise and genuine interest in the role.

8. **Culture** - Determining the company's culture allows you to understand their working environment and can be a great indication of the kind of employees they hire. To determine the culture of an organization, evaluate how the company talks about the workplace and employees on its social media profiles. This allows you to align yourself with the culture and better demonstrate that you are a good fit. For example: Is the company a casual and vibrant place? Mention that you value working in a creative atmosphere.

9. **Leadership** - Research the people that have important roles in the company, such as executives and upper management. Read the employee bios and the about page on the website to learn who holds the leadership positions within the company. You can then find them on social media and view their profiles to gain additional insight into the company and the roles they play.

10. **Latest mentions in the news** - It's a good idea to know the company's latest developments and news. Get a better idea of the recent achievements and challenges of an organization by checking to see if they have press releases on their site or by performing a simple search on the Internet.

PREPARE MATERIALS

When preparing for your interview, remember to gather your materials and place them in a folder or portfolio to keep them organized.

At a minimum, your folder or briefcase should contain:

- Pen and paper for note-taking (if permitted)
- Multiple copies of your current resume
- References (confirmed and ready to receive calls or emails about you)
- Copies of appropriate licenses and certifications
- Letters of recommendation (if available)

> *Several military-focused non-profits, such as your local AJC, Hire Heroes USA or USO, offer live interview practice with professionals in your chosen industry. Just sign-up for their free services.*

Think ahead for the interview. If the interviewer may require you to perform a task, ensure you are prepared. For instance, if you are applying for a job as a welder, the interviewer may ask you to demonstrate your skills on the spot. Have your work clothes and tools available at the interview.

PRACTICE INTERVIEWING

When rehearsing, keep the following points in mind:

1. The more you practice, the more comfortable you will be in the interview.
2. Practice your responses so you can reply confidently and naturally without sounding rehearsed or mechanical.
3. Do not memorize your answers; this can trip you up if you forget what you memorized.
4. Practice answering aloud and with another person.
5. Your goal during an interview is to build rapport and create a positive first impression.
6. Practice how you will relate your qualifications to the job requirements.
7. Practice questions you might have for employers. Choose the most important for you to have answered.
8. Practice how to exit the interview with another person. You want to end on a positive note.

Some tips to remember before your interview:

Prepare in private - Confident people are prepared. When you arrive at your interview, take time to gather your documents, put your phone on silent, and review any information before you enter the building. As soon as you walk inside, you will be interacting with company employees, and you immediately want to project confidence to them. Gather your thoughts and materials in a private place.

Be aware in the waiting room - Waiting for the interview to begin may seem like a great time to catch up on emails or send a text, but your time is better spent introducing yourself to the receptionist and waiting patiently.

Where to sit - When in the waiting room, choose a chair that gives you the best visibility of people coming and going so you won't be caught unaware by the interviewer. In the interview, if given a choice of seats, choose a seat that will allow you to maintain excellent posture and to comfortably make eye contact with everyone in the room.

Your personal items - If you have a briefcase or purse, set it on the floor by your side so you can easily shake hands with the interviewer when they walk in. If you plan to provide any documents or take notes, get those items out of your bag as soon as you enter the room, so you don't disrupt the flow of conversation.

The DOL VETS Resource Guide has interview resources from LinkedIn and Indeed. (https://dol.gov/DOLEWmaterials)

INTERVIEW ATTIRE

First impressions matter. Appropriate attire and grooming are critical. Research the company's dress code to choose the right interview attire. Ensure you dress one level above the position for which you are interviewing.

Consider the industry norms for dress.

- For a position in a more creative field, such as marketing or information technology, you can wear something smart casual.
- For a position in a trade industry, you should wear a nice casual shirt/blouse and trousers/skirt and take appropriate work gear with you if the employer has indicated you might be required to demonstrate your skills during the interview.
- An executive position or a position in a conservative industry, you should wear more traditional choices like tailored suits and dress shirts/blouses.

Choose clothing that you will feel comfortable and confident in.

Ensure your interview outfit fits well and presents a professional appearance. Do not wear clothes that are too tight, too loose, or uncomfortable to sit in; it will be distracting.

Use your best judgment. Do not overthink it. Inspect all pieces of clothing you plan to wear for stains, snags, pet hairs, and holes. Clothing should be pressed and wrinkle-free. Follow the examples shown in the table.

BUSINESS PROFESSIONAL

GENERAL	MEN	WOMEN
Suits - Choose a conservative solid or pinstripe suit. Colors most suitable for an interview include medium to dark gray, black, and navy blue. **Shirts** - Shirts and blouses should be white, cream, or pale blue, preferably a solid color without patterns. **Ties** - The tie should complement your suit. **Socks or Stockings** - Socks should complement the suit: blue, black, gray, or brown. **Shoes** - Shoes should be black, burgundy, or brown leather, depending on the color of the suit. **Accessories** - You may want to bring a professional portfolio to hold copies of your resume and to take notes. Avoid wearing religious or political insignias. Belts should complement or match the shoes you wear. **Jewelry** - Minimize the number of pieces and aim for subtlety. **Cologne & Perfume** - Avoid heavily scented cologne, perfume, or deodorants.	**Suits** - The best colors for suits are navy, black, and charcoal through light gray. **Shirts** - Always wear a long-sleeved shirt. **Ties** - Choose a classic, professional tie in a solid color or opt for a subtle pattern. Avoid overly bright colors or flashy designs. Tie knots should be small, and the tie should reach the belt. **Socks** - Socks are required and usually complement the pants. **Accessories** - Watches should be plain and simple. Avoid “smart watches” since they are connected to phones and notifications would be a distraction to you and the employer.	**Suits** - Also appropriate: Pants suit or a skirt with a coordinating solid black or navy jacket. One-piece business dress with matching jacket. Jacket should be long sleeve and able to be buttoned. Skirts should be no shorter than 2” above the knee. **Blouses** - Blouses should be solid in color, preferably white or cream. **Stockings** - Stockings or tights should complement the outfit. Avoid bright colors or patterns. **Shoes** - Shoes should be closed-toe pumps with low or mid heels. The best colors to wear are black, brown, and navy. **Accessories** - If you carry a briefcase, do not carry a purse. **Makeup** - Makeup should be natural and subtle.

BUSINESS CASUAL

GENERAL

Suits - Full suit and tie are not normally worn as daily attire in a business casual environment.

Shirts & Blouses - Colors should be conservative and appropriate based on research of the company.

Socks or Stockings - Socks should complement the pants: blue, black, gray, or brown.

Accessories - You may want to bring a professional portfolio to hold copies of your resume and to take notes.

Avoid wearing religious or political insignias.

Belts should complement or match the shoes you wear.

Jewelry - Minimize the number of pieces and aim for subtlety.

Cologne and Perfume - Avoid heavily scented cologne, perfume, or deodorants.

MEN

Suits - Seasonal sport coat, if desired. Slacks or khakis, but not jeans.

Shirts - Shirts with open collar such as a golf shirt or button front dress shirt.

Ties - A tie is not generally worn as daily attire, but may be a personal choice.

Socks - Socks are required and usually complement the pants.

Shoes - Shoes can be loafers and usually brown, black, or muted colors.

Accessories - Watches should be plain and simple. Avoid “smart watches” since they are connected to phones and notifications would be a distraction to you and the employer.

WOMEN

Suits - Can include a coordinated blazer or cardigan sweater, if desired. Dress, skirt, or pants are all acceptable. Skirts should be no shorter than 2” above the knee.

Blouses - Blouse or top should be solid in color.

Stockings - Stockings or tights should complement the outfit. Avoid bright colors or patterns.

Shoes - Opt for coordinated, well-fitting, close-toed shoes.

Accessories - If you carry a briefcase, do not carry a purse.

Makeup - Makeup should be natural and subtle.

SMART CASUAL

GENERAL	MEN	WOMEN
Suits - Suits are not normally worn as daily attire in a smart casual environment. **Shirts & Blouses** - Colors should be conservative and appropriate based on research of the company. **Socks or Stockings** - Socks should complement the pants: blue, black, gray, or brown. **Shoes** - Shoes, well fitting, not too worn. **Accessories** - You may want to bring a professional portfolio to hold copies of your resume and to take notes. Avoid wearing religious or political insignias. Belts should complement or match the shoes you wear. **Jewelry** - Minimize the number of pieces and aim for subtlety. **Cologne and Perfume** - Avoid heavily scented cologne, perfume, or deodorants.	**Suits** - Seasonal sport coat, if desired. Slacks, khakis, or dark wash jeans without distressing are appropriate. **Shirts** - Shirts with open collar such as a golf shirt or button front dress shirt. **Ties** - A tie is not generally worn as daily attire, but may be a personal choice. **Socks** - Socks are required and usually complement the pants. **Shoes** - Shoes can be loafers and usually brown, black, or muted colors. **Accessories** - Watches should be plain and simple. Avoid “smart watches” since they are connected to phones and notifications would be a distraction to you and the employer.	**Suits** - Can include a coordinated blazer or cardigan sweater, if desired. Dress, skirt, or pants are all acceptable. Skirts should be no shorter than 2” above the knee. **Blouses** - Designs and colors are more acceptable in a smart casual environment. **Stockings** - Stockings or tights should complement the outfit. Avoid bright colors or patterns. **Shoes** - Opt for coordinated, well-fitting, close-toed shoes. **Accessories** - If you carry a briefcase, do not carry a purse. **Makeup** - Makeup should be natural and subtle.

INTERVIEW ATTIRE CHECKLIST

☐ Research the company's dress code.

☐ Follow the examples shown on the previous pages.

☐ Choose clothing that you will feel comfortable and confident in.

☐ Use your best judgment. Do not overthink it.

☐ Avoid revealing clothing.

☐ Choose clothing appropriate to the climate and season.

☐ Inspect all pieces of clothing you plan to wear for stains, snags, pet hairs, and holes.

☐ Clothing should be pressed and wrinkle-free.

Once dressed and prepared, go to the interview. Your interview starts the moment you arrive on the company property.

- Arrive 10-15 minutes early.
- Turn off your phone, smart watches, or any other electronic devices that could be distracting.
- Be polite to every person you encounter.
- Dress for the occasion (including the weather).

BODY LANGUAGE

Body language is the way you communicate your feelings with your posture, gestures, facial expressions, and movements. It is an important indicator of your emotional state, comfort, confidence, and interest for interviewers.

Body language is usually subconscious, but with practice, you can learn to control your body language to create the best possible impression with those around you.

To make sure your body language indicates confidence, positivity, and interest, keep the following in mind during your next interview:

1. **Walking -** Walk smoothly and confidently between the waiting area and the interview room. Maintain your posture while walking and firmly hold on to your belongings so you don't drop anything.

2. **Breathe deeply** - Deep, even breaths calm the body and help reduce the desire to perform nervous actions like jiggling your leg or drumming on your arm.

3. **Handshakes** - You will likely shake hands with the interviewer. Your handshake should be a firm, whole-hand handshake and last a second or two, regardless of who you are shaking hands with. If you tend to have sweaty palms, carry a handkerchief and use it before you enter the interview site. Do not wipe your hands, either with the handkerchief or on your clothing, in view of the person you will be shaking hands with.

4. **Maintain good posture** - Be aware of your posture at all times. Good posture will help you listen and reinforce you are interested in the position. It also displays confidence. Sit up straight and lean forward toward the interviewer slightly. Keep your shoulders back and down and your chin lifted. Practice this posture regularly so it is comfortable for you. When you are in the actual interview, keep your posture as upright as possible, yet comfortable. Choose a straight-backed chair if possible.

5. **Use natural hand gestures** - Use your hands to talk if that is natural for you. Using natural gestures when you talk can also help you relax and convey enthusiasm. If you are seated at a table or desk for the interview, try to keep your hands visible.

6. **Use effective eye contact** - Make eye contact with the interviewer. If doing a virtual interview, look regularly into the camera. Many interviewers use your eye contact to look for enthusiasm, sincerity, and inconsistencies in your responses. However, eye contact should be moderated. Too little eye contact gives the appearance of nervousness, while too much is aggressive. Pretend you are having a comfortable conversation with a friend during the interview to guide your eye contact. Make eye contact with them regularly but look away when it feels natural to do so. Always maintain eye contact when shaking hands.

7. **Be responsive** - Show your interest in what the interviewer is saying by smiling, nodding, and leaning forward when they are speaking. This demonstrates you understand what the interviewer is saying and agree with their statements.

8. **Pay attention to the nonverbal cues from the interviewer -** The interviewer's facial expressions will let you know how well they are listening. If the interviewer is not attentive, shorten your answers, use an example, or ask a question.

9. **Leg position** - Your legs should be still and uncrossed if possible. Crossing your legs may become uncomfortable, meaning you will need to stretch them out during the interview. Consider crossing your legs at the ankles if you feel the need to cross your legs.

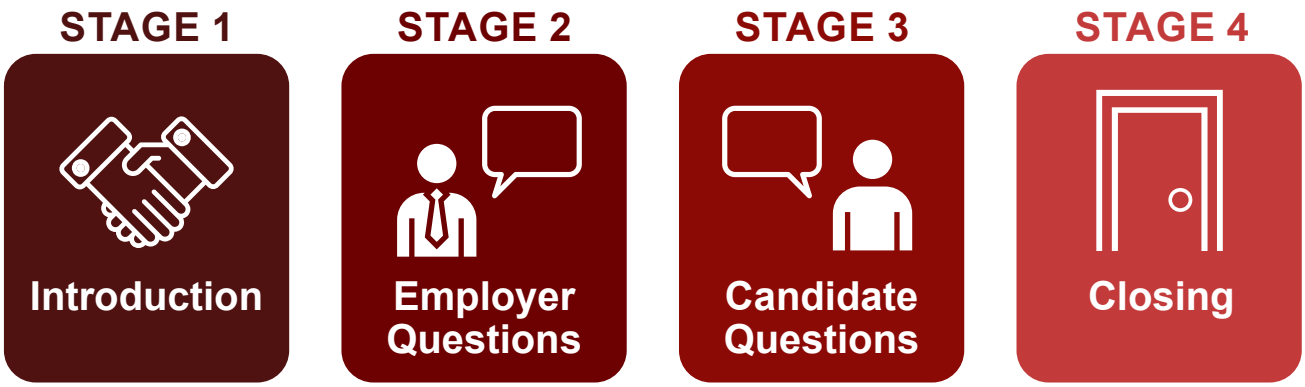
10. **Restlessness** - If you have a nervous habit like jiggling your leg, tapping the table, or touching your face or hair, do your best to suppress it. Restless habits can be distracting and may demonstrate nervousness or disinterest to the interviewer.

DURING THE INTERVIEW

Now we need to discuss the different stages that all interviews progress through.

These stages occur regardless of the type of interview you may be attending. Most interviews have four stages.

The better you understand each stage and what is expected of you during that stage, the better prepared you will be for your interview.



STAGE 1: INTRODUCTION

This stage allows you to build rapport, get used to the surroundings, and allow your nerves to settle. Make appropriate small talk to get comfortable with the interviewer. As the interview begins, remember the following:

- Speak clearly and not too fast. The interviewer will assess your communication skills based on how you express yourself.
- Listen carefully to the interviewer. Make sure you answer the question the interviewer is asking.
- Keep your answers concise and complete; two minutes per answer is normal.

Again, first impressions matter. The introduction is your opportunity to set the tone for the interview. Follow these best practices for the introduction stage.

Your goal during the introduction is to:

- Introduce yourself to the employer and state for which position you are interviewing.
- For in-person interviews, introduce yourself professionally. Follow the employer's lead. If appropriate, offer a firm, whole-hand handshake. Shake hands with both men and women the same way.
- Find common ground. Make appropriate small talk. Avoid topics such as religion, politics, and controversial current events.
- Project enthusiasm and confidence. Be respectful. Be positive. Your face conveys your attitude and reinforces what you say.
- Build rapport.

STAGE 2: EMPLOYER QUESTIONS

The most important part of preparing for an interview is practice. Anticipating what job interview questions may be asked is essential—that way, you can craft your answers well in advance and feel confident in your responses.

Using the STAR Method when Interviewing

Using the STAR Method in crafting and answering interview questions is a common practice. You may recall from your EFCT Workshop that STAR is an acronym for Situation, Task, Action, and Result.

SITUATION – Think of a specific time or circumstance when you used this skill; define the general context of that situation.

TASK – Name the key objective you were responsible for in that situation or the challenges/obstacles you had to overcome.

ACTION – Describe what you did to complete the assigned task; emphasize the skills and resources involved.

RESULT – Summarize the outcome and how you specifically contributed; describe the improvements and/or benefits.

Remember to incorporate evidence, specific examples, data, and anecdotes to illustrate your points. Use numbers to quantify your accomplishments where applicable.



PRO TIP:

USE STAR TO STAND OUT

Distinguish yourself as an applicant by creating achievement statements that demonstrate your ability to perform, and even excel, as an employee.

The STAR method will help you discuss how you used your skills to achieve goals. It will give you a method and pattern for how you respond to an interviewer's questions. This provides a concise narrative that gives a fuller picture of your competencies and how you previously put them into practice.

As mentioned in the EFCT Workshop, employers generally are looking for answers to three basic questions:

1. Does the candidate have the skills and abilities to perform the job?
2. Does the candidate possess the attitude and work ethic the employer expects?
3. Will the candidate be a team player and fit into the organization?

Develop answers to the example questions using the STAR method and use them when you respond to interview questions. Continuing to think like an employer, make sure your responses address the employer's concerns.

- What will be your "value add" as the employer sees it?
- What gap in the company's required skillset will you be providing?
- What level of skill will be good enough to produce a profit for the company?

Asking yourself questions like these will help you anticipate the sort of answers an employer wants to hear and help determine if your level of skill and experience is sufficient for the position they are trying to fill.

TYPES OF INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

Most employers ask a standard set of interview questions relating to how your skills, knowledge, training, and work experience fit the job and the company. These questions fall under three categories: traditional, behavioral, and hypothetical/situational.

Traditional questions are broad-based. Behavioral questions demonstrate your behavior in past situations. Hypothetical or situational questions reveal how you would handle a specific situation. Interviewers also ask common leadership questions for those seeking management-level positions. Prepare answers to these typical questions to present your strongest skills and qualifications and follow these best practices.

- Keep your answers brief, but be certain that you answer the questions thoroughly.
- Think about your answer before you start to speak. It is okay to pause, collect your thoughts, and then give your answer. Try to relate your response to the position for which you are applying by using keywords from the job posting.
- Every chance you get, use examples to explain how you would go about doing a job rather than just saying you can do it.
- While it is important not to get too detailed, describe your specific certifications, training, and other specialized experience that will give you an edge over other applicants.

TRADITIONAL INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

Traditional interview questions are straightforward. Here is a list of traditional interview questions.

Interview Question 1:

"Tell me about yourself."



- **Explanation**: The interviewer will likely start out with a question about you and your background to get to know you. This is the time to provide your targeted professional introduction.
- **Response**: Start out by giving an overview of your current position or activities, then provide the most important and relevant highlights from your background that make you most qualified for the role. If you have specialized certifications, training, or licenses relevant to the position you have applied for, this is an excellent time to mention them. Close it out by stating how you will use these skills to benefit their company or how they align with the position.

Interview Question 2:

"How would you describe yourself?"



- **Explanation**: When an employer asks you to describe yourself, they are looking for information about how your qualities and characteristics align with the skills they believe are needed to succeed in the role. This question also gives you the opportunity to talk about something you know well, yourself, and breaks the ice.
- **Response**: Think about characteristics your prior co-workers or employers would share about you. Provide three or four characteristics along with examples of quantifiable results to show how you used your best attributes to drive success. Example characteristics you can use are: persistent, trustworthy, innovative, passionate, results-driven, and industrious.

Interview Question 3:

"What makes you unique?"



- **Explanation**: Employers often ask this question to find out why you might be more qualified than other candidates they are interviewing. This is not an opportunity to confess unusual habits or odd traits, but essentially an opportunity to express what makes you special and better suited for the role.
- **Response**: While this response may be similar to "How would you describe yourself?," consider a particular trait that makes you stand-out, along with a past example on how it was a benefit to the organization. Stay away from generic terms, such as hard-worker or dedicated. Instead, consider a transferable skill like technology-savvy or research-driven with an example how those traits were results-oriented.

Interview Question 4:

"Why do you think you are qualified for this position?"



- Explanation: The interviewer is checking to see if you know the qualifications for the job you are applying for and how you think you fit the role.
- **Response**: Pick two or three main factors about the job and about you that are most relevant. Discuss with specific details. Select a technical skill, a specific management skill (organizing, staffing, planning), and a personal success story.

Interview Question 5:

"What are your greatest strengths?"



- **Explanation**: This question gives you an opportunity to talk about both your technical and soft skills.
- **Response**: To answer, share qualities and personal attributes and then relate them back to the role for which you are interviewing.

Interview Question 6:

"What do you consider your most significant challenge?"



- **Explanation**: It can feel awkward to discuss your weaknesses in an environment where you are expected to focus on your accomplishments. Sharing your weaknesses can show that you are self-aware and want to continuously get better at your job—traits that are extremely attractive to many employers.
- **Response**: If you can, choose a weakness that is either not required for the job or at least does not impact any major aspect of the job or its responsibilities. Start with the weakness and then discuss the measures you have taken to improve. This way, you are finishing your answer on a positive note.

Interview Question 7:

"Have you ever accomplished something you did not think you could?"



- **Explanation**: The interviewer is trying to determine your level of self-confidence.
- **Response**: Provide a good example of when you overcame difficulties to succeed. Show you are goal-oriented and have a strong work ethic.

Interview Question 8:

"Why do you want to work here?"



- **Explanation**: Employers often ask this question to determine whether you took time to research the company and to learn why you see yourself as a good fit.
- **Response**: To prepare for this question, research the company—its products, services, mission, history, culture, and values. Find out what matters most to them. In your answer, highlight what you like about the company with specific examples. Show how their priorities match your own, with examples, and explain why those things matter to you in an employer.

Interview Question 9:

"What interests you about this role?"



- **Explanation**: Like the previous question, employers often include this question to make sure you understand the role and give you an opportunity to highlight your relevant skills.
- **Response**: In addition to thoroughly reading the job description, it can be helpful to compare the role requirements against your skills and experience. This is where you can use your transferable skills.

Interview Question 10:

"What do you like or dislike about your current position?"



- **Explanation**: The interviewer may be trying to determine your compatibility with the open position.
- **Response**: Avoid complaining about your dislikes and keep the answer positive.

Interview Question 11:

"How do you handle pressure? Do you like or dislike these situations?"



- **Explanation**: The interviewer is trying to determine your levels of motivation and determination to reach a goal.
- **Response**: High achievers tend to perform well in high-pressure situations. Conversely, this question also could imply that the position is pressure-packed. If you perform well under pressure, provide a good example with details that give an overview of the stressful situation. Try to relay the situation as a challenge rather than focusing on your ability to handle pressure. The interviewer will see you turn a negative into a positive situation.

Interview Question 12:

"Good employees can take the initiative and get the job done. Can you describe yourself in terms of this statement?"



- **Explanation**: The interviewer is trying to determine your levels of initiative and self-motivation.
- **Response**: A proactive, results-oriented person does not need constant supervision. To convince the interviewer you know how to take the initiative, you must describe a situation in which you were self-motivated. Try to discuss at least one example in depth. Demonstrate a strong work ethic and creativity.

Interview Question 13:

"What is the most difficult aspect of your career? How would you have done things differently in hindsight?"



- **Explanation**: This is a question to find out if you are introspective and if you learn from your mistakes.
- **Response**: The right answer indicates an open, flexible personality. Do not be afraid to talk about negative results or problem issues, particularly if you have learned from them. Dynamic, high-performance individuals learn from mistakes. End your story on a positive note.

Interview Question 14:

"Can you tell me more about the time on your resume when you were not working?"



- **Explanation**: It is reasonable that an employer will notice career gaps on your resume and want to hear more. You may experience a gap due to your final PCS, terminal leave, or school. Spouses also experience gaps due to PCS moves. Be prepared for this question.
- **Response**: Explain the time off and if applicable, why it was important or beneficial. Share the value you picked up along the way. Highlight new skills you acquired. Emphasize why you are returning to work now. Keep your explanation short. Have a finish line so you don't trail off into embarrassed silence. Be confident. Move on. Don't overshare. If not properly prepared, a moment of panic could lead to you to divulging way too much information.

BEHAVIORAL INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

These questions are designed to find out how you responded in the past in difficult situations. They are considered predictors for how you might behave on the job in the future. Behavioral questions are more probing and more specific than traditional interview questions. The best way to answer behavioral questions is by using the STAR method.



PRO TIP:

USE STAR TO STAND OUT

Distinguish yourself as an applicant by creating achievement statements that demonstrate your ability to perform, and even excel, as an employee.

Here is a list of some behavioral interview questions and how your STAR statements can be used to provide a response.

Interview Question 15:

"Can you tell me about a difficult work situation and how you overcame it?"



- **Explanation**: This question is often used to assess how well you perform under pressure, as well as your problem-solving abilities. Keep in mind that stories are more memorable than facts and figures. This is also an excellent opportunity to show your human side and how you are willing to go the extra mile without being asked. Use the STAR method to guide your response.
- **Example Response**:
  - SITUATION: "We had a big hurricane last year and most of my department (platoon) was tasked with the hurricane relief. I was left behind with two other team members to see walk-in patients."
  - TASK: "My department was supposed to be back that morning at 10:00 AM, but their truck broke down. Our peak time in the clinic was from 9:00 AM to 2:00 PM, so we were extremely short on staff to handle the walk-in patients."
  - ACTION: "To help as many patients as possible, I created a triage method to assess patients' levels of pain. Once we identified their levels of pain, we categorized the pain levels and saw the patients with the highest level of pain."
  - RESULT: "I rescheduled the patients with pain levels of 0-3 to a later time to relieve the bottleneck effect in the waiting room."

Interview Question 16:

"Give an example of a goal you didn't meet and how you handled it."



- **Explanation**: Employers want to assess how you handle disappointments and how you value personal accountability. Make sure your example shows that you took personal responsibility and focused on what you could do differently next time. When answering a question, the answer may not parallel to the acronym. For example, in the following response, the Task comes before the Situation.
- **Example Response**:
  - TASK: "I was working on two major projects with my team and a new opportunity came in. This opportunity was the one I really wanted to work on. Out of excitement—without thinking—I accepted it."
  - SITUATION: "I didn't take into consideration the other two projects that were due soon. Work began to pile up, and I was feeling the pressure. I decided that I had to prioritize."
  - ACTION: "At the end, I had to let go of the new project because I was not able to complete that project in the fashion that I would have liked. I was disappointed, but I know that was the right thing to do."
  - RESULT: "This situation taught me the importance of prioritizing and time management."

Interview Question 17:

"Tell me about a time you needed to get information from someone who wasn't very responsive. What did you do?"



- **Explanation**: The employer wants to know how you work in a group setting and how your personality would fit in with their team. You need to give an example that shows that you are persistent and able to follow through but at the same time you are a team player. In the following response, the Task comes before the Situation.
- **Example Response**:
  - TASK: "At the end of the month, I am responsible for submitting our department total recruitment head count."
  - SITUATION: "I needed my coworker's total recruitment number for that month to complete my report. I sent out a reminder email two weeks prior to the deadline, then a gentle follow-up email three days later."
  - ACTION: "When I didn't get a response from him, I checked in with him personally. I would always try to see if I could assist my coworker because I know sometimes things would fall through the cracks."
  - RESULT: "I was able to obtain the requested numbers during our meeting and completed the report on time. Our team maintained our 100% on-time reporting."

HYPOTHETICAL OR SITUATIONAL INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

Hypothetical questions are the type of interview questions in which the interviewer puts you in an imaginary and experimental situation to assess how you would handle that situation.

Here are three hypothetical/situational interview questions.

Interview Question 18:

"How would you approach a task you've never done before?"



- **Explanation**: Your employer wants to assess whether you have problem-solving skills and whether you can approach new tasks intelligently.
- **Example Response**:
  - SITUATION: "In my previous position as Project Support Officer, I was often challenged with new projects requiring me to step outside of my comfort zone."
  - TASK: "Because of these opportunities, I developed a systematic approach to each challenge."
  - ACTION: "The first thing I do is collect as much information as I can to ensure I understand what is needed. Then, break the project down into manageable steps. I would also undertake internet research and consultations with colleagues who had previous experience with a similar project. After I had completed each piece of work, I would always double-check the progress with my manager to ensure I'm on the right track and to get feedback."
  - RESULT: "This approach has resulted in receiving praise from my supervisors."

Interview Question 19:

"The work quality of one of your staff has dropped off precipitously. What would you do to address the situation?"



- **Explanation**: This question is to help employers identify your leadership skills. You want to share your leadership skills and how you can resolve the problem while highlighting your discipline and problem-solving ability. If a hypothetical question provides a scenario that you have encountered before, you can answer with what you actually did and learned. This may be a stronger answer than explaining what you think you might do.
- **Example Response**:
  - SITUATION: "I gained a lot of experience leading teams and groups in my past job, and I've encountered this situation a few times."
  - TASK: "The key first step to dealing with an underperforming colleague is honest communication."
  - ACTION: "In one of my past experiences, I met with a member of the team privately, explained my concerns about the quality of his work, and asked him to explain the cause of the problem. My junior teammate said he knew that his work had been subpar lately but was afraid to address the issue with me."
  - RESULT: "We came up with a plan to address his performance, and I provided him with the support he needed."

Interview Question 20, “an oddball” question:

“If you were a fruit, what kind would you be and why?”



- **Explanation**: This question is asked to assess your self-awareness, creativity, and ability to think on your feet in an unexpected situation. It reveals how you perceive yourself, how well you can communicate abstract ideas in a meaningful way, and possibly assess your culture fit.
- **Example Response**: Choose a fruit that reflects a key trait or strength you bring to the role and briefly explain the connection in a creative, thoughtful way. - “I’d be a grape. Grapes thrive in bunches, and I see myself the same way - I enjoy working in teams, supporting others, and contributing to collective success.”

HOW TO ANSWER SALARY EXPECTATION QUESTIONS

Salary questions are tricky since you want to get the highest salary you can without jeopardizing your shot at the job. There are various approaches you can take when a recruiter or hiring manager inquires about your salary expectations. Review the following four example options and the response that you could possibly give.

We will discuss salary ranges and negotiation in-depth later in the workshop.

Option 1: Delay discussion of salary.

Show the interviewer your skills and worth by explaining your accomplishments before discussing salary.

You can say… "I'm looking for a competitive package, but I'd like to know a little more about the job requirements first."

Option 2: Turn the question back to the interviewer.

Ask what the range is for the job or ask to hear the interviewer's best offer.

You can say… "I would want a salary that's consistent with current employees at the same level. What is your pay range for this position based on my skills and experience level?"

Option 3: Provide a range.

Give the amount as a range. Keep in mind, however, that the employer may opt for the lower end of your range, so make sure your target number is as close to the bottom number as possible.

You can say… "Thank you for asking. Based on my research, an annual salary between $67,000 and $72,000 is in line with the industry average and reflects my skills and experience level well. I am, however, flexible and open to hearing about the company's compensation expectations for this position."

Option 4: Provide a range – alternate answer.

You can say… "I am seeking a position that pays between $75,000 and $80,000 annually. I am open to negotiate salary depending on benefits, bonuses, equity, stock options, and other opportunities."

INAPPROPRIATE OR ILLEGAL QUESTIONS

How do you respond to seemingly inappropriate questions? There are certain topics that are off-limits during an interview. However, some companies slip them in, maybe not even realizing they are inappropriate or even illegal.

Some of the topics that should be avoided pertain to age, religion, disabilities, military discharge, criminal record, citizenship, family status, salary, and credit rating. In some cases, a topic may be conditional for the job; however, that must be disclosed. An example is needing to be able to bend over and lift a certain amount of weight, where a disability that would prohibit you from doing that task, even with accommodations, may disqualify you. These questions are legal only when an organization can prove that they are bona fide occupational qualifications (BFOQs) that are relatively essential to the routine functions of a company that cannot be done with accommodations.

If you are in an interview and you feel the question is illegal, you always have the option to respectfully decline to answer the question and/or end the interview. However, we know too well that those actions may be uncomfortable or cause us to lose the opportunity for the job, so let's consider other options.

1. Answer the question if you personally do not mind.

   Example question: How old are you?

   Example answer: 46

2. Answer the legal part of the question.

   Example question: How old are you?

   Example answer: I'm over the age of 21, if that is the question.

3. Ask how it applies to the job.

   Example question: How old are you?

   Example answer: I'm happy to answer your question, but can you tell me how that relates to the job?

4. Do not answer the question.

   Example question: How old are you?

   Example answer: My age is not an issue for my performance in this job.

Here are some other graceful ways to answer these types of questions:

1. I can perform all the duties that this position entails.
2. I am confident that I will be able to handle the requirements of this position.
3. There is nothing in my past which would affect my ability to perform the duties of this job.
4. This question does not affect my ability to perform the job.

Although you may not encounter these types of questions, it is a good idea to prepare yourself just in case you are put in this situation. By practicing, you won't be caught off guard and you will already have an idea of how you plan to handle such questions.

ACTIVITY 5.1: PRACTICE ANSWERING INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

Use the space below to write notes on how you would answer some common interview questions. Choose from the questions listed in the previous pages and take into consideration the explanations of the employer's objective for asking those questions when developing your responses.

My Answer to Question # _____

My Answer to Question # _____

My Answer to Question # _____

My Answer to Question # _____

My Answer to Question # _____

ACTIVITY 5.2: MODEL INTERVIEW PRACTICE

As with every skill or talent, the more you do it, the better you'll be at it. You may be familiar with the saying "Train like you fight." A model interview will provide you with the training you need to get ready for the job interview. It will help you learn how to answer difficult questions, develop interview strategies, improve communication skills, and reduce stress before an actual job interview.

Let's practice answering interview questions and receive live feedback!

Your facilitator will ask for volunteers to be interviewed in front of the class. This is a great opportunity to receive one-on-one feedback from the facilitator and your classmates.

- **Candidate role**: Each volunteer will select a question they answered in Activity 5.1 and provide that question number to the facilitator. The facilitator will ask the question, allow the volunteer to answer as if they were in a real interview and then provide feedback.
- **Employer role**: The facilitator will play the employer, ask each candidate a question, and provide one-on-one feedback. Once the facilitator has provided feedback, they will allow the class to provide feedback or ask the facilitator questions for clarification.
- **Observer role**: Use the following page to help you provide feedback to the candidate or to get clarification from the facilitator during the discussion that follows the interview questions.

MODEL INTERVIEW OBSERVATIONS

While observing the model interviews, be on the lookout for the following. Was the response to the question clear? Did the candidate use the STAR method? Did the candidate stumble, ramble, or respond to the questions with natural body language and confidence? Use the space below to write questions you may have for the facilitator or make notes on your observations.

STAGE 3: CANDIDATE QUESTIONS



Quick Tip

Having questions prepared to ask often shows that you have a greater interest in the role and want to learn more about the company.

After asking several questions of you, interviewers usually ask if you have questions for them.

Interviewers listen to the questions you ask to determine your level of interest in the job and your knowledge of the company. Your questions provide you with information that will help you decide if the job is a good job fit for you.

Interviewers also learn about you, and remember you, by the questions you ask. They respect candidates who carefully consider their choices, and they appreciate knowing you did your homework. Ask two to three questions to gauge the organization's fit to your standards and criteria. Ideally, have six to seven questions to select from and tailor your selection on those most appropriate to ask based on the experience during the interview.

Smart questions to ask during an interview:

1. After hearing my answers to your questions, do you have any concerns about my ability to do the job?
2. If I get this position, what will be most important for me to do to ensure that you and the team are successful?
3. How soon do you plan to fill this position?
4. Is it okay if I follow up with you next week?
5. What are the greatest challenges of this position?
6. What does a typical week on the job consist of?
7. Are there any questions to which I did not adequately respond?
8. Who is the supervisor for the position?
9. What do you expect me to accomplish in the first six months?
10. How would you describe the work environment?
11. Do your employees work individually or as a team?
12. Is this a newly created position or has it existed for some time?
13. What further education or training does the company consider important for my future progress?
14. What are the department's goals for the year?
15. What is the company culture like?
16. How do you measure employee performance?
17. What is the most challenging aspect of the position?
18. What do you enjoy most about working with this company?

Questions you SHOULD NOT ask during an interview:

1. What is the salary for this position?
2. When can I take time off for vacation?
3. Can you tell me about your company's benefits?
4. Do you offer any flextime options?
5. How long will it take to get promoted?



ACTIVITY 5.3: USE AI TO ASSIST IN DEVELOPING CANDIDATE QUESTIONS

In this activity, you will prompt an AI chat to help you generate questions to ask an employer.

STEP 1: Navigate to your desired AI chat (ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, Gemini, Perplexity, etc.)

STEP 2: Use the following prompt: "Help me prepare for an interview. I am applying for a [desired job title] role in the [desired industry] industry. What are some questions I should ask the interviewer about the role, company, and its culture."

STEP 3: You can also modify the questions by including the specific company you are interviewing with. Also ensure they are questions that show you have done some research and your interest in the job.

STAGE 4: CLOSING

When they signal the interview is over, end on a positive note. There are three vital steps in the closing stage of an interview.

- First, thank them for the invitation to interview. If you are in a video interview, it is especially important to look into your camera during this stage.
- Second, express your sincere interest in the job and company. An example would be, to say, "After learning more about this position and your company, I think I would be an asset and would welcome the opportunity to become a member of your team."
- Finally, set a timeline for follow-up. You can inquire as to the next steps in the process or when might be a good time to follow-up with the company. After leaving, give yourself a deadline for following up with a thank-you note or information that was requested of you. Make a gracious exit; smile and be pleasant, and on your way out say goodbye to anyone you see who may have helped you.

AFTER THE INTERVIEW

FOLLOW-UP

Follow up immediately after the interview (the same day) by sending a thank-you email or a handwritten thank-you note to your interviewer(s). It is a good idea to obtain contact information from any interviewer while you are there for an interview so that you will have their names, job titles, and contact information.

The thank-you note gives you the opportunity to briefly add anything you forgot to say in the interview. It also serves as an opportunity to reinforce your interest in the position, highlight relevant information discussed during the interview, and express your appreciation for the interviewer's time.

It will also help distinguish you from other candidates.

Did You Know?

A recent survey on Thank You Emails After Interviews, cited by Robert Half, found that 27% of hiring managers believe a thank-you note can tip the scales in a candidate's favor when skills are equal. (https://www.roberthalf.com/us/en/insights/landing-job/how-to-write-thank-you-emails-after-interviews)

THANK YOU NOTE

Thank you notes should be brief and to the point. See the following examples.

THANK YOU EMAIL EXAMPLE:

Dear Mr. Williams:

Thank you for allowing me the opportunity to interview with you today. The information you shared with me about Washington Mutual Bank clarifies the impact of loan officers to your overall mission. I am excited about the possibility of applying my education and experience to this position with your bank. The expansion and public lending plans are especially intriguing, and I look forward to helping the bank enter the new market.

If I can provide you with any additional information, please let me know. I look forward to hearing from you soon.

Sincerely,
Blair Henderson
(916) 999-9999

THANK YOU LETTER EXAMPLE:

Judy R. Smith
(916) 999-9999 • jrsmith@email.com • www.linkedin.com/in/judy-smith

February 2, 20XX
Ms. Martha Anderson, President
Carrington Cable Corporation
5555 Cable Boulevard
Los Angeles, CA 95999

Dear Ms. Anderson:

Thank you for taking the time to interview me this afternoon. The Cable Installer position at CCC really seems like a perfect fit for my skills and experience. I believe that I could be a valuable addition to CCC while you continue to grow your customer base.

One thing I forgot to mention during our conversation is that I recently completed a certification course in fiber optic installation, which would be especially valuable as CCC expands its high-speed service offerings.

I also enjoyed our discussion about local fishing spots, and I am excited to try your suggestions.

Thank you again for your time, and I look forward to hearing from you next Thursday.

Sincerely,
Judy R. Smith

Another opportunity for follow-up occurs if you are advised that you are not selected for the job. Think about sending a note or email expressing that while you are disappointed not to be selected, you are still interested in the company.

Hiring managers often return to their pool of previously interviewed applicants when new openings occur. It is a good idea to be remembered in a positive light and stay on good terms with hiring managers you met during your job search.

INTERVIEWING SKILLS SECTION REVIEW

In this section, you learned to:

- distinguish the different types of interviews.
- recognize key aspects of before, during, and after the interview.
- identify best practices of in-person and virtual interviews.

6 Salary Negotiations

SECTION 6: SALARY NEGOTIATIONS

This section of the workshop provides information on how to prepare to negotiate a salary and how to conduct a salary negotiation after a job offer.

SECTION OBJECTIVES

- Determine a reasonable salary range.
- Compare a job announcement posting and requirements to your experience and education.
- Evaluate and negotiate job offers.
- Identify and discuss three ways to respond to a job offer.

Quote

"In business and in life, you don't get what you deserve, you get what you negotiate."

~ Dr. Chester L Karrass, Author of *Give and Take: The Complete Guide to Negotiating Strategies and Tactics.*

SALARY NEGOTIATION PREPARATION

In this lesson, we will review basic information on pay, market value, and company research.

Why is understanding salary negotiations important?

- Knowing your worth can affect your earnings.
- Pay, market value, and company research are linked to your worth.
- It ensures you're compensated at a rate that meets or exceeds industry standards.
- You want to deal with facts. Do not negotiate out of emotion.

PAY

The EFCT course provided a good foundation of pay, pay ranges, and market value and how they are associated. The amount of salary or wages paid to an employee is determined by the employer and is based on what similar positions are paid in the same region and industry. A salary range provides the company the opportunity to offer compensation to their employees or candidates based on job requirements, skills, and demand. Candidates can often negotiate their pay and sometimes their benefits.

You were also introduced in the EFCT course to the Fair Labor Standards Act (FLSA), which establishes minimum wage, overtime pay, and recordkeeping requirements affecting employees in the private sector and in federal, state, and local governments.

MARKET VALUE

In the EFCT, you discussed and defined market value.

Market value can be defined as the price your knowledge, skills, and abilities would bring based upon the industry and location of the position.

Knowing your market value to an employer is important when negotiating a job offer to ensure you identify a fair market value and not a random number based on your personal financial needs. You will also need to ensure your research includes the geographic area where you will work. Given the differing costs of living, it is reasonable to expect that salaries are adjusted accordingly in Washington, DC, and Omaha, Nebraska.

COMPANY RESEARCH

Before applying for jobs, you researched companies and market trends to understand salaries, demand for your skills, and benefits. Now, use that knowledge to determine whether a job offer aligns with your priorities and help you decide whether to accept or reject a job offer.

While salary matters, a strong company culture is what truly keeps employees committed long-term. It should be a good "fit" on more than one level. Employees stay when they feel aligned with the company's values, priorities, and overall mission. In other words, employees stay because they "fit" with the company's culture.

How can you understand a company's culture? Again, it's time to do research.

A good place to start is at the company's website, beginning with the "About Us" page. Get to know the company's entire website, especially noting its mission statement, key leaders and staff. Review the company's LinkedIn page, as well as Facebook and other social media sites. Look for the company's key leaders and decision makers on LinkedIn. Review employee comments and testimonials on sites like Glassdoor, Indeed "Company Reviews," Comparably, Blind, or Reddit.

Use the vast amount of information available online to decide if a company is a good fit for you and where you would want to belong as an employee.

KNOW YOUR WORTH: SALARY RESEARCH

Knowing your market value gives you confidence as you interact with clients, supervisors, colleagues, or friends and can be used to help negotiate the salary you want. Knowing the standard salary or wage for a position, along with identifying your KSAs, can assist in developing a strategy to ensure that you are paid your market value.

For example, employers may have you list your salary requirements on your application. It is okay to write “open” or “negotiable.” If those are not options, provide a salary range based on salary research for your identified career.

A cost-of-living comparison can provide you with additional qualitative information. This comparison is for you, the candidate, and not the employer.

While salary and cost of living are often used together, they are different. Your salary is pay for work done and cost of living is the amount of salary needed to sustain a certain standard of living in a specific location.

SALARY RESEARCH

Conduct salary research to ensure your offer matches your market value. Consider factors that impact salary, including job title, industry, location, job requirements, and your skills and experience.

Remember, your base salary is not what you take home. Employers deduct taxes, healthcare insurance, and retirement contributions from your salary.

For research purposes, salary may be grouped by job family which is a group of jobs that involve similar work and require similar training, skills, knowledge, and expertise. Some job family examples include:

- Administrative/Management
- Administrative/Support
- Communications/Marketing
- Human Resources (HR)
- Information Technology (IT)

Consider the IT job family from the list above which may include a Business Analyst, Help Desk Representative, Database Developer, IT Policy and Planning Analyst, Telecommunications Specialist, Network Security Officer, and Product Manager. Each of these positions may have ranges from entry-level to senior level.

More Information

Visit the FLSA homepage, (https://www.dol.gov/agencies/whd/flsa) or review the Handy Reference Guide to the Fair Labor Standards Act, (https://www.dol.gov/agencies/whd/compliance-assistance/handy-reference-guide-flsa), for information on basic wage standards, tipped employees, computing overtime pay, and other labor laws.



PRO TIP:

KNOW YOUR MARKETABLE SKILLS

Knowing what job skills you have, and which of those skills employers are looking for, greatly enhances what you offer as a job applicant.

EMPLOYMENT WAGES

There are a variety of online resource options for conducting private-sector salary research. Let's walk through a few.

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics
(https://www.bls.gov/oes/home.htm)

Tap into your network to identify a pay range for your specific job and organization. The Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS) program produces employment and wage estimates annually for nearly 800 occupations. These estimates are available for the nation as a whole, for individual states, and for metropolitan and nonmetropolitan areas; national occupational estimates for specific industries are also available.

Salary.com
(https://www.salary.com)

Salary.com pulls HR-reported aggregate market data to accurately report salaries on thousands of jobs. This site offers products and services such as:

- Salary research
- Cost-of-living wizard
- Job listings

Glassdoor.com
(https://www.glassdoor.com/Salaries/know-your-worth.htm)

Know Your Worth is based on millions of real salaries from Glassdoor users. Glassdoor's economists and data scientists unearth important trends in hiring, pay, and the broader economy. Once you complete your profile, Glassdoor will calculate how much you could earn in today's job market. You can try this salary calculator for your next salary negotiation.



Did You Know?

Salary.com (https://www.salary.com/) has been in business for over 20 years. They continually update their information on pay, benefits, and career data providing information for over 16,000 unique job titles in over 140 countries.

Calculator.net
(https://www.calculator.net/salary-calculator.html)

The Salary Calculator converts salary amounts to their corresponding values based on payment frequency. Examples of payment frequencies include bi-weekly, twice a month, or monthly payments. Results include unadjusted figures and adjusted figures that account for vacation days and holidays per year. Each calculator is coded and developed individually, and put through strict, comprehensive testing.

Do not rely solely on websites and online resources. Mentors, colleagues, and network connections are of considerable help on this topic. Corporate recruiters can provide excellent information on market reasonable salary ranges. This is another great reason to stay connected to your network.

ACTIVITY 6.1: IDENTIFY A SALARY RANGE

Conduct salary research using AI.

Using AI can assist your salary research during a job search. By crafting specific prompts, you can instruct AI to analyze current compensation trends for your desired role and location, providing you with a clearer understanding of the salary landscape. This approach allows you to assess where your qualifications position you within the market, aiding in setting realistic salary expectations. Incorporating AI into your research empowers you to make informed decisions and approach salary negotiations with greater confidence.

This activity will focus on identifying mean wages. The **mean wage** is the average wage, calculated by totaling the wages paid to all employees within a defined population and dividing that sum by the number of employees. This metric offers a benchmark for understanding compensation levels within a particular occupation or industry.

Use the following example as a reference when conducting your salary research.

STEP 1. In your browser, open your desired AI tool to provide a prompt.

STEP 2. Create your own personalized prompt, using the following example:

“Provide a market salary range for a [insert job or role] in [insert state or city]. Provide the mean wage and resources used for the results.”

Example: Provide a salary market range for a logistics manager in Sacramento, California. Provide the mean wage and resources used for the results.

STEP 3. Factors such as company name, education and years of experience can provide a more specific range to consider. Here is another prompt that can assist you in getting a more focused range.

“Provide a market salary range for a [insert role] with [number of years] years’ experience, with a [insert degree or certification] in [insert location]. Provide the mean wage and resources used for the results.”

Example: Provide a salary market range for a logistics manager with 8 years’ experience, with a bachelor’s degree in Sacramento, California. Provide the mean wage and resources used for the results.

Tip: If you already know what company you will be interviewing with, include the name of the company in your search.

Salary Range Research Table

In the following example, the participant lives at Fort Campbell, KY. After separating from the military, he and his family want to remain near Kentucky, but are unsure whether they want to remain in the immediate area.

Salary research was conducted using the role of Transportation Specialist with 5-6 years of experience for both Fort Campbell, KY, and Knoxville, TN. The two cities are approximately four hours apart. The salary is slightly higher in Knoxville, TN.

EXAMPLE: Salary Comparison for Transportation Specialist.

SALARY RESEARCH	RESULT
Desired Job	Transportation Specialist
City/ State	Fort Campbell, KY
Range for this occupation in your preferred location (city/state)?	$60,000-$119,000
Specific salary based on your education and years of experience?	$73,570

SALARY RESEARCH	RESULT
Desired Job	Transportation Specialist
City/ State	Knoxville, TN
Range for this occupation in your preferred location (city/state)?	$66,000-$130,000
Specific salary based on your education and years of experience?	$80,840

Use the charts below to record your own salary search for an occupation and location you are interested in.

SALARY RESEARCH	RESULT
Desired Job	
City/ State	
Range for this occupation in your preferred location (city/state)?	
Specific salary based on your education and years of experience?	

SALARY RESEARCH	RESULT
Desired Job	
City/ State	
Range for this occupation in your preferred location (city/state)?	
Specific salary based on your education and years of experience?	

COST OF LIVING

In evaluating relocation criteria, salary should not be the single determining factor. Include a cost-of-living comparison when selecting a career path.

A cost-of-living calculator compares the overall price of goods and services among different areas. You can use your current location and your new location to determine the salary you need to maintain the same standard of living. If you have attended the DOW TAP Financial Planning for Transition module, you may remember some discussions about the importance of understanding your salary needs and expectations especially if you are relocating.

FACTORS TO CONSIDER INCLUDE:

Energy/Utilities	Housing
Food	Transportation (car payments, fuel, or public mass transit)
Healthcare	State and Local taxes (sales, licensing, fuel, etc.)

Cost-of-living calculators are offered on Salary.com as well as these other websites:

- **Numbeo.com** (https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/) Numbeo is the world's largest cost-of-living database. Numbeo is also a "crowd-sourced" database of quality-of-life information including housing indicators, perceived crime rates, and quality of healthcare, among many other statistics. Crowd-sourcing involves obtaining work, information, or opinions from a large group of people who submit their data via the Internet, social media, and smartphone apps.



AI is another resource you can use to verify cost of living in your preferred area.

- **Bankrate.com** (https://www.bankrate.com/calculators/savings/moving-cost-of-living-calculator). You may have already conducted a cost-of-living comparison using BankRate.com during the DOW Financial Planning for Transition workshop.
- **SmartAsset.com** (https://smartasset.com/mortgage/cost-of-living-calculator) SmartAsset is an online financial technology company that provides consumer-focused information, personalized financial calculators, and a platform connecting users with vetted financial advisors.

Use the information from the calculators to answer questions such as:

- Is the cost of living higher or lower than your current location?
- What preparations can you make, e.g., create a current and projected budget?

JOB OFFERS

EVALUATING A JOB OFFER

Receiving a job offer is an exciting time in your job search; after all, this is your goal in the process.

But, do not make decisions or accept offers on the spot.

Instead, say, “I want to make sure I understand all the components of the offer; will you send me an email outlining the proposed terms?”

Evaluate your job offer to ensure it matches your career goals and weigh your options.

TERMS OF THE OFFER

When reviewing a job offer, consider the entire package, not just salary. The total compensation package consists of many items: salary, benefits, hours, flexibility, vacation time, and retirement plans.

JOB BENEFITS

Be sure to consider your benefits when reviewing your offer. Benefits packages can provide a wide range of options.

The quality of the benefits may impact what you are willing to accept as your salary. Some companies offer lower salaries, but the benefits of flexible schedules, work locations, or remote opportunities outweigh the difference in salary. Other companies may give you a higher salary to compensate for a lack of benefits.

Consider all benefits when reviewing your offer:

1. Medical Insurance - For full-time employees, a typical employer may cover a portion of the cost of health insurance, splitting the cost with the employee. Health insurance plans vary in their offerings, so read the terms of the plan.
2. Dental and Vision Insurance - Many companies that offer a health insurance plan also offer some type of dental and vision insurance with preventive care at an added cost.
3. Paid Time Off (PTO) - PTO includes a pool of paid time-off, such as vacation time, sick days, and other leave. Some employers offer it as a bank of days, while others may offer vacation and sick leave as separate benefits. Often, PTO must be accrued over time, usually earning a set rate of hours per pay period. Companies also have paid holiday time off, which may include select holidays, federal holidays, or even flexible or floating holidays to be taken at an employee’s discretion.
4. Education Benefits - Employers may offer a type of benefit to compensate employees who invest in education or training. This benefit may require a time-with-the-company payback or full completion of the education or training prior to the company reimbursing expenses.

5. 401(K) or Retirement Contributions - Employers may contribute to employees' retirement plans. The amount of compensation the employer contributes to an individual's account varies greatly. Companies can require a vesting period, which means those dollars contributed to the individual retirement accounts are not immediately available to the individual. Once the worker is vested, those contributions transfer ownership to the individual.
6. Stock or Equity - Some companies offer stocks or stock options. Stock is a percentage of ownership in a company. For small or start-up businesses, stock may be more commonly offered. Stock options are an option to purchase stock at an agreed-upon rate. Stock or equity opportunities typically have a vesting period.
7. Profit-Sharing - Some companies set aside a predetermined percentage of profits for distribution to employees who qualify under the terms of the benefit. Each of these terms varies from employer to employer.
8. Transportation Allowance - Some employers offer transportation expenses like:
    - Monthly car allowances
    - Employer-leased vehicles
    - Other fees associated with travel or work commute (public transportation, parking, etc.)

    Tip: Be aware that some of these benefits are taxable to the employee.
9. Other Benefits - Pre-Tax Deductions, Company Perks, and Other Insurance (Life, Short-term Disability, Long-term Disability, Identity Theft Protection, etc.)

EVALUATION

To evaluate your offer, make a checklist of what is acceptable and unacceptable. Compare how well the job matches your preferences and values. Keep in mind, your job decisions affect your family, so include them in the decision-making process.

Take into consideration these factors when evaluating a job:

Industry	Position	Company
Schedules/Work	Environment	Paid time off (PTO)
Paid sick time	Health insurance	Paid life insurance
Savings	Profit-sharing	Retirement plans
Other benefits		

- What terms of the job offer are important to you?
- Are there any terms of a job offer that are non-negotiable for you?
- What are the key factors to you in accepting a job offer?

Use the following topics to evaluate items about a company's job offer. Use the questions to help decide if the offer is acceptable or unacceptable. Add comments as applicable. Refer to Appendix F for an expanded Job Offer Evaluation Checklist.

JOB OFFER EVALUATION CHECKLIST		
Industry	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Interest in the industry Do I want to build a career in this field?	○	○
Job Position	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Work duties Do the duties of the job interest me and use my skills?	○	○
Potential for advancement What opportunities are available?	○	○
Wages/benefits Do they meet my needs?	○	○
Company	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Growth potential How has the company performed over the last five years?	○	○
Schedule/ Work	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Work schedule Does the job allow for flexible work schedules?	○	○
Remote work Does the company have a main or primary location? Does it have branch locations? Are any closer to your location? Can you work remotely?	○	○
Other Benefits	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Does the company offer cars or transportation allowance provided for executives, salespeople, or managers who must travel?	○	○

JOB REQUIREMENTS AND CANDIDATE EXPERIENCE

Job announcements are an external marketing tool meant to attract viable candidates. They may provide details about company values and culture, as well as the benefits the organization offers a prospective candidate.

Another aspect of analyzing the job posting is that it will assist in making a connection between your skills and the employer's requirements to determine your worth to the employer. This is the employer's wish list for their ideal candidate. They will be comparing your skills against their needs and wants.

Items to consider in your evaluation are:

1. Educational Requirements
2. Technical Qualifications
3. Prior Work Experience
4. Skills – Interpersonal, Communication, Leadership, Customer Service, Planning, Management
5. Technology Skills – Microsoft Access (create a database), Microsoft Publisher (create flyers), or Microsoft Outlook (communicate to vendors, caterers, participants, etc.)
6. Knowledge – Customer service, excellent written and public speaking skills, and strategic planning
7. Abilities – Organizing, planning, prioritizing, problem-solving, previous event coordination experience
8. Company Knowledge – Review website and any provided company information to see if their needs and values are consistent with yours.



PRO TIP:

ANALYZE JOB POSTINGS

Looking closely at a job posting will let you think like an employer and create an effective targeted resume.

CREATE A SKILLS COMPARISON CHART

Let's practice. Review a job posting's requirements and information, then compare them to the candidate's skills and current situation. Use this information to identify overlapping and missing areas. Review the fictitious military veteran bio and the Indeed.com job posting. Use the information to determine a strategy for negotiating higher pay.

BIOGRAPHY, Marc Gardner

Marc is a Marine Corps veteran. In the military, he was a Field Artillery Cannon Crew Member. He recently separated and relocated to Elizabethtown, Kentucky, to be closer to his brother.

Marc's career goal is to become a realtor and eventually have his own business. The following information is an excerpt from his resume.

EXPERIENCE:

- Utilized Microsoft Word, Excel, Outlook, PowerPoint, Access, and Internet protocols. Extensive knowledge of Excel to include mail merge, conditional formatting, charts, and formulas.
- In charge of battery office supplies and acquisition including the office credit card operating within the annual budget constraints of $10K.
- Justified the purchase of new equipment, improved work methods, and procedures used to streamline assignments and increase productivity.
- Delegated work to 7 personnel based on priorities, selective consideration of the difficulty and requirements of assignments and the capabilities of the employees, set and adjusted short-term priorities, prepared schedules for completion of work and evaluated work performance.

EMPLOYMENT HISTORY:

- U.S. Marine Corps, Field Artillery Cannoneer, Camp Lejeune, NC August 2016 – July 20XX

Marc is currently pursuing a 96-Hour Sales Associate Real Estate Pre-License Course online. He has completed 9 credit hours to include the following classes:

1. Home Ownership Concepts
2. Financing Practices
3. Investments

Marc is prepared to relocate but would like to remain in the area. This area is also close to other family members who live in Tennessee and Florida.

JOB POSTING, Office Coordinator, Clark Wade eXtreme Real Estate Team

Salary: $30,000 - $39,000 a year

Job Type: Full-time

Qualifications:

- High school or equivalent (Preferred)
- QuickBooks: 1 year (Preferred)

Full Job Description- Office Coordinator and Assistant:

- Office duties such as filing folders, listings, email, and Excel spreadsheets.
- Following up on leads, calling clients, and setting up appointments.
- Must be proficient in Excel, Outlook, and Word.

Related keywords: Administrative Assistant, Office Manager, Administrative

Schedule: 8-hour shift, Monday to Friday

Supplemental Pay: Commission

Education: High school or equivalent (Preferred)

Experience: QuickBooks: 1 year (Preferred)

Work Location: One primary location

This Job Is Ideal for Someone Who Is:

- Dependable -- more reliable than spontaneous
- People-oriented -- enjoys interacting with people and working on group projects

This Company Describes Its Culture as:

- Aggressive -- competitive and growth-oriented
- Team-oriented -- cooperative and collaborative

Work Remotely: No

Job Posting	Marc's Skills and Qualifications
High school or equivalent (Preferred) QuickBooks: 1 year (Preferred) NOTE: Used for bookkeeping.	Have high school plus 9 credit hours towards Real Estate Pre-License Excel: Have extensive knowledge. Used Excel in military and in college for: • Mail merge for creating unit memorandum, • Conditional formatting for identifying supplies, • Charts for work schedules, and • Formulas for evaluating supply usage.

Did you identify the following items that could be used as part of Marc's negotiation strategy?

1. His education level is higher than what the employer prefers. He can use this information to negotiate for higher pay.
2. However, he does not have QuickBooks knowledge which the employer prefers. But QuickBooks is easy to learn. There are online tutorials for QuickBooks, such as those available through LinkedIn Learning. Marc does have extensive Excel knowledge. He could use this information to persuade the employer that he is a better candidate, because Excel could be used to manage office supplies and to track equipment, budgeting, preparing schedules, and contacting clients.

Are there any other areas of comparison? Did you identify that he is pursuing a realtor license and has some familiarity with the business?

Use this method when negotiating a job offer to decide if the company's values align with yours, to find your weaknesses and strengths, and to show why you are the best candidate.

ACTIVITY 6.2: COMPLETE A SKILLS COMPARISON CHART

In this activity, you will compare your job posting qualifications requirements against your qualifications and skills using the Skill Comparison Chart.

1. In the first column, list the job qualifications from your job posting.
2. In the second column, enter your qualifications and skills in relation to the job qualifications.

Compare the two columns to identify where you may exceed qualifications or fail to meet stated qualifications.

Job Posting	Your Skills and Qualifications

How could you use the Skill Comparison Chart as a tool in your negotiation strategy?

Which specific items in the Skills Comparison Chart could you use in your salary negotiation?

NEGOTIATING JOB OFFERS

Negotiation usually involves a strategic discussion aimed at reaching an agreement or resolving an issue that benefits both parties and both parties find acceptable. A salary negotiation is simply the process of coming to an agreement on the amount of pay that an employee will receive, and the employer will give. Many position announcements do not supply a salary or salary range.



Quote

"Everything is negotiable. Whether or not the negotiation is easy is another thing."

– Carrie Fisher, Actress

NEGOTIATION PREPARATION

You may receive an offer that includes a mix of desirable and undesirable elements. Rather than turning down the offer, you may want to consider negotiating the terms of the offer with the employer.

Before you decide to negotiate, you must make decisions. First, be sure the issue is so serious that you would not take the job unless it was changed.

SALARY

- If money is the issue, be sure you research and know the salary for the position in your market and the range you will accept. Having a range allows for compromise.
- For example, you can say, "My research confirms that based on my skills and experience, the range for this position in (location) would be $___ to $___."
- If the employer is not willing to flex on salary, you may want to negotiate other terms of the offer instead.



Did You Know?

According to Glassdoor, 59% of workers did not try to negotiate the salary of their current job.

According to NPR, people who never negotiate salaries can miss additional earnings of between $1 million and $1.5 million in their lifetime.

SCHEDULE FLEXIBILITY

- Time is money.
- You can negotiate for more vacation days, flex time, and the ability to telecommute. These options can help maintain a healthy work-life balance and make the job more attractive to you.

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

- Negotiate for the employer to pay the tuition for a degree program or the cost of earning a professional certification. This option will help increase your skill set and add value to the organization.

TRAVEL REIMBURSEMENT

- Gas, parking, and toll costs can add up quickly. You can negotiate for travel and transportation reimbursement, including public transportation, bus or train fares, gas, parking, and tolls.
- Put in the work and be creative! These little things can make a big difference in your quality of life.

NEGOTIATION ACTIONS

It takes time and money to find the right candidate to fill a position, so the employer has already invested in you. Out of all the candidates they interviewed, they chose you. Keep in mind when you negotiate, they want this to work out; they want you to accept the offer. Strive for a mutually acceptable outcome.

If you like the potential job but are not happy with one or more of the offer components, negotiate the job offer. When you accept the offer, be sure it is what you want.

To negotiate a successful job offer, develop a plan. Conduct research and analyze the job, company, compensation and benefits packages, and opportunities for career growth. Be prepared because a negotiation is time sensitive.

Use hypothetical scenarios to prepare yourself for the negotiation. For example, ask yourself the "what ifs" of the negotiation and have a contingency plan for them: "If they offer me more vacation time instead of an increase in salary, will I accept it?"

Preparing for these possibilities in advance gives you time to react. Prepare before the negotiation or the employer has the upper hand.

Review the following list of **Actions to Take** and the **Actions to Avoid**.

ACTIONS TO TAKE

1. Research the average salary and salary ranges for the type of job in your location.
2. Be realistic in your expectations.
3. Be aware of your strengths and accomplishments so you can show the value you'll bring to the employer.
4. Be open minded about the offer and maintain a professional and positive attitude during the negotiation phase. Allow the employer to initiate the salary negotiation; this can give you a better understanding of their budget and potentially a stronger negotiating position. By knowing the salary range, you will have an idea of the interviewer's negotiating parameters.
5. Consider every aspect of the compensation and benefits package, not just the base salary or any one part of the offer package.
6. Try to negotiate other parts of your offer (e.g., shorter probationary period, sign-on bonus, more vacation, etc.) if the employer can't match your desired salary.
7. Aim high when stating your desired salary range, as you can always come down but cannot talk your way back up if you aim too low.
8. Prepare your list of skills, experience, and added value to support your requested compensation.

ACTIONS TO AVOID

1. Negotiating the job offer right after the offer is made. You need time to analyze the offer package and come up with negotiation strategies.
2. Making a decision based solely on the salary. Many other benefits offered should also be considered such as health care, retirement, or days off.
3. Trying to leverage one job offer against another job. It can and typically will backfire. Don't assume that a company will match another company's offer.
4. Accepting an offer before you've seen all the terms in writing.
5. Getting overly aggressive in negotiating the salary you want, and don't negotiate using ultimatums.
6. Accepting the first salary offer you receive without due diligence. You want to be confident and excited about the job, company, and opportunity for growth.
7. Acting too eager to accept, even if the offer was more than you expected, as most employers leave room to negotiate.
8. Providing your current compensation or your financial obligations as a reason the employer should pay more.

Quote

"Salary negotiations shouldn't be limited to just salary. Salary pays your mortgage, but terms build your career."

– Christopher Voss, Author and Negotiation Expert

HOW TO NEGOTIATE

A salary negotiation should have a win-win outcome. The plan is that you will establish a positive working relationship with this employer.

An in-person negotiation offers the advantage of addressing the employer's objection(s) on the spot. If the job you are applying for is one where an offer may be made at the end of the interview, you should be prepared to negotiate at that point.

An in-writing negotiation can give you the opportunity to word your remarks carefully. It gives the employer a chance to evaluate your ideas, talk them over with others, and make a counteroffer. It avoids instant refusal. Remember to keep the letter positive and factual.

Whether negotiations are performed in person or in writing, you must think like an employer and strategize. Evaluate where you meet or exceed the job preferences or requirements.

Use the following guidelines when composing a salary negotiation email:

1. **Recipient**. Usually, the hiring manager or interviewer who extended the offer.
2. **Subject Line**. Clearly state what the email is about.
3. **Salutation or Greeting**. A suitable greeting, such as Dear Mr./Ms. First Name Last Name.
4. **Paragraph 1 – Opening**. Start by showing your appreciation for the job offer (or for the Position Title) and the hiring manager's time throughout the job-hiring process. You can also include your excitement for the opportunity.
5. **Paragraph 2 – Proposal**. Make your case. Identify what is acceptable, and what you want to negotiate. Explain and justify why you are requesting the specified changes to the initial offer. Discuss the skills and experience that you offer. Use a persuasive argument in this initial communication. Include the new proposal along with supporting information. Restate your qualifications for the job, and whether you are willing to accept other forms of compensation, such as additional paid time off, in lieu of a higher salary.
6. **Paragraph 3 – Closing**. Reiterate your interest in the position. Be genuine so the employer knows it is worth their time to try to make your request work and thank them for the offer.
7. **Signature**. Use the same method to sign this email as you did with other correspondence during the job search. You can end with any of the following: Sincerely, Regards, or Best.

As with any communication with prospective employers, keep your salary negotiation emails polite, professional, and direct. Be respectful of the hiring manager's time. Be firm, but not pushy. Strive for a tone of thankfulness for the opportunity you've been offered. You want to join their team and they want you to join their team.

SALARY NEGOTIATION EMAIL EXAMPLE

Let's review the following salary negotiation email example to find out how the guidelines apply.

KP Enterprises, Atlanta, GA Operations Manager Salary Discussion

Dear Mr. Whitfield,

Thank you for the Operations Manager job offer! I am confident I will make a significant contribution to the growth and efficiency of the team over the short and long term. The terms you have described in the offer are acceptable, except for the base salary offer of $40,000 per year.

The research I've completed on comparable salaries in Atlanta, Georgia, shows that a base salary range of $45,000 to $52,000 would be appropriate. My eight years of expertise overseeing technical operations and supervising technical teams allows me to immediately be an asset to the organization with little to no training time involved. Additionally, my volunteer experience for local community programs not only increased my knowledge of how to develop personal and professional relationships, but also aligns with the company's core value of caring. Based on the above, I would ask you to kindly consider, as a compromise, a base salary of $47,000.

I am excited for the chance to work with KP Enterprises as an Operations Manager. I look forward to speaking with you again soon.

Regards,

Jules Mendez

OFFER EVALUATION AND NEGOTIATION

So far, we have discussed negotiation preparation, actions to take and avoid, and reviewed guidelines when composing a salary negotiation email.

There is no definitive timeline for salary discussions. Usually, a counteroffer is made between 24-48 hours after receiving the job offer. Today's practice involves an on-the-spot job offer negotiation simulation. This will allow you to develop crucial strategic communication and persuasion skills. It will also give you better insight into the value of negotiating more than just your salary.

ACTIVITY 6.3: JOB OFFER NEGOTIATION

Goal: To work as a team to negotiate a complete job offer package that maximizes the Candidate's priorities and understanding that a Hiring Manager has flexibility in benefits and logistics, even when salary is fixed.

Your Task: Your group has 15 minutes to analyze and negotiate the **Candidate's Priorities** and the **Hiring Manager's Constraints** on the Scenario Worksheet, along with their added flexibilities. You must find creative trade-offs (using PTO/Holiday, Tuition/Professional Development, and the Sign-On Bonus) to make the final offer acceptable to both parties.

1. Group Roles
You will be assigned one of the following roles within your group:

Role	Responsibility	Key Action
Hiring Manager	The final decision-maker. Must enforce the budget cap of **$80,000** for salary but can strategically leverage high-flexibility items (PTO/ Holidays, Tuition/Professional Development, and Sign-On Bonus).	Follow your salary constraints and offer alternatives. Tip: In this activity, the manager and negotiators will research the flexible items and add your own additions and limitations on those items.
Candidate	The person whose priorities (vacation, higher pay, education) the team must try to satisfy.	Clearly articulate the *value* of each priority item to the team.
Strategist(s)/Negotiator(s)	The analysts who review the numbers and suggest trade-off ideas. They assist the manager in gathering flexibilities to include for PTO/Holiday and Tuition/ Professional Development by doing research and guiding both parties toward a solution.	Propose creative solutions using flexible items to bridge the gaps.

2. Key Ground Rules

- **Win-Win Approach**: The goal is to reach a final agreement where both the Candidate accepts the job, and the Hiring Manager stays within budget. This is not "hardball"—it's problem-solving.
- **Salary Limit is FIRM**: The Hiring Manager **cannot** offer more than **$80,000** in base salary. You must use the Sign-On Bonus or other benefits to offset the difference.
- **Focus on Trade-Offs**: Every time you can't meet a Candidate's need directly, use the flexibilities you added. You want to hire this person, so you want to make it work.

3. Final Step

After negotiations are complete, fill out "The Final Offer Package" table on your scenario worksheet with the agreed-upon terms. Then, choose one person from your group to be ready to share your negotiation strategy during the class discussion.

SCENARIO WORKSHEET: JOB OFFER AND ITEMS TO NEGOTIATE

You have received an initial job offer for a **Defense Engineer** position. Your group must act as a negotiation team (Candidate, Manager, Strategists) to come up with a final offer package that satisfies as many of the Candidate's needs as possible while respecting the Manager's constraints.

INITIAL JOB OFFER DETAILS

Candidates must decide which items are most important to them. **Place an "H" for High priority, "M" for Medium priority, and "L" for Low Priority based on your personal goals.**

Item	Current Offer	Candidate's Needs/ Wants	Personal Priority Levels (H, M, L)
Salary	$77,500	Wants $82,000 or more.	
Start Date	Next Monday (ASAP)	Needs to start 30 days from Monday (due to a prepaid vacation).	
Paid Time Off (PTO)/ Holidays	2 weeks (10 days)	Wants 3 weeks (15 days) at minimum.	
Tuition/ Professional Development	Assistance Available (Amount not specified)	Wants the company to cover the $8,400/year local MBA program.	

HIRING MANAGER'S CONSTRAINTS (BUDGET & POLICY)

Item	Current Offer	Candidate's Needs/Wants
Salary	Cannot exceed **$80,000**.	This is a firm budget cap.
Start Date	Can only be delayed by a maximum of **3 weeks** (15 business days).	Some flexibility, but projects are urgent.
Paid Time Off (PTO)/ Holidays	Company policy allows a maximum of 3 weeks (15 days) for new hires.	Can grant the full 3 weeks without needing special approval. Anything more would require a request to corporate. Can consider holiday/work hours flexibility without approval. **(Tip: Research possible flexibilities a manager can use with holidays and hours)**
Tuition/ Professional Development	Can offer up to **$3,000 per year** without special approval.	Cannot cover the full $8,400 local MBA program cost. Can consider Tuition/ Professional Development flexibilities outside of the $3,000 cap. **(Tip: Research possible flexibilities a company can offer for Tuition and Professional Development)**
Sign-On Bonus	Can offer up to **$5,000** if salary negotiation fails.	Must be used strategically; company prefers not to offer it unless absolutely necessary.

Final Negotiation Task (15 Minutes)

As a team, you must decide on the final, accepted offer. Your goal is to maximize the Candidate's satisfaction by leveraging the Manager's flexibility on non-salary items.

Instructions:

1. **Candidates** need to look at the offer and decide what their priorities are and document it in their chart.
2. **Managers and Negotiators** will take a few minutes to research what other flexibilities could be offered for PTO/Holidays as well as Tuition/Professional Development, decide which they would like to add as additional items to offer, and fill in the column with what you decided to add. Do not share details with candidates until you are ready to negotiate.
3. Begin the discussion by allowing the **Candidate** to state what they do not accept from the offer and state what they would like based on their priorities.
4. **Managers** will begin to use their newly selected flexibilities within PTO/Holidays, Tuition/Professional Development and Sign-On Bonus and the listed fixed constraints to move closer to the Candidate's $82,000 salary goal (which is impossible) and 30-day start date (which is also impossible).
5. Come up with a single, finalized offer package below.

MANAGER'S PERSONAL FLEXIBILITIES

Item	New Flexibilities to Offer (Candidate is not aware of)
Paid Time Off (PTO)/Holidays	
Tuition/Professional Development	

THE FINAL OFFER PACKAGE

Decision: What was the best offer the **Candidate** was willing to accept?

Item	Final Accepted Terms	Trade-Off/Justification (How did you leverage this?)
Salary	$	
Start Date		
Paid Time Off (PTO)		
Tuition/Education		
Sign-On Bonus	$	

Tips for accepting the offer.

- If you only take an offer to bridge the gap for something at a higher salary, you may regret it later. It can lead to short-term job retention and can burn bridges.
- Or you may love the job but begrudge it because you missed out on negotiating the salary you deserve.



Tips for negotiating the offer.

- If you are happy with the job and benefits, negotiate your salary! You lose out if you decline a job that you want, because you did not attempt to negotiate.
- Stay flexible to consider all elements of the offer. Remember, salary is not the only thing you can negotiate.
- Negotiation is not an ultimatum; it is a conversation.
- First, set your range. You should know your walk-away amount. Your lowest acceptable salary should be determined through research and consideration of worth, skills, and experience.
- A negotiation is not a continuous back-and-forth activity. You should be comfortable in the range or amount you initially request.



Tips for declining the offer.

- You can always decline an offer. You may feel that your worth is so much more than the total compensation offered.
- If you want the job and the salary is the only obstacle, always negotiate before declining an offer.



Remember:

1. Salary negotiations may seem adversarial, but the employer's offer confirms that they want you to join their organization. Respond to their offer with this in mind.
2. Know your market worth and your budgetary needs before negotiations begin.
3. Salary means more than just a salary number. Consider the benefits package as well.
4. Define your walk-away point.
5. Avoid saying a number first.
6. Ask for time.
7. Prepare talking points.
8. Identify and discuss three ways to respond to a job offer (through practice negotiation scenarios).
9. Ask for more than your target number.
10. Be flexible.
11. Do not be afraid to walk away.

COMMUNICATING YOUR DECISION

NEGOTIATION OUTCOME

Remember, this is a collaborative negotiation where you and the employer want a positive outcome. If necessary, you can accept the offer as presented or if you are unable to find middle ground during your negotiations with your employer and you choose to decline their offer, you can thank them for their offer and respectfully decline.

JOB OFFER COMMUNICATION

After all the work you have done researching, building your brand, networking, applying to jobs, and interviewing, you've been offered the position. Job well done!

In this section, you will learn how to effectively communicate your decision to the employer.

Consider the following:

- Are you comfortable with asking for more time to consider? If not, what do you need to do to be comfortable?
- Do you understand that maintaining professionalism when accepting, delaying, or rejecting an offer can impact future opportunities?

After evaluating the job offer, and possibly negotiating, communicate your decision to the employer. Based on the timeline the employer provides, communicate your decision either verbally or in writing: accept the offer, request for more time to give a decision, or reject the offer.

ACCEPT THE OFFER

Accepting a job offer is a big decision. Do not rush to give an immediate answer. It is a good idea to ask for time to consider the offer. Use that time to talk to your family and friends about the opportunity and evaluate the job offer. If you accept the position, ensure you thank the employer for the opportunity, and verify the salary, benefits, position, and starting date.

When you receive a job offer, follow the instructions in the offer and meet the prescribed deadlines.

OFFER ACCEPTANCE EXAMPLE EMAIL:

Dear Mr. Patel:

It was wonderful to speak with you on the phone yesterday about the Program Director position at Zen Company. I'm thrilled to formally accept this job offer. I'm looking forward to working with you and the rest of the senior management team on charting a new direction for our marketing strategy.

It is my understanding that the conditions of my employment are as follows:

My start date will be May 13th.

Annual salary of $60,000.

Benefits include accident, health, and life insurance, which are effective on my start date.

My probationary period lasts 90 days, with an initial performance and salary review after that time.

Vacation and sick leave accrue at a rate of one day per month and are cumulative.

I'm looking forward to seeing you next Monday. Please let me know if there is any paperwork or additional information you need from me beforehand, or if there is any documentation that I should bring along on my first day.

Sincerely,
Kelly Barrett

ASK FOR MORE TIME TO EVALUATE / NEGOTIATE THE OFFER

The employer may expect you to request time to consider the offer or to make a counteroffer. To request a delay of the decision, start by relaying your thanks and appreciation for the job offer. Then ask what the deadline is to get back with your decision.

REQUEST A DELAY EXAMPLE EMAIL:

Dear Mr. Patel,

Thank you very much for offering me the position for the Program Director position at Zen Company. I greatly enjoyed our conversation. I would like to take 48 hours to consider your offer and discuss this opportunity with my family. Is there a deadline for my response?

Sincerely,
Kelly Barrett

NEGOTIATION EXAMPLE EMAIL:

Dear Mr. Patel,

Thank you for extending the offer to join Zen Company. I am enthusiastic about the opportunity and eager to contribute my skills and experience to the team.

After reviewing the offer, I would like to discuss the proposed salary of $60,000. Based on my qualifications and experience, I believe a salary of $70,000 more accurately reflects my expertise and the value I bring to the role.

Your job posting outlines the following requirements, and I believe my background exceeds these expectations:

- **Education**: The role requires a bachelor's degree, with a preference for a master's.
  - I hold both a **Bachelor's degree in Business** and a **Master's degree in Project Management,** surpassing the preferred qualifications.
- **Experience**: The position seeks four years in a related field.
  - I bring **over 12 years of experienc**e, including expertise in data analysis, project management, and team leadership.
- **Skills**: The role highlights teamwork, punctuality, Microsoft proficiency, and remote work experience.
  - My **15 years of military service** honed my leadership, collaboration, and adaptability skills, including managing teams of up to 250 people in dynamic environments, to include virtually/remote.

Given these qualifications and my ability to contribute meaningfully to the team, I respectfully request that you consider adjusting the salary offer to $70,000. I appreciate your time and consideration and look forward to discussing this further. Thank you again for this opportunity. I look forward to your response.

Sincerely,
Kelly Barrett

DECLINE / REJECT THE OFFER

If you decide to reject the offer, communicate quickly with the employer, and express your gratitude for their time. You never know to whom they are connected. Even if the negotiation did not go the way you hoped, continue being professional and gracious.

OFFER REJECTION EXAMPLE EMAIL:

Dear Mr. Patel,

Thank you for offering me the Program Director position at Zen Company and for reviewing my counteroffer with management. I fully understand that budgets are tight, but I must respectfully decline the position at the current compensation.

Thank you for your graciousness during the negotiation process. I wish you and Zen Company all the best.

Sincerely,
Kelly Barrett

SALARY NEGOTIATIONS SECTION REVIEW

You can approach your next job search and salary negotiation with knowledge and confidence.

In this section, you have learned how to:

- determine a reasonable salary range.
- compare a job announcement posting and requirements to your experience and education.
- evaluate and negotiate job offers.
- identify and discuss three ways to respond to a job offer.

7 Conclusion

SECTION 7: CONCLUSION

WORKSHOP GOALS

We have covered a lot of information over these two days. We took a deep dive into several important employment topics such as resume styles, the federal hiring system, networking, interview techniques, and salary negotiation.

Knowing and understanding the fundamental concepts of a job search and the Pro Tips associated with them, provides you with an advantage over other applicants. Most job seekers approach the process on their own without these tips or without a plan.

You learned the importance of **Developing Your Brand** and ways of marketing yourself to stand out to employers. You also learned the important concept of **Think Like An Employer** and how looking through that lens helps you create a resume and interview using STAR to stand out. Finally, you know the value of **Maximizing Your Resources**. We have provided you with many additional websites and resources to help you on your journey and we have made it easy to access all of those resources using this DOL VETS Resource Guide. (https://dol.gov/DOLEWmaterials)

You learned how to:

- write a master or targeted resume.
- use resources to assist you with the federal employment process.
- expand your network, including using social media.
- develop interview strategies and practice answering questions.
- conduct salary negotiations and respond to job offers.

Your job search now requires motivation and courage to take the next steps. To maximize your success, focus on these key actions: Market yourself, aggressively network, and tighten up your resume and LinkedIn profile. Don't hesitate to dig into the provided resources and reach out to available agencies for support. Start identifying and collecting your professional references and continue practicing your interview responses.

You have participated in a unique program – the Transition Assistance Program – which provides information and tools to give you a great starting point when you are ready to embark on your job search in civilian life.

Congratulations on taking this step towards reaching your post-transition goals!

THANK YOU

Thank you for your participation and your service. The DOL stands ready to provide you with the information and support you need to move forward with your transition. We recognize your devotion, commitment, and the sacrifices that you and your family members make each day to protect and defend our freedom. We are dedicated to supporting you in your transition and beyond.

8 Appendices

SECTION 8: APPENDICES

APPENDIX A: RESUME QUIZ

Answers to the Resume Quiz on Page 18.

1. **The number one rule for writing a good resume is "more is better."**

   FALSE: An employer reviews a resume, on average, less than 30 seconds, so there is a very short amount of time to catch their attention.

2. **Regardless of your age, your resume work history should list all jobs going back to high school.**

   FALSE: The guideline for work experience history is about 10 years unless the employer requests more information or older experience is specifically relevant. Federal resumes and applications may also require a longer and more comprehensive history.

3. **Your targeted resume should not be longer than two pages.**

   TRUE: In most cases, the length of your targeted resume depends on the employer and their requirements.

4. **The best resume is flexible enough to cover various job options within your professional field of interest.**

   FALSE: Resumes need to be targeted for specific job postings. A networking or general resume may be used at certain times, but when applying for a job, a targeted resume is recommended.

5. **A good resume paints a clear picture of you, including your height, weight, race, age, marital status, and number of children.**

   FALSE: It is important to stay away from discriminatory types of information. The items listed in this statement are not requirements for doing a job and would not be necessary to include.

6. **Employers like to see that you are interested in things other than just your job, so include volunteer work, continued education, and association involvements.**

   TRUE: Remember to include things other than your jobs that are relevant to the specific position. Resumes can include paid and unpaid (volunteer) work to show experience.

7. **All resumes should contain the complete names, addresses, and telephone numbers of your references.**

   FALSE: References will be on a separate document and will be provided to the employer if they ask. Some online resume applications will ask for this information, so it is important to identify your references in advance.

8. **To help your resume stand out, you should make it as unusual as possible by printing it on brightly colored paper or including a picture of yourself.**

   FALSE: Avoid using gimmicks that you think will get your resume reviewed. It will most likely backfire, and you will be remembered—but not in a good way.

9. **A well-written resume is sufficient to get you the job you want.**

   FALSE: Resumes are designed to get you into the interview seat, and the interview plays a major role in your hiring process.

10. **It is always better to spend money getting a professional resume writing service to write your resume for you as opposed to doing it yourself.**

    FALSE: Most resume writing service providers will need a great deal of assistance from you, so it will not save time and will cost you money. Furthermore, if you follow the best practices discussed in this curriculum, you will understand how to write your resume and will not need their help.

APPENDIX B: EMAIL EXAMPLES FOR NETWORKING

INTRODUCE YOURSELF TO A FRIEND OF A FRIEND

Hello Kathy,

My name is Steve, and I'm good friends with Jade Johnson, who passed along your contact information to me.

Jade mentioned that we share a background in education, and that you live in the San Diego area. She said you'd be a great person to get to know! So, I thought I'd reach out, introduce myself, and let you know that I'd love to find out more about you and your experience in Southern California.

I will be relocating to San Diego this summer and with 10 years in education, I will be looking for opportunities in the area. Any insights or tips you have for going into this field would be greatly appreciated. Looking forward to connecting with you.

Sincerely,

Steve Reynolds

TO AN ALUMNI

Dear Dr. Patel,

I hope all is well. My name is Lou Adams, and I am currently a student at U-State. I found your name on our alumni association and am very interested in learning more about the environmental engineering field. I would love to understand more about your role at your company and how you got started in such an exciting and competitive industry. Would you be willing to spend some time speaking with me about your experience and background?

I have attached a copy of my resume for your information so that you can have a little more background about me. I am hopeful that you will be willing to have a phone conversation when your schedule allows. Thank you so much for your time. I look forward to hearing from you.

Kind Regards,

Lou Adams

TO A TRADE ASSOCIATION CONTACT

Hi Kelly,

It was so nice to meet you at the marketing association meeting and chat about content marketing trends for military spouses. After our conversation, I found this article interesting and enlightening, so I thought I would pass it along.

Again, I really enjoyed meeting you, and I'm looking forward to keeping in touch. Don't hesitate to reach out if you want to get together and bounce around some more ideas. I'd love that!

Yours Truly,

Steve Reynolds

TO ASK A VOLUNTEER COLLEAGUE TO INTRODUCE YOU TO ANOTHER

Hi Anne!

It was so nice to work with you at the Food Bank last Friday. I enjoyed our conversation. As we were talking about my upcoming move to San Diego, you mentioned that you have a friend who works as an educator in the public school system there. I am interested in knowing more about that area and the education system. If you're willing, an introduction to your friend would be so helpful for me to gain insight about the education market in San Diego.

I've included an easy-to-copy blurb to provide context, but let me know if there's any other information I can provide. I appreciate your help!

Message: Hi , [Insert friend's name], I have connected with a new friend, Steve, at the food bank, who is moving to San Diego soon, and I told him about you and your experience with the education system. He is also an educator and wants to continue his career in California. He would love to connect with you to learn about the local market as he works on his licensing requirements. Do you mind if I connect you both so you can provide him with any guidance you have to offer?

Kind Regards,

Steve Reynolds

TO CONNECT ON SOCIAL MEDIA

Hi May,

I'm also a member of the Pioneering Marketing Facebook group and I always find your posts to be incredibly helpful and thought-provoking. I'd love to be able to keep in touch and hear more about your work.

Respectfully,

Steve Reynolds

TO A NEW CONTACT MET AT A NETWORKING EVENT MEETING

Hi Kevin,

It was such a pleasure having the chance to meet you at the Propel Networking Event yesterday. Thank you so much for your time and for sharing your story about some of your struggles breaking into the advertising industry. As I begin my career, would it be alright to stay in contact with you if I have any questions? Again, thank you so much for your time.

Regards,

Steve Reynolds

INVITATION TO CONNECT ON LINKEDIN

Hello Simone Jackson,

I found your profile on the Veteran to Contractor Network page and wanted to reach out to discuss your career path, as we have similar backgrounds. I would like to connect with you on LinkedIn to create a mutually beneficial networking opportunity.

Sincerely,

Steve Reynolds

TO CONTACT A BUSINESS OWNER (REFERRAL WAS THE AMERICAN JOB CENTER)

Hello Hector,

My name is Steve Reynolds. I have recently relocated to the area and would like to learn more about starting my own business in event planning. Mr. John Smith from the American Job Center suggested that I reach out to you for advice.

Mr. Smith explained your extensive experience in catering and event planning across the tri-state area. I also have experience in the industry but am new to this market. It would be great to sit with you and learn more about the local area and industry, as well as the "dos" and "don'ts" as I get started on my own business.

If you're open to it, I'd love to buy you a coffee to find out more about your experience and get your advice.

Best regards,

Steve Reynolds

TO CONTACT A FORMER CO-WORKER, COLLEAGUE

Hi Curtis,

How are you? I hope you and the family are doing well. I will be joining you as a California resident soon. I am looking for a career in counseling as I complete my degree and relocate. I would love to chat with you, fill you in on what I'm thinking about, and hear the latest from you. It would be great to catch up.

Best regards,

Steve Reynolds

TO A PROFESSIONAL CONNECTION AT JOB FAIR

Dear Ms. Russo,

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me at the Virtual Career Fair today. You were extremely helpful in explaining Green Street's plans to expand and the challenges of finding people with the right skills to fill these new positions.

As I mentioned during our conversation, I have 5 years of experience in supporting and troubleshooting hardware, software, and networking issues. I have a strong background in all current versions of Microsoft Windows. I am certain my technical skills and experience would make me an asset to your team.

As you suggested, I submitted my application through Green Street's website, and have also attached my resume for your review. I would welcome the opportunity to talk with you again. I will follow-up with you next week. Again, thank you for your time.

Best regards,

Steve Reynolds

TO SET UP AN INFORMATIONAL INTERVIEW

Dear Mrs. Anderson,

We have a shared contact in Dr. Susan Smith, CEO of Boys and Girls Club. She suggested that I contact you for additional information regarding your career pathway in social services.

I recently completed a volunteer opportunity working with the Navy as a Child Development Specialist. I would like the opportunity to meet or speak with you to discuss your insights on the range of careers to pursue within the social services field, especially with my skills and experience. I understand that you are busy and would appreciate any time that you could spare to meet with me in person or by phone. May I have 15-20 minutes of your time at some point over the next few weeks to ask you a few questions?

Any suggestions you could offer would be greatly appreciated. Thank you for your time.

Best regards,

Steve Reynolds

APPENDIX C: COMMON INTERVIEW QUESTIONS FOR MANAGEMENT OR LEADERS

For those seeking management-level positions, the following questions will help you prepare for your interview. These questions are designed to see how well you relate to your peers, as well as those who work for you.

1. “Describe your process for delegating tasks to your team.”

   This is one of the more popular manager interview questions because, as a manager, delegation is a regular part of the job. Managers who delegate well are more productive, and so are their teams.

2. “How would you handle a project that was running over budget?”

   This question is asked for two reasons: to learn how you handle stress and to understand your budgeting skills. Your interviewer will want to see how you prioritize tasks and which hard or soft skills you use to rein in the cost and make the rest of the project run efficiently.

3. “How do you keep your team motivated?”

   As a leader, your team looks to you to set the tone of morale and motivation. In your answer, give specific examples of ways in which you provided positive reinforcement to your team, encouraged them to take the initiative, and understood each person’s strengths.

4. “What is your management style?”

   The best answer offers a broad scope rather than a specific answer. In your response, highlight your ability to handle situations and problems as a manager while talking about real experiences. You will need to define what a good manager is and provide an example of how you use that skill as a leader.

5. “How do you support an employee who is not meeting expectations?”

   Interviewers ask this question to determine how you will work with a direct report to guide them back onto the path of success. They will look for methods, such as giving clear feedback to an employee and jointly developing an action plan to support meeting future performance goals.

6. “Give an example of how you have had to provide negative feedback. What was your approach?”

   Interviewers look to see how you deliver feedback to your staff. In your response, include that your feedback was specific and done promptly to address the situation.

7. “Do you consider yourself to be an organized person?”

   Interviewers want to know how you prioritize your time and which tools you use to help you along the way. In your response, share examples of your time-management skills and show off your flexibility.

8. “How would your coworkers describe you? How would your direct reports describe your management style?”

   These questions are designed to see how well you relate to your peers, as well as those who work for you. Your answer is a great opportunity to speak about your strengths. Ideally, talk about the characteristics that make you an excellent manager.

APPENDIX D: ANDREW THOMPSON'S TRANSITION DOCUMENTS

Master Resume Example. The Master Resume is your reference document and is not provided to the employer.

Andrew Thompson II

(301) 555-5555 • andrewthompson2nd@gmail.com • linkedin.com/in/andrew-thompson2nd

Summary of Qualifications

Astute military professional with 13 years comprehensive ground combat experience that includes wide-ranging training and simulation participation to ensure maximum readiness. Extensive knowledge of ground surveillance protocols, mine detection techniques, and explosives removal procedures. Proven ability to adapt to new surroundings while remaining continuously observant, physically capable, and mentally alert under pressure.

- Active security clearance
- Experienced with patrols, security, and conducting safety investigations
- Expert weapons qualifications on automatic and semi-automatic weapons
- Able to operate, troubleshoot, and repair radios and other electronic equipment
- Effective manager and team player
- Instructor and test evaluator for numerous Soldiers on a variety of subjects
- Fluent in Spanish and English

Work Experience

Infantryman, Fort Campbell, KY, U.S. Army, **March 20XX - Present**

Served as Team Leader for 15-person team.
Supervisor: John Doe, Contact: hisname@email.com

- Supervised, trained, and ensured the safety and welfare of a 15-person team, maintaining a 100% safety record.
- Communicated weekly status reports of ongoing projects and problem resolution through professional verbal and written presentations to leadership and stakeholders.
- Maintained security of classified information.
- Scored in the top 10% of a 100-person organization during the semi-annual physical fitness training. Received an Ironman designation. Trained with 5th Special Forces Group in conventional warfare.

Served as Expert Infantryman instructor for unit and test evaluator for adjacent units.
Supervisor: Jane Doe, Contact: hername@email.com

- Managed training programs, ensuring all personnel were compliant with required training.
- Developed training on a variety of subjects such as weapons handling, search and reconnaissance, and tactical maneuvers, ensuring all training standards were met.
- Served as an instructor and test evaluator in five different subject areas. Provided instruction, testing, and certification for more than 25 employees preparing for temporary overseas assignments. Recognized by leadership for resourceful problem-solving techniques.

Infantryman, 12-month deployment to Afghanistan, **March 20XX - March 20XX**

Served as Team Leader for six-person team.
Supervisor: Jerry Doe, Contact: hisname@email.com

- Inspected team members' weapons and equipment for proper operation and 100% serviceability prior to deployment.
- Supervised, trained, and ensured the safety and welfare of all assigned personnel and sustained a 100% safety record.
- Selected out of 150 personnel in the unit and appointed to the distinguished position of Company Sniper.
- Successfully completed more than 15 sniper missions, enhanced overall safety of military patrol missions.
- Oversaw facility and personnel security for 150-person unit.
- Escorted key leadership personnel during multi-national exercises.
- Maintained security of classified materials ensuring all policies and procedures were executed.
- Liaised with Security Agency personnel, providing local area guidance.
- Managed facility, personnel, and communications security at 2 Closed Areas.
- Recognized by supervisors for excellent performance and awarded an Army Commendation medal during Operation Enduring Freedom.

Assigned to Post Ammunition Supply Point for 2 months.
Supervisor: Mike Doe, Contact: hisname@email.com

- Loaded, secured, and unloaded high explosive artillery rounds in vehicles.
- Conducted daily safety inspections throughout the facility.
- Implemented access control measures to ensure only authorized personnel entered the facility.
- Conducted thousands of searches of vehicles and personnel entering the facility with zero breaches of security.
- Conducted weekly inventories of ammunition.

Infantryman, Ft. Drum, NY, **March 20XX - April 20XX**
Supervisor: Amy Doe, Contact: hername@email.com

- Operated and maintained 100% accountability for over $100,000 of equipment, including night vision goggles, multiband radios, laser target locator, and mine detection equipment.
- Certified to operate wheeled and tracked vehicles.
- Performed preventive maintenance checks and services before and after each trip.
- Inspected, issued, and maintained 100% accountability for unit's chemical, biological, radiological, and nuclear defense equipment, including personal protective gear and hazard detection devices.
- Earned Expert Infantry Badge.

Basic and Infantry Training, Fort Benning, GA, December 20XX - February 20XX

Key skills acquired:

- Safe handling of explosives
- Land navigation
- Operation of radios and other electronic equipment
- Emergency medical aid

Retail Associate, 6-12 Convenience Store, Eastport, MD, August 20XX - December 20XX

- Led team of ten employees, ensuring full schedule coverage for all shifts.
- Trained new employees on computers, including point of sale systems, ensuring compliance with company policies and procedures.
- Stocked display shelves and conducted weekly inventory reviews, ensured adequate stock and resupply.
- Monitored and managed accounting and reporting for over $500K in inventory on a quarterly basis to ensure accurate balancing.
- Fostered customer loyalty by providing friendly and efficient service and problem resolution.

Education

- **Bachelor of Science, Business Administration and Management**, University of Maryland Global Campus, Adelphi, MD
- **Associate degree, Business Administration**, Howard Community College, Baltimore, MD
- High School Diploma, Columbia High School, Columbia, MD

Military Training

- Basic Combat Training, Infantry School, Fort Benning, GA 20XX Advanced Individual Training: Infantry School, Fort Benning, GA 20XX Combat Sniper Course, US Army 20XX
- Combat Lifesaver Course, US Army 20XX
- Infantry Drivers' Academy Course, US Army 20XX Management Development Course
- Sexual Harassment/Assault Response and Prevention Training (annually)

Job Posting Example: Andrew Thompson II

Facility Security Officer

About Us:

At Grayson Missiles & Defense, you have the opportunity to make a bigger difference across a broader end-to-end solution, an expanded range of disciplines, a growing global footprint, and a more diverse team of colleagues and customers.

Job Summary:

Provide oversight and leadership of the following elements of the National Industrial Security Program (NISP): Personnel & Facility clearances, Training & Briefings, Classification & Markings, Administrative Inquiries, Safeguarding, Classified Visits & Meetings, Classified Subcontracting, Communications Security (COMSEC), and DOW Closed Areas.

Responsibilities to Anticipate:

- Administer the company programs for handling and safeguarding classified and proprietary information.
- Coordinate with government and industry oversight agencies to obtain authorizations, facilitate inspections/audits of security programs and systems.
- Write policy and procedures to enforce compliance with government and Company requirements.
- You will investigate security incidents, violations, and prepare reports detailing procedures to preclude future occurrences.
- You will lead facility level Insider Threat Program, security incident response, and workplace violence prevention team.
- Provide guidance, subject matter expertise, and mentorship to security personnel.
- You must hold a current Secret Clearance and be able to obtain a Top Secret Clearance.

Qualifications You Must Have:

- Typically requires Bachelor's degree in Business Management, Security, Global Security, or Criminal Justice, and eight (8) years of relevant experience.
- Experience in a leadership or supervisory role.
- Experience working with Defense Counterintelligence, Security Agency, and/or other Security Agency personnel at varying levels.

Qualifications We Value:

- Knowledge of customer security and acquisition structures.
- Excellent writing and verbal communication skills.
- The ability to perform effectively in a fast-paced, multi-program environment.
- Proactively partner with key leadership personnel at all levels, in full support of business objectives, while ensuring compliance with US Government and Company directives and policies.
- Expected to manage the Security Office ensuring compliance for all security requirements, and provide expertise concerning all security disciplines.

Targeted Combination Resume

Andrew Thompson II

(301) 555-5555 • Andrewthompson2nd@gmail.com • linkedin.com/in/andrew-thompson2nd

SECURITY SPECIALIST

Astute, detailed, self-motivated 12-year veteran, with a passion for excellence and strategic security solutions. Proven ability to adapt to new surroundings while remaining observant and accurately assessing security needs. Able to employ creative approaches and meet or exceed all designated objectives. Excellent written and verbal communication skills.

RELEVANT SKILLS

Security: Active Security Clearance, Counterintelligence, Security Program Oversight

Leadership: Supervisory Roles, Strategic Planning, Client Relations

Physical security: Personnel Security, Data Protection, Safeguarding Classified Materials

WORK EXPERIENCE

Safety and Security

- Conducted military-precision perimeter inspections and patrols in the U.S. and overseas, ensuring safety and security.
- Implemented control measures and guarded access points; performed lawful searches on thousands of individuals and vehicles; ensured security of controlled spaces.
- Monitored and investigated security violations; ensured 100% understanding of and compliance with all government directives and policies. Completed written reports.
- Oversaw facility and personnel security for 150-person unit as facility security officer.
- Maintained security of classified materials, ensuring all policies and procedures were executed.
- Coordinated Counterintelligence and Security Agency personnel providing local area guidance.
- Managed facility, industrial, and communications security at 2 DoD Closed Areas, escorted key leadership personnel during multi-national exercises.

Communication and Program Management

- Conducted security training and test evaluator for 25+ team members on a variety of subjects.
- Provided instruction, testing, and certifications in preparation for counterintelligence and security work in a war zone.
- Led, supervised, and provided mentorship to 15-person team, maintaining cohesiveness and open communication.
- Served as Subject Matter Expert on local area security on insider threat issues.
- Prepared weekly status reports of ongoing projects and problem resolution; communicated through verbal and written presentations to leadership and senior stakeholders.
- Operated and maintained 100% accountability for over $100,000 of equipment in fast-paced environment, including night vision goggles, multiband radios, laser target locator, and mine detection equipment.

WORK HISTORY

December 20XX – July 20XX, Security Specialist, U.S. Army, various locations in the US and overseas

EDUCATION & TRAINING

- Bachelor of Science, Business Management, University of Maryland Global Campus, Adelphi, MD
- Associates degree, Business Administration, Howard Community College, Baltimore, MD

Andrew Thompson II

(301) 555-5555 • andrewthompson2nd@gmail.com • linkedin.com/in/andrew-thompson2nd

September 1, 20XX

Pat Smith
Human Resources Manager
Grayson Missiles and Defense
321 Main Street
Norfolk, VA 21113

Dear Ms. Smith,

I am excited about the opportunity to apply for the position of Facility Security Officer. As a 12-year military veteran in the security and reconnaissance field, I feel I will be able to bring a fresh and global viewpoint to your security needs. I have led security teams as well as provided training and mentoring on many aspects of security.

I currently hold a Secret security clearance and a Bachelor's degree in Business Administration and Management, providing me the knowledge to successfully lead a team that is customer focused and security minded. I also have experience in managing programs as well as providing effective training. Additionally, in the military, I handled many background investigations with Defense Counterintelligence to ensure the appropriate people gained access to needed information and secured facilities.

I am excited at the prospect of bringing the skills I developed in the military to Grayson Missiles and Defense. Thank you for your consideration. I very much look forward to the opportunity to speak with you in person about my interest in this position.

Best Regards,

Andrew Thompson II

LinkedIn Profile

Sample Reference Page

Andrew Thompson II

(301) 555-5555 • andrewthompson2nd@gmail.com • linkedin.com/in/andrew-thompson2nd

References

CPT James Sweeny
Commanding Officer, US ARMY
123-456-7890
james.p.sweeny@us.army.mil

Philip Miller
Supervisor, 6-12 Convenience Store
987-6543-212
Philip.Masterson@SixTwelve.com

Antionette Johnson
College Advisor, UMGC
410-555-1234
Johnson.Antionette@UMGC.edu

Sample Letter of Recommendation

January X, 20XX

Human Resources Manager
Grayson Missiles and Defense
321 Main Street
Norfolk, VA 21113

Dear Hiring Manager:

It is my distinct pleasure to provide this recommendation for Andrew Thompson as he pursues a Facility Security Officer position with Grayson Missiles and Defense. I've known Andrew for over six years. For the past 3 years, I've had the privilege of supervising Andrew while he was assigned as one of my team leads with the responsibility of supervising, training, and ensuring the safety and welfare of more than 50 personnel. During that time, Andrew was able to sustain a 100% safety record. He is an extremely competent and enormously valuable team member, ready to step up to the next level.

Andrew is one of those rare finds, who I've seen adeptly navigate a variety of complex and multifaceted situations to beneficial outcomes, with sparse guidance, no matter the difficulty. He has proven to be extremely knowledgeable and reliable. He has excelled by using his leadership, influencing, and negotiating skills. He has developed strong relationships with internal and external partners. Through Andrew's expert guidance, our division successfully completed a rigorous assessment, where we received the highest grade admissible.

Andrew has become our resident expert in written and oral communication, and his planning and evaluating skills outshine his peers. His ability to assess security needs while planning and executing processes has always resulted in exceptional customer support.

I highly recommend Andrew Thompson for the Facility Security Officer position. He is extremely capable and committed. More than that, he has the requisite skills to lead an organization now and into the future.

If I can provide any additional information to validate that Andrew would be the perfect candidate for your position, please contact me at 123-456-7890.

Sincerely,

J. Sweeny

Commanding Officer

KENDRA KNOWLES

512-555-1212 | KKnowles@email.com
www.linkedin.com/in/kendra-knowles

PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

Skilled communications professional and executive administrator with over 10 years of experience providing customized customer and business solutions, specifically in the areas of client services, training and development, labor relations, and financial management. Detailed knowledge of business market programs and conducting market analyses. Areas of expertise include excellent communication skills; organizing and planning; able to type 75 words-per-minute without errors; familiarity with MS Office, Adobe Suite, Final Cut Pro, and QuickBooks.

EDUCATION

Kennesaw State University, Kennesaw, GA
Bachelor of Science in Communications

RELEVANT SKILLS

Marketing

- Created publications, such as informational brochures, company newsletters, blogs, and social media websites used to promote organization services.
- Assisted with coordination of fundraising events by soliciting sponsors, coordinating event venue, activities, and logistics which raised over $10,000 in support.
- Monitored current events using internet research to avoid scheduling conflicts.

Communication

- Built and maintained positive relationships with executives, staff, vendors, brokers, and local agencies to request quotes, develop contractual agreements, and identify employee services and support that followed organization, state, and federal regulations.
- Provided daily status updates to leadership via verbal and written communication to discuss and address operational issues or concerns.
- Attended meetings with Department of Labor, Internal Revenue Service, and Department of Transportation, as the primary point of contact for the organization, to gather and communicate compliance requirements to executives and staff, ensuring 100% adherence with operations safety procedures and policies.

Social Media/Advertising

- Created advertisement and marketing campaigns using X to promote business capabilities while expanding client footprint by 36%.

Office Operations

- Ordered and worked with vendors to maintain supplies and equipment, ensuring availability and operability of office automation products and tools.
- Organized, conducted, and documented minutes of daily conference calls and monthly meetings, including room set-up and breakdown to discuss schedule changes, project status, and regulatory updates, keeping employees and leadership abreast of operational changes.
- Maintained office organization by opening, routing, and filing daily documents, including profit loss and loss reports, incoming and outgoing mail, and receipts.
- Entered, updated, and maintained accurate personnel records for over 300 employees, which assisted with the efficient processing of employee entitlements.
- Supervised and trained 20 employees, including prioritizing daily assignments and tasks, reviewing performance, providing feedback, as well as executing award or disciplinary actions.

Financial Management

- Processed accounting actions, including license and insurance forms, accounts receivable, account payable, payroll tax and deductions valued at over $30,000 weekly to ensure timely payment to vendors and employees.
- Entered all payroll, fuel, and inbound and outbound invoices daily in Microsoft Excel to track and maintain status of financial operations.
- Developed and implemented commission-based financial incentive program for employees, increasing revenue by 75%.

WORK HISTORY

- January 20XX- Present – US Marine Corps, Camp Lejeune, NC
  Personnel Administrator
- June 20XX – December 20XX - Averitt Trucking Atlanta, GA
  Executive Assistant Internship
- September 20XX – December 20XX - Hands on Atlanta, Atlanta, GA
  Funding/Volunteer Coordinator (Volunteer position)

Avery Jackson

Norfolk, VA | (555) 123-4567 | Avery.Jackson@email.com | https://www.linkedin.com/in/xxxx-j

ADMINISTRATIVE PROFESSIONAL

U.S. Navy veteran with 3 years of experience in administrative support. Experienced as a front desk clerk handling high volume of incoming and outgoing phone calls and in-person requests. Ability to manage multiple priorities at one time in a fast-paced environment. Trained new hires and collaborated with managers and supervisors to coordinate facilities maintenance. Ability to work well individually and as a part of a team.

SKILLS

Communication & Customer Service: Strong active listening, excellent verbal communication, and customer service skills, with experience in complaint escalation and resolution.

Organization & Administration: Skilled in maintaining records, scheduling software, and policy implementation to support efficient operations.

Security & Confidentiality: Experienced in protecting personally identifiable information and handling sensitive data, with an active Security Clearance.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

UNITED STATES NAVY – Norfolk, VA October 20XX to October 20XX

Front Desk Clerk

Served as the first point of contact for military housing property management directorate, serving an installation-wide population of 10,000.

- Maintained highest level of integrity when handling sensitive and confidential information.
- Upheld property reputation for service excellence by personally handling escalated client concerns with 100% resolution.
- Maintained data security and confidentiality to safeguard personal information shared during registration.
- Fielded tough questions and provided answers, ensuring client understanding and reassurance.
- Increased team success by proactively developing strong working relationships with both team members and management.
- Managed caseload of 10 to 15 customer inquiries per hour with zero formal customer complaints.
- Offered and delivered customers' products and services based on their individual needs.

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

Tidewater Community College, Norfolk, VA
Associate in Applied Science, Business (21 credits)

Zachary Wallace

757-229-xxxx | xxxxx@gmail.com | https://www.linkedin.com/in/xxxx-w

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MEDICAL SERVICES ASSISTANT

U.S. Navy veteran with over 8 years of experience as a medical services assistant. Knowledge of Occupational Safety and Health requirements in a clinical setting. Experience using computer-aided design in the workplace. Ability to work in outdoor field environment.

SKILLS

Administrative & Technical Skills: Strong written and verbal communication, record-keeping, material procurement, and proficiency in Microsoft Word and Excel for efficient documentation and workflow management.

Safety & Compliance: Knowledge of OSHA regulations, job-site safety, attention to detail, and time management, with an active Security Clearance ensuring secure handling of sensitive information.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

UNITED STATES NAVY – Virginia Beach, VA May 20XX - Present

Dental Assistant (Hospital Corpsman)

- Assist dentists in preparation of work plans and procedures.
- Maintain examination rooms' sanitation as well as $30K supply ordering and delivery tracking.
- Assist in gathering data to perform job-hazard analysis, keeping clinic procedures and equipment within EPA standards.
- Assess all areas of risk within the clinic and draft plan to ensure public waterways are kept clean and address remediation of potential contamination sites.
- Interpret dental drawings and use CAD/CAM software to produce precise dental implants.
- Recognize discrepancies in material recordkeeping and solve shortage problems.

TEXAS HEALTH RESOURCES – Fort Worth, TX Oct. 20XX – Apr. 20XX

Patient Transporter

- Ensured the timely and safe transportation of patients within the hospital.
- Assisted staff and supervisors in training employees in proper safety procedures during lifting and transport.
- Maintained care of five emergency vehicles. Ensured supplies were maintained as well as vehicle safety checklists were completed.

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

Tidewater Community College, Hampton Roads, VA
Associate of Applied Science degree in
Engineering Technology

CERTIFICATIONS

OSHA-10

Chronological Resume

Taylor Brown

(555) 789-6543 • Taylor.brown@somedomain.com • LinkedIn URL

SUMMARY OF QUALIFICATIONS

- Seven years of emergency medical technician duties working at home station and in the field.
- Two years' experience as Lead Technician supervising a six-person medical team.
- Proficiency in Microsoft Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Access, and Outlook).
- Taught Emergency Medical Technician refresher courses to over 200 EMTs.
- Assisted physicians in the Emergency Department with trauma patients.
- Maintained National EMT, BLS, ACLS, and PALS.
- Mentored EMT students with clinical and classwork.
- Managed $85K medical supply account with 100% accountability.
- Fluent in English and German.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Emergency Medical Technician **June 20XX - Present**
Medical Center, Fort Drum, NY

- Administer basic and restricted advanced life support to patients on scene, en-route to hospital and in-hospital setting in accordance with federal, state and local laws and standards.
- Assess the nature and extent of injury or illness to establish and prioritize medical procedures.
- Rescue and extricate victims of accidents, sudden illness or entrapment using proper rescue and medical techniques.
- Perform procedures such as injections, immunizations, management of infection and EKGs.
- Perform phlebotomy on all age groups from newborn to geriatric.
- Participated in hospital performance improvement activities; improved safety and patient outcomes by 20%.

Emergency Medical Technician **July 20XX - June 20XX**
Deployment Site, Undisclosed

- Led 3-member response team, 4.8k clinical visits, 12 Aerovac missions, and over 350 ER runs, responding to all dispatches safely, ensuring life-saving techniques were executed.
- Performed lab tests and communicated results with 100% accuracy.
- Operated and maintained care of emergency vehicles to include supply maintenance and infection control.
- Thoroughly documented assessments, physical findings and treatment rendered in pre-hospital setting on patient care report within 24 hours of dispatch.

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

- Bachelor of Science in Emergency Medical Studies, GPA 3.75, University of Missouri, Columbia, MO
- Nationally Registered Emergency Medical Technician EMT-B, 2021 (initial certification in 20XX)
- ACLS and PALS certification, 20XX
- Emergency Vehicles Operations Course (EVOC)

Chronological Resume

Andrew Bowlin

Email | Phone | LinkedIn | Location

Logistics - Data Analyst - Training Specialist

Army veteran working in strategic supply and logistics planner with 7+ years of experience improving military movement capabilities. Expert in identifying capacity constraints. Thrives in leading decision analysis processes and optimizing supply chain capabilities through thoughtful and careful prioritization. Collaborative spirit and a bias for action.

Areas of Expertise

Data & Operational Analysis: Constraint planning, data analysis and visualization, forecasting, reporting, budgeting, compliance, and process improvement to optimize logistics and decision-making.

Leadership & Communication: Personnel management, relationship building, project management, and verbal, written, and presentation communication, with a Top Secret Security Clearance ensuring secure data handling.

Professional Experience

UNITED STATES ARMY **20XX - Present**

Policy and Plans Senior Analyst

Ft. Eustis, VA, 20XX – Present

- Spearhead Department of the Army's 10-year plan for personnel restructuring and reorganization.
- Identify key senior executive stakeholders and market plan and strategy, soliciting feedback, and integrating multiple conflicting processes.
- Develop, integrate, and manage training operations and requirements, concepts, policies, and plans across entire Human Capital Enterprise.

Operations Manager, Strategic Planner

Ft. Bliss, TX, 20XX – 20XX

- Oversaw acquisition of equipment for 4,000 personnel global military movement, resulting in on-time delivery and zero loss.
- Tracked key performance indicators to improve lead time in supply acquisition.
- Led high-level discussions with global stakeholders and cross-functional partners to resolve backlog issues and successfully ensured zero shortage related issues.
- Maintained critical inventory parameters, considering lead time and transportation constraints.
- Collaborated with remote organization headquarters and oversaw the restructuring of a 600-staff office.

Training and Development Specialist, Strategic Planner

Hohenfels, Germany, 20XX – 20XX

- Oversaw training program for multi-national organization and tracked and monitored improvements in all performance metrics.
- Trained users on processes and systems supply planning.
- Built effective relationships with senior trainers from partner countries.
- Provided consultation services to multi-national NATO military advisory teams.
- Researched all global regularity policies and presented constraints to senior executives.

Operations Officer

Ft. Stewart, GA, 20XX – 20XX

- Identified material shortages against inventory plans and developed action items.
- Responsible for long-term capacity status, weekly category KPI updates, product shortage reporting and ad-hoc daily information flow amongst supply planning partners.
- Evaluated and implemented solutions and ensured alignment of 60-person organization's global military movement capabilities.
- Led rapid problem-solving meetings with cross-functional partners, saving over $1M in supply loss.

Education

Master of Business Administration (MBA) | GPA 3.95

COLLEGE OF WILLIAM & MARY, Mason School of Business, Williamsburg, VA

Master of Arts (MA), International Relations

UNIVERSITY OF OKLAHOMA, Norman, OK

Bachelor of Arts (BA), History

UNIVERSITY OF CENTRAL FLORIDA, Oviedo, FL

Technical Experience

Advanced Planning Systems (TAMIS) (advanced)

Excel (advanced)

MS Office and Google Suite (advanced)

Learning Management Systems (DTMS) (advanced)

Tableau (intermediate)

Python (Basic)

SQL (Basic)

Certifications

Lean Six Sigma Green Belt (Mason School of Business) | August 2021

ROGER BLANC

(302) 465 – XXXX | roger_XXXX@yahoo.com | https://www.linkedin.com/in/rogerxxxxxx

PROGRAM MANAGEMENT | PROCESS IMPROVEMENT | STRATEGIC PLANNING

Aspiring Program Evaluator and Military Veteran with a Secret Security Clearance and over 10 years focused on delivering process improvements to meet strategic goals. Expert in cross-functional team building and leadership, multicultural communications, change management, organization development, project management, and quality performance improvement. Demonstrated capability to forge, cultivate and maintain deep relationships with and connections among a broad network of regional and local human services organizations. Possess a comprehensive background in establishing systems to identify and mitigate vulnerabilities and sources of instability that prevent organizational success from the strategic level to the execution level.

Data & Operational Analysis: Skilled in constraint planning, data analysis and visualization, forecasting, reporting, budgeting, compliance, and process improvement to optimize logistics and decision-making.

Leadership & Communication: Experienced in personnel management, relationship building, project management, and verbal, written, and presentation communication, with an active Security Clearance.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

United States Air Force (AF)– Various Locations **20XX – Present**

Program Manager, Electronic Security Systems Course **20XX – 20XX**

Oversaw Electronic Security Systems training with 190 SF operators and administrators annually for 10 Major Commands. Provided staff assistance for Security Forces/ESS Center, DoD contractor headquarters, and Air Force system administrators.

- Introduced Subject Matter Expert guest lecturers into the course; 58 classes/218 members inundated on the performance of work requirements between customers and clients using Installation Intrusion Detection Systems; decreased sensor downtime 30% within three Major Commands.
- Presented Problem Management process focused on improving installation security system purchase requests; approved 15 base protection projects, approved $1.3M project upgrades; co-chaired joint security effort amidst manpower shortage; revised two lesson plans and electronic study guides, saved unit $8.7K in printing costs.
- Appraised 27 student records; reviewed 21 classes, fixed 25 entries; rectified 5 student transcripts allowing the release of 54 CCAF credits, 1 CCAF awarded, and 13 special experience identifiers earned.
- Managed 25 instructors and 36 tech training teams for pandemic ops; rectified purchase request for Active-Duty unit; halted funding on three non-approved items--saved Air Force $350K and de-certified processes.

Instructor **20XX - 20XX**

Executed Incident response & Integrated Defense plan training for over 2K Active Duty, Air National Guard, and Air Force Reserve Non-Commissioned Officers each year. Instructed and awarded Security Forces, Civilians, and Department of Defense contractors on proper operations for Base security operating systems.

- Created training, progress checks and tests for the new Craftsman course; implemented DoD's only approved Electronic Security Systems course to certify Air Force Installation defense program managers.
- Hired, trained, and supported the development of 10 advanced course instructors; coordinated 14 faculty development courses/awarding 27 Community College of the Air Force credits.

- Led 4 Instructors to receive Master Instructor certifications: reallocated $90K in equipment throughout 4 Air Force career fields and enhanced combined operations.
- Trained 17 program managers on newly purchasable items; oversaw Electronic Security Systems course material updates; 5 system | 37 technical items | 46 additional training hours added to course material.

Program Manager **20XX – 20XX**

Managed 30 personnel, provisioning curriculum development, and training, covering subjects such as cross-cultural awareness, legal considerations, embassy operations, airfield survey techniques, explosive ordnance awareness, aircraft searches, and unarmed self-defense techniques. Created classroom training and practical exercises in antiterrorism/force protection, weapon system security, verbal judo, combative, tactical baton employment, and advanced firearms proficiency.

- Engineered an additional $1.2M annual spend; created cross-functional funding request with Special Warfare Center, allowing for 15 additional personnel, equipment, and training.
- Supported President of the United States press meeting; 17 missions, 30 days, 108K lbs. cargo, and 54 United States Secret Service agents; solidified African Union & American relations.
- Expedited 82 cargo on/off-loads; improved efficiency, and saved Air Force $36K in fuel annually; identified as “Key Player” for Air Mobility Command’s fuel-saving initiative program.

EDUCATION

Master of Science, Human Services | Wilmington University, New Castle, DE

Bachelor of Science, Psychology | Wilmington University, New Castle, DE

Associate of Applied Science, Criminal Justice
Community College of the Air Force, Montgomery, AL

Associate of Applied Science, Instructor of Technology and Military Science
Community College of the Air Force, Montgomery, AL

CERTIFICATIONS

Instructional Systems Specialist (GS-1750) | Enlisted Professional Military Education Instructor

Professional Manager | Air Education and Training Command Master Instructor

Community College of the Air Force Instructor /CIC-II/CIC-III

Analysis Design Development Implementation & Evaluation (ADDIE) Instructional Design

Lean Six Sigma- Green Belt| Certified Project Officer| Scrum Fundamentals

SPECIALIZED MILITARY TRAINING

Basic Instructor Course | Technical Writer Principles | Training Supervisor Course | Training Development Course

Training Management Course | Instructors Intervention Course | Electronic Security Systems Course | Wing Inspection Team Member

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Software: Microsoft Office Suite, Google Workspace, Zoom, Microsoft Teams

Operating Systems: Mac OS/ Microsoft Windows

Other Tools: SharePoint, Slack, Adobe, basic CRM or ERP systems

Chronological Resume

Devin Maley

Email | Phone | LinkedIn URL

Professional Summary

Mission-driven Intelligence Analyst with over twelve years of experience and expertise in conducting all-source intelligence analysis supporting full spectrum operations. Facilitated effective collaboration across echelons through systematic management, in-depth research, comprehensive analysis, processing, and dissemination of strategic intelligence reports. Completed highly critical and timely assessments enabling assigned organization to successfully complete client specific missions in a dynamic, fast-paced environment. Strong leadership qualities with excellent interpersonal and communication skills. Proactively convey operational needs to executive-level management. Seeking position utilizing my professional, technical and leadership skills.

Skills

Analysis & Operations: Skilled in data collection, project research, critical thinking, problem-solving, and project management to support intelligence-driven decision-making.

Leadership & Communication: Experienced in organizational leadership, inter-agency coordination, briefing skills, collaboration, adaptability, and effective communication, with a Top Secret Security Clearance.

Professional Experience

Strategic Intelligence Operations Manager July 20XX – Present

Tower Barracks, Germany

- Prepare detailed multi-source analytical reports derived from data collection, analysis, evaluation, and interpretation for use in the refinement of strategic posture.
- Conduct daily risk-analysis briefings for executive and senior leadership, providing actionable objectives and contingency recommendations.
- Supervise a multi-functional team of 35 intelligence professionals who update extensive intelligence databases, systems, and mechanisms for sharing relevant information to support ongoing and planned projects.
- Lead technical development and strategic implementation of various new initiatives, regulations, and policies.
- Advise executive management on training development principles to assess, refine and implement initiatives based on priorities and effectiveness of dispersed operations.

Lead Instruction Supervisor Feb 20XX – July 20XX

Schofield Barracks, HI

- Facilitated readiness of intelligence professionals by providing required accreditation and technical certification to enhance mission command proficiency with strict adherence to training regulations, guidelines, and policies.
- Provided a venue to collectively certify military intelligence professionals and units (team and higher) in full support of commanders executing assigned, allocated, apportioned, or distributed missions.
- Facilitated the relocation and subsequent distribution of $3 million in equipment across three sites with no losses or degradation. Supervised the collection and maintenance of training records and student progress to provide organizations detailed assessments of competency and aptitude at the conclusion of training or upon an ad-hoc request.

Intelligence Analyst Jan 20XX – Feb 20XX

Fort Bragg, NC

- Temporarily assigned to a complex and hazardous region in support of transnational objectives, providing direct analytical support at the organizational level.
- Pursued and identified operations of Violent Extremist Organizations to deter, interdict, target and exploit network's vulnerabilities.
- Developed and implemented organization-wide information security program with focus on activities to preserve the availability, integrity, and confidentiality of organizational information resources in compliance with applicable security policies and standards.
- Maintained extensive intelligence databases and systems for sharing relevant intelligence and information to support ongoing and planned projects.

Education

- **Master of Science, Intelligence Operations** | Wilmington University, New Castle, DE
- **Bachelor of Science, Intelligence Studies** | Wilmington University, New Castle, DE

Jordan Trenton

(123) 456-7890 | JordanT@email.com | LinkedIn URL

HOSPITAL ADMINISTRATION | OPERATIONS MANAGER

Operations Manager with an Active Secret Security Clearance and 15+ years of experience leading diverse teams in a dynamic, rapidly evolving environment. Varied background including healthcare administration, practice management, operations management, process improvement, problem solving, and strategic planning. Employed comprehensive risk management to protect $2M+ worth of assets. Proficient in instruction, facilitation, coaching and mentoring leaders. Adept in face-to-face and remote communications. Completed a bachelor's degree in Healthcare Administration to support professional career.

Operations & Compliance: Skilled in regulatory compliance, resource allocation, information technology, and equipment management to ensure efficient hospital administration.

Leadership & Patient Care: Experienced in team building, labor relations, instructional design, and patient satisfaction, and bilingual in Spanish/English.

EXPERIENCE

United States Army | Various Locations

Operations Manager | Senior Manager | Fort Polk, LA **10/20XX – Present**

Deliver comprehensive reports to senior leadership and maintain liaison with junior leaders to conduct strategic planning and allocate resources.

- Maintain information flow between headquarters and organizational leadership which enables executive decision-making.
- Plan, coordinate, and facilitate military training and readiness for over 350 Soldiers.
- Develop Word documents, Excel spreadsheets, and PowerPoint presentations to facilitate organizational training.

Assistant Director of Pulmonary Services| Fort Leonard Wood, MO **07/20XX – 10/20XX**

Supervised a Pulmonary Department consisting of 13 military and civilian respiratory therapists in a 43-bed community hospital which provided inpatient and outpatient services. Managed over $550,000 worth of equipment.

- Assisted with orientation, training, and on-boarding of new employees. Maintained personnel files, training records, timecards, and performance evaluations.
- Initiated daily inspections, audits, and employee education that was integral to achieving facility accreditation during a Joint Commission Survey with zero high risk findings.
- Assessed and revised 46 Pulmonary SOPs, ensuring compliance with clinical guidelines and quality healthcare.
- Completed all responsibilities and duties in accordance with the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) to include proper handling of Protected Health Information.

Supervisor | Instructor | Trainer| Fort Sam Houston, TX **06/20XX – 06/20XX**

Served as a lead responsible for training initial entry recruits. Directly responsible for the health, welfare, physical fitness, discipline, and training of Army recruits.

- Trained and onboarded over 2,000 entry-level employees in basic Army protocols and military traditions.

- Designed a 6-week training program that assured 95% of new recruits passed graduation requirements.
- Assured proper safety training, record keeping, and regulatory compliance during training exercises which resulted in zero critical or catastrophic training accidents.
- Processed over 500 personnel actions to include leave requests, pay inquiries, and administrative actions in a timely manner.

Practice Manager | Instructor | Fort Sam Houston, TX **06/20XX – 06/20XX**

Managed a Pulmonary Specialty Practice with six Staff Pulmonologists, 10 Pulmonary Fellows, four Respiratory Therapists, three nurses, and four receptionists. Augmented the Army Respiratory Therapy Program as a Pulmonary Functions Instructor.

- Expanded services within the Pulmonary Practice to include an Ambulatory Sleep Clinic and Home Oxygen Certifications for Medicare/Medicaid.
- Conducted community outreach during Respiratory Care Week and World Asthma Day events. Provided patients with information on pulmonary diseases, treatments and therapies, and smoking cessation.
- Maintained personnel files, training records, timecards, and performance evaluations for over 20 employees.
- Maintained files/forms via electronic systems/paper files and data integrity.
- Managed the security and proper maintenance of over $2.2 million in medical equipment.
- Trained over 90 Respiratory Therapy Students in Pulmonary Functions Testing, Bronchoscopies, EKGs, and Exercise Stress Tests.
- Completed and complied with all required HIPAA and other training and refresher courses on a timely basis.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science in Healthcare Administration
Southern New Hampshire University, Manchester, NH

SPECIALIZED MILITARY TRAINING

Senior Leader Course | Instructor Training Course | Equal Opportunity Leader Course

Master Resiliency Trainer Course | Basic Healthcare Administration Course

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Enterprise Applications: Electronic Health Records

Software: Microsoft Office 365, Adobe Acrobat

Chronological Resume

Riley Finley

(504) 239-6597 | RileyFinley@gmail.com | www.linkedin.com/in/riley

Program Manager with 5-year track record of driving results:

- Successfully planned and executed the aviation communication plan for 37 multimillion dollar operations while leading a 25-person business unit, exceeding all Objectives and Key Results (OKR) set by senior leadership.
- Ensured successful communication and collaboration between three government agencies comprised of over 260 personnel with 37 distinct job functions.
- Tracked the maintenance and utilization of over $25MM of equipment in support of operations development and training support.

SKILLS

Technology: CRM software (TBMCS, AC2S), MS Office, MS Project, Agile/Scrum

Leadership & Operations: Active Secret Clearance, teamwork, process improvement

WORK EXPERIENCE

United States Marine Corps May 20XX - Present

Program Manager: Twentynine Palms, CA June 20XX - Present

Led a five-person project team, overseeing the effective operations of 156 personnel during a multimillion-dollar exercise.

- Trained and developed 5 project managers in the safe and effective execution of command and control operations, resulting in the development of innovative concepts and a top-ranked team.
- Ensured all the administrative and logistical functions, including human resources, maintenance support, cross-country flights, and life support sustainment, were taken care of for all personnel.
- Managed the outward and inner command and control for 8 business units, resulting in effective communication and training for 16,000 military personnel.

Project Manager: Yuma, AZ June 20XX - May 20XX

Led a 74-person team with 6 direct reports achieving noteworthy remarks on a biennial training assessment of the unit.

- Led the safe and effective execution of an aviation command and control agency and its long-range extensions spread over 8 locations, meeting or exceeding all OKRs and increasing unit proficiency metrics.
- Oversaw the safe execution of 12,496 miles of convoy operations, without a single incident.
- Managed the data, radio, and other network communications pathways, enabling the seamless collaboration between 3 business units and the execution of aviation command and control.

Project Manager: Havelock, NC June 20XX - May 20XX

Managed 120-person team with 15 direct reports achieving 100% completion of training metrics.

- Supervised the risk-management, tasking, and training of the business unit, resulting in 2 successful annual administrative and maintenance inspections and 21 operations, exercises, and events.
- Mentored 10+ junior leaders in their decision-making and preparation for operations, resulting in the successful completion of training, exercises, and deployments.
- Facilitated the day-to-day operations of the unit by producing operational correspondence, presentations, and deliverables.

Project Manager: Okinawa, Japan June 20XX - May 20XX

Managed a 30-person team responsible for command and control of Marine Corps Aviation.

- Led a team of 30 specialized Marines, responsible for Marine Corps aviation command and control in the Indo-Pacific region, ensuring productive training, assessment, and workforce management for the team.
- Oversaw the timely and effective planning and support to 5 multimillion-dollar exercises, ensuring all OKRs were met.
- Ensured the safe execution of operational risk measures during all training for the team.

EDUCATION

- **Bachelor of Science**, United States Naval Academy, Annapolis, MD
- Graduated with Merit. Coursework included a heavy focus on STEM, Leadership, and English, with additional classes on History and Chinese.

Angel King

(504) 239-9999 | AngelKing@gmail.com | www.linkedin.com/in/angel

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

U.S. Navy veteran with over 9 years of experience in administrative support and 3 years as an events and logistics coordinator. Experience working with vendors, customers, and team members to meet tight schedule demands. Full event life-cycle experience including planning, set-up, execution, clean-up, and after-action review. Ability to continuously prioritize and administer multiple projects and activities through development, planning, and execution process.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

United States NAVY – various locations April 20XX - Present

Religious Program Specialist

Event and Logistics Coordinator | Dec. 20XX - Present

Manage every aspect of each event, including administrative details, responding to inquiries, and marketing events through print, digital, and social media strategies.

- Establish procedures for various types of events (10-200 participants) and collaborate with staff in other departments to ensure events run smoothly.
- Oversee and motivate a team of 10 staff members to achieve optimal productivity and efficiency.
- Coordinate simultaneous events with effective organizational, multitasking, and prioritization skills.
- Use sound judgment to respond to and handle customer issues and complaints as fast and efficiently as possible.
- Continually improve customer satisfaction by integrating feedback and reviewing at departmental meetings.
- Greet customers and make presence known at all times throughout the event process (pre-event, event, post-event).

Travel Coordinator | Jun. 20XX - Dec. 20XX

- Arranged and booked best available travel for individual associates and groups, including flights, trains, hotels, and rental cars.
- Negotiated military rates with local and national hotels saving organization >$10,000 annually.
- Coordinated with multiple departments to ensure efficient operations and workflows.
- Provided on-call assistance to co-workers during nights and weekends for any travel emergencies.

Religious Support Office Administrator | Sep. 20XX - Jun. 20XX

- Coordinated day-to-day scheduling and booking of meeting rooms and conference facilities ensuring 100% availability to customers.
- Prepared and maintained required forms, records, correspondence, reports, and files.
- Implemented streamlined organization methods to maximize productivity.
- Coordinated ground transportation provided by in-house drivers.

Work Center Supervisor | Apr. 20XX - Sep. 20XX

- Assisted in administering payroll to 3 civilian employees via Wide Area Workflow.
- Supervised and oversaw 3 separate departments to make certain the highest level of service was provided.

EDUCATION

- High School Diploma - Marlboro Central High School, Marlboro, NY

CERTIFICATIONS

- Administrative Services Manager, (USMAP), 20XX
- Lean Six Sigma Yellow Belt, (DOL Coach), 20XX

Chronological Resume

Morgan Reeves

(555) 789-6543 • Morganr@somedomain.com • LinkedIn URL

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

U.S. Navy Veteran and physical security services manager with over 10 years of experience managing over 100 armed security personnel and providing protective and emergency response services. Expertise in anti-terrorism and force protection readiness and training for global operations. Experience ensuring all law enforcement professionals exceed performance requirements. Experience managing the completion of day-to-day work activities and compliance of large security services team.

SKILLS

Security Operations & Planning: Asset management planning, Risk mitigation, Emergency response training, Emergency evacuation planning, Project management

Technical & Communication Skills: Technical writing, Building teams, Fluent in Spanish, Training Instructor, Active security clearance

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

United States Navy – various locations — Jan 20XX - Present

Program Manager — Aug 20XX - Present

Lead, coordinate, or provide subject matter expertise to complex projects for military emergency management and homeland security, including assessments, plans, training, exercises, and evaluations.

- Lead a team of 6 instructors in providing classroom and hands-on training for all aspects of security and law enforcement professionals' training requirements.
- Manage timely completion of all qualification activities, exceeding standards by 10%.
- Provide continuous assessment and evaluation of personnel to ensure compliance and initiate corrective action as needed.
- Prepare and maintain safety compliance reports.
- Communicate and coordinate with executive managers in a fast-paced environment in order to safeguard personnel and material resources.

Security Training Manager — Jan 20XX - Aug 20XX

- Analyzed and evaluated security operations to identify risks or opportunities for improvement through auditing, review, and assessment.
- Designed and delivered training courses for over 100 senior-level security managers.
- Standardized and updated security training modules based on operational requirements and policy updates.
- Built internal capacity of team through direct and indirect management and coaching, delegation of tasks, identification of project teams, delivery of feedback, and regular mentorship and coaching of direct reports and peers.

Security Team Supervisor Jul 20XX - Jan 20XX

- Maintained detailed documentation and logged inspections and incident reports.
- Identified security concerns through regular facility and equipment inspections.
- Devised and practiced contingency plans for diverse emergencies and disturbances.
- Directed ethical, consistent security operations covering personnel, visitors and assets.
- Identified and fulfilled staffing needs to maintain peak personnel readiness.

EDUCATION

Master of Arts in Homeland Security

American Military University, Charlestown, West Virginia

Bachelor of Arts in History

University of Maryland Global Campus, College Park, Maryland

CERTIFICATIONS

- Certified Emergency Manager (CEM) – Emergency Management Institute (FEMA) –Sep 20XX

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

- Leadership and Influence – Emergency Management Institute (FEMA) – Sep 20XX
- Decision Making and Problem Solving – Emergency Management Institute (FEMA) – Sep 20XX
- Effective Communication – Emergency Management Institute (FEMA) – Sep 20XX
- Social Media in Emergency Management – Emergency Management Institute (FEMA) – Sep 20XX
- Emergency Planning – Emergency Management Institute (FEMA) – Sep 20XX
- Master Training Specialist – Naval Education & Training (US Navy) – Oct 20XX
- Anti-Terrorism Training Supervisor – Center for Security Forces (US Navy) – Sep 20XX
- Interservice Non-Lethal Individual Weapons Instructor Course – (USMC) – Jul 20XX

Federal Resume Example

JOSEPH WRIGHT

1000 Pacific Street Oceanside, CA 92055 | (760) 777-7777 | josephwright@gmail.com
Security Clearance: Secret

Operations Manager | Training & Development Leader | U.S. Marine Corps Officer

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Results-driven Marine Corps officer with 7+ years of experience leading teams, managing operations, and executing complex missions across the Indo-Pacific, Middle East, and Africa. Skilled in personnel management, training development, logistics, and risk management. Proven ability to coordinate across agencies, oversee multimillion-dollar assets, and deliver results in high-pressure environments.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Leadership & Mentorship: Team Leadership, Coaching & Development, Personnel Management

Operational Excellence: Mission Planning, Resource Allocation, Multimillion-Dollar Asset Oversight

Training & Development: Instructional Design, Curriculum Delivery, Performance Enhancement

Strategic & Critical Thinking: Operational Analysis, Decision-Making, Risk Mitigation

Communication: Briefings & Reports, Stakeholder Engagement, Cross-Agency Coordination

Risk & Resource Management: Safety Compliance, Accountability Systems, Efficient Logistics

Integrity & Professionalism: Ethical Leadership, Standards Enforcement, Mission Commitment

RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

United States Marine Corps – Camp Pendleton, CA

Weapons Platoon Commander (Personnel & Operations Manager) **Mar 20XX – Present**

50–80 hrs/wk | $XX,XXX annually

- Led, trained, and mentored 45 Marines and Sailors; directed weapons employment and joint mission planning.
- Managed $250K in serialized weapons and gear, ensuring accountability across deployments.
- Directed shipboard external security operations aboard USS Somerset during multiple international strait transits, maintaining continuous freedom of navigation in high-risk waters.
- Coordinated 30+ training plans and live-fire exercises.
- Served as Officer in Charge of external ship security during an 8-month deployment, ensuring freedom of navigation.
- Directed the integration of intelligence and fire support updates into company operations, applying sound judgment under pressure to guide tactical decisions.

KEY ACCOMPLISHMENTS

- Directed platoon operations supporting U.S. Border Patrol, resulting in ~400 apprehensions across 600 square miles.
- Created and executed security plan in Somalia safeguarding 150+ U.S. personnel during exfiltration.
- Planned and executed a 14-day training cycle in Saudi Arabia that incorporated three progressive live-fire ranges, strengthening platoon proficiency and overall battalion readiness.

Company Executive Officer (Deputy Director & Assistant Manager) Jun 20XX – Sept 20XX

50–80 hrs/wk | $XX,XXX annually

- Directed and coordinated daily operations and training for 170 personnel, ensuring readiness across logistics, communication, and administration.
- Led and developed a team of 14 subject-matter experts in trauma care, communications, intelligence, and vehicle operations, elevating mission readiness and operational effectiveness.
- Managed accountability and redeployment of $10 million in equipment and assets.

KEY ACCOMPLISHMENTS

- Designed and executed a 10-day cold-weather training plan during Exercise Northern Edge 21 in Alaska.
- Oversaw and empowered 26 Marines and authored performance evaluations, directly influencing career progression.
- Coordinated redeployment logistics for 170 personnel and $10 million in assets across five ship-to-shore movements.

Combined Anti-Armor Platoon Commander (Operations Manager) Jan 20XX – Jun 20XX

50–80 hrs/wk | $XX,XXX annually

- Led 55 personnel and managed $7.5 million in vehicles, weapons, and optics.
- Conducted training and readiness exercises for deployment with the 31st MEU.
- Coordinated with allied forces for bilateral training events.

KEY ACCOMPLISHMENTS

- Planned and executed joint training with Royal Thai Marines during Cobra Gold 2019, increasing interoperability.
- Directed independent platoon operations in Guam during Exercise Dragon's Back.
- Oversaw 20+ live-fire ranges, enhancing combat proficiency and readiness.

University of Mary Washington (Fitness Center Staff) Sep 20XX – May 20XX

Fredericksburg, VA

KEY ACCOMPLISHMENTS

- Assisted in developing and executing 15 intramural sports competitions.
- Selected as one of two staff trusted to close the facility independently.

Costco Wholesale (Team Member) Oct 20XX – Nov 20XX

Richmond, VA

KEY ACCOMPLISHMENTS

- Trained and onboarded 10 new employees, improving team productivity.
- Consistently recognized for strong customer service in high-volume environment.

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

Bachelor of Arts (in progress) University of Mary Washington, Fredericksburg, VA

Risk Management & Safety Certification (DoD)
Marine Corps Officer Leadership Training (multiple levels)
Operational Security (OPSEC) Training

Curriculum Vitae Example

DAVID CUMMINGS, M.D.

631-340-5035 | david.cummings@email.com

Certification and Licensure

- Massachusetts Medical License (expires 12/31/20XX); Washington, D.C. Medical License (expires 12/31/20XX)
- Board Certified in Internal Medicine by the American Board of Internal Medicine, through 20XX
- Board Certified in Cardiology by the American Board of Internal Medicine, through 20XX

Employment History

August 20XX –Present Clinical Instructor of Medicine, Uniformed Services University of the Health Sciences, Bethesda, MD

June 20XX –Present Attending Cardiologist, Walter Reed National Medical Center, Bethesda, MD

July 20XX –June 20XX Attending Cardiologist, US Army Landstuhl Regional Medical Center, Germany

Education and Post-Graduate Training

20XX-20XX Walter Reed National Medical Center (WRNMC) Bethesda, MD
Cardiology Fellowship

20XX-20XX Walter Reed Army Medical Center (WRAMC) Washington, D.C.
Internal Medicine Internship and Residency

20XX-20XX Doctor of Medicine, Harvard Medical School Boston, MA

20XX-20XX Bachelor of Science, Biochemistry, University of Chicago Chicago, IL

Military Training

- Combat Casualty Care Course, San Antonio, Texas
- WRAMC Digital Cardiac Imaging (DCI) Research Course, Washington, D.C.
- Army Medical Department (AMEDD) Officer Basic Course, San Antonio, Texas

Professional Societies, Committee Memberships, and Academic Appointments

- Clinical Instructor, Uniformed Services University of the Health Sciences, Bethesda, MD
- Appointed Physician-in-Training Representative, American College of Physicians-American Society of Internal Medicine (ACP-ASIM) Medical Services Committee
- Elected Armed Forces Representative, American College of Physicians-American Society of Internal Medicine (ACP-ASIM) Council of Associates
- Appointed Representative, WRNMC Ethics Committee
- Elected Governing Council Member (Harvard Medical School class of 20XX representative to the Massachusetts Medical Society)
- Membership in the following: American Medical Association, Massachusetts Medical Society, ACP-ASIM, and American College of Cardiology

Publications

Lee, J.C., Atwood, J.E., Lee, H.J., **Cummings, D.**, Devine, P.J., Taylor, A.J. Association of Pulsus Paradoxus with Obesity in Normal Volunteers. *Journal of the American College of Cardiology* 2021;47(9):1907-9.

Isenbarger, D.W., Atwood, J.E., Scott, P.T., Bateson, T., Coyle, L.C., Gillespie, D.L., Pearse, L.A., Villines, T.C., **Cummings, D.**, Venous Thromboembolism Among United States Soldiers Deployed to Southwest Asia. *Thrombosis Research* 2020;379-383.

Cummings, D., Atwood, J.E. Apical Hypertrophic Cardiomyopathy with Giant Negative T-waves. *Mayo Clinic Proceedings* 2018; 80(9):1245.

Cummings, D., Atwood, J.E., Engler, R.M., Linz, P.E., Eckart, R.E., Vernalis, M.N., Grabenstein, J.D. Reply to letter to the editor: Cautious Interpretation of Data Regarding Myopericarditis Associated with Smallpox Vaccination. *Journal of the American College of Cardiology* 2016;45(1): 160-161.

Eckart, R.E., Love, S.S., Atwood, J.E., Arness, M.K., **Cummings, D.**, Campbell, C.L., Boyd, S.Y., Murphy, J.G., Swerdlow, D.L., Collins, L.C., Riddle, J.R., Tornberg, D.N. Incidence and Follow-up of Inflammatory Cardiac Complications after Smallpox Vaccination. *Journal of the American College of Cardiology* 2015;44(1):201- 205.

Cummings, D., Atwood, J.E., Engler, R.M., Linz, P.E., Grabenstein, J.D. Smallpox Vaccination and Myopericarditis. *Journal of the American College of Cardiology* 2013;43(9):1503-1510.

Cummings, D., Argyros, G. A 55-year-old Mechanically Ventilated Male Requiring Aeromedical Evacuation. *Military Medicine* 2012;167(7):606-9.

Cummings, D. So Many Worlds. *Harvard Medical Alumni Bulletin* 2010;73(2):20-21.

Selected Abstracts and Presentations

Cummings, D. Presented two one-hour review lectures to the primary care track, one on Hypertension and one on Hyperlipidemia (reviews of current guidelines) at the Medical-Surgical Conference in Willingen, Germany, from 23- 27 April 2020.

Lee, J.C., Lee, H.J., **Cummings, D.**, Taylor, A.J., Atwood, E. Pulsus Paradoxus in Obesity. Poster presentation at 2017 American College of Cardiology national meeting. Abstract published in: *Journal of the American College of Cardiology* 2017;45(3, supplement A): 142A.

Javaheri, S.P., Shry, E., Eckart, R., **Cummings D.**, Atwood, J.E., Grabenstein, J.D. Assessment of Vaccinia-associated Myopericarditis with Cardiac Magnetic Resonance Imaging. Poster presentation at 2019 American College of Cardiology national meeting. Abstract published in: *Journal of American College of Cardiology* 2019;45(3, supplement A):142A.

Cummings, D., Wiley, T. A. Heart-shocking Gut-wrenching Complication. Poster presentation at annual Army ACP meeting, Crystal City, Virginia, November 2021.

Cummings, D. Breaking study from the Journal of the American College of Cardiology: Smallpox Vaccination and Myopericarditis: A clinical review. Oral presentation at American Medical Association media briefing, New York, May 13, 2022.

Eckart, R.E., **Cummings, D.**, Atwood, J.E., Love, S.S., Campbell. C.L., Scott. W. Pattern of Cardiac Isoenzyme Elevation in Probable Smallpox Associated Myocarditis. Oral presentation at annual American College of Cardiology conference, March 2018.

Cummings, D., Gentlesk, P., Atwood, J.E. Apical Hypertrophic Cardiomyopathy with Giant T-wave Inversions: A Case Presentation. Poster presentation at annual Army ACP meeting, Fall 2018.

Cummings, D. A 39-Year-Old Woman with Severe Headache and Meningismus. Poster presentation at annual Army ACP meeting, Fall 2021.

Cummings, D., Fitzpatrick, T.M: Unexplained Post-Bronchoscopy Hypoxemia in an 18-Year-Old Asthmatic. Poster presentation at regional ACP meeting, Spring 2020.

Military Related Awards

- Army Commendation Medal, for performance while deployed in Iraq
- Army Commendation Medal, for performance as a fellow at WRNMC
- Army Commendation Medal, for performance as a resident at WRAMC
- Army Achievement Medal, for research activities at WRAMC
- Army Achievement Medal, for performance during JRTC in Ft. Polk, LA
- Army Achievement Medal, for performance during a hospital power crisis
- Army Achievement Medal, for research presented at regional ACP-ASIM conference

APPENDIX F: JOB OFFER EVALUATION CHECKLIST

Use the following checklist to evaluate various aspects of a company's job offer.

JOB OFFER EVALUATION CHECKLIST		
Industry	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Interest in the industry Do I want to build a career in this field?	○	○
Potential for long-term growth Is this a growing industry?	○	○
Job Position	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Work duties Do the duties of the job interest me and use my skills?	○	○
Potential for advancement What opportunities are available?	○	○
Position level Where is the job in the organization? To whom do I report?	○	○
Wages/benefits Do they meet my needs?	○	○
Hours Do I consider them reasonable?	○	○
Company	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Growth potential How has the company performed over the last five years?	○	○
Planned expansion What plans exist, and how do they fit with the economy?	○	○
Success What are the company's debt/profit ratios and other indicators of success?	○	○
Reputation What is the company's reputation in the industry and with its employees?	○	○
Management team What is the tenure, growth, and origin of the management team?	○	○
Paid Time Off (PTO)	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Paid vacations Am I eligible? How many days do I receive? How many days after a year of employment? After five years of employment?	○	○
Paid sick time Is sick time provided? Is carry-over of unused days permitted?	○	○

Schedule/ Work	Acceptable	Unacceptable
Working conditions What are the company's expectations and work style?	○	○
Work schedule Does the job allow for flexible work schedules?	○	○
Job quality How long has the position been open, and why is it open?	○	○
Travel requirements How often would I have to travel?	○	○
Remote work Does the company have a main or primary location? Does it have branch locations? Are any closer to your location? Can you work remotely?	○	○
Environment	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Geographic location Is the job someplace I would like to live?	○	○
Area factors Am I comfortable with the traffic, growth, cost of living, crime rate, etc.?	○	○
Housing Is affordable housing available and to my liking?	○	○
Recreation Are recreational opportunities available and within reason?	○	○
Schools Are good schools available for my children, spouse, and self?	○	○
Insurance	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Medical and dental Do I receive medical benefits fully or partially paid by the employer? Is dependent coverage fully or partially paid by the employer? Does coverage include vision care or dental care?	○	○
Paid life insurance What is the employer-paid life insurance coverage? How many times the annual salary is offered (earnings-based coverage) or is at least $15,000 (flat dollar-amount coverage) offered?	○	○
Profit-Sharing	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Does the company offer saving/thrift plans, cash profit-sharing, or deferred profit-sharing?	○	○
Retirement Plans	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
Is a pension plan (defined benefit) provided? Does the company offer 401K, 403B, or other tax-deferred retirement savings plans? Does the company offer association, professional, or union plans, or mutual fund retirement plans?	○	○

Other Benefits	Acceptable	Unacceptable
Do I get full or partial relocation allowance?	○	○
Do I get full or partial reimbursement for educational expenses?	○	○
Does the company offer financial or legal counseling plans?	○	○
Does the company offer childcare?	○	○
Does the company offer long-term incentive plans (stock options or other types of performance award)?	○	○
Does the company offer cars or transportation allowance provided for executives, salespeople, or managers who must travel?	○	○
Additional benefits not listed in checklist	**Acceptable**	**Unacceptable**
	○	○
	○	○
	○	○
	○	○
	○	○
	○	○

DEPARTMENT OF LABOR EMPLOYMENT COURSES FOR TRANSITIONING SERVICE MEMBERS, SPOUSES, VETERANS AND CAREGIVERS

TRANSITION ASSISTANCE PROGRAM (TAP)

TAP is a congressionally-mandated DOW program for all transitioning, separating, and retiring military service members. TAP offers live classroom and virtual courses, as well as resources related to benefits and employment. For more information, visit your local military installation or visit the DOL VETS TAP Website. (www.dol.gov/agencies/vets/programs/tap)

TRANSITION ONLINE LEARNING (TOL)

For online TAP courses, visit Transition Online Learning (TOL). (www.TAPevents.mil/courses). From the TAP Curriculum drop-down menu near the middle of the page, choose All Courses to view options of TAP Core Requirements and Transition Tracks. Select a desired course and follow instructions for registering. Q&A Sessions are available for all eLearning participants of DOL TAP workshops, offering open office hours to answer questions on any portion of the eLearning content.

WOUNDED WARRIOR AND CAREGIVER EMPLOYMENT WORKSHOP (WWCEW)

For wounded, ill, or injured transitioning service members (or those in the IDES process), WWCEW offers an alternative to fulfill their DOL one-day EFCT requirement. WWCEW is a self-paced eLearning training that is fully accessible and 508 compliant. It introduces essential tools to help participants find success in their job search. Q&A Sessions are available for all WWCEW participants. WWCEW is available at Transition Online Learning (TOL). (www.TAPevents.mil/courses)

EMPLOYMENT NAVIGATOR AND PARTNERSHIP PROGRAM (ENPP)

ENPP offers one-on-one career assistance to transitioning service members and their spouses at select military installations worldwide. Provided outside of the formal DOL TAP classroom instruction, Employment Navigators assist in securing meaningful and lasting post-separation careers. Learn more at DOL VETS ENPP website. (www.dol.gov/employmentnavigator)

TRANSITION EMPLOYMENT ASSISTANCE FOR MILITARY SPOUSES AND CAREGIVERS (TEAMS)

TEAMS is a series of employment-training workshops that help military spouses and caregivers find success in their job search. These workshops are delivered by trained facilitators across a wide range of times to provide ample flexibility for participants stationed worldwide. Workshops are offered on-installation and instructor-led virtually. More information and course descriptions are available on the DOL VETS TEAMS website. (www.dol.gov/TEAMSworkshops)

Transition Assistance Participant Assessment (TAPA)

YOUR FEEDBACK IS IMPORTANT

The ***Transition Assistance Participant Assessment (TAPA)*** is a critical evaluation tool used to gain feedback on TAP, facilities, facilitators, curriculum, and materials. Feedback is reviewed quarterly and used to make improvements to TAP. Participant feedback is essential to ensure a quality program.

Assessments are available for the following:

Core Curriculum

- Managing Your Transition
- MOC Crosswalk
- Financial Planning for Transition
- VA Benefits and Services
- Employment Fundamentals of Career Transition

2-Day Tracks

- **Employment:** DOL Employment Workshop
- **Education:** DoW Managing Your Education
- **Vocational:** DOL Career and Credential Exploration
- **Entrepreneurship:** SBA Boots to Business

Examples of curriculum updates made based on Service member feedback include:

- Created a comprehensive resource guide that lists all TAP-related websites in one document.
- Removed unnecessary or obsolete information.
- Added information related to finding purpose, healthcare, and life insurance after transition.
- Added more hands-on activities and enhanced content on American Job Center resources, social media, and resume examples.

The TAPA is Located at: https://www.dodsurveys.mil/tap

or

Scan the QR Code below with the camera on your personal device to begin the assessment.

Please Note:

- An assessment should be completed at the end of each course.
- Participation in the assessments is anonymous. You will be asked to re-enter your background information for each assessment (such as component and time until separation).